

WHILE YOU LIVE · BOOK 1

Sic Semper

Andrew F. Young



Version 2 · October 1, 2026

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The Offer

The electric bill was on top because it was the only one printed in red.

I moved it to the bottom of the pile, which changed nothing, and then moved it back, which changed less. Through the wall I could hear Freda on the phone, laughing the low, careful laugh she saved for friends. She was sixteen. A good kid, everyone said so, and I believed it. But lately there was a door in my daughter that stayed shut, and I had not yet found out what was behind it.

Dinner was done and the dishes put away. Tomorrow's lunches were already in the fridge, and the permission slip for Friday was signed and clipped to Freda's bag. On the laptop, tonight's job sat open: four hundred words on why a family should choose one brand of gutter guard over another.

These days I wrote whatever people paid me to write. The gutter company paid sixty dollars a piece and paid on time, which put it ahead of most. There was also a dentist who wanted a blog, a retired man writing a memoir about forty years in the carpet business, and a real estate office that sent me photos of houses and asked me to make them sound bigger. I did all of it well and on time. It paid most of the bills. None of it would ever be read twice.

There had been a time when people quoted me. Not often, and not on television, but in rooms that mattered, by people who had read the whole piece. I had been the reporter who went and checked the thing everyone else took for granted. As far as I had ever understood it, that was the whole job: find out whether it was true.

Then there had been the auction house story.

Six years ago, a man had called the newsroom and asked for me by name. He worked in the back rooms of Carrow House, the old auction house downtown, the one with the brass doors and the catalogs printed on heavy paper. His job was repairing old documents before they went to sale: flattening letters, mending torn deeds, rebinding diaries that had come apart at the spine. He said that some of the letters Carrow sold as genuine, signed by presidents and generals and famous names, were not genuine at all. He said he could prove it. He said he had been asked to *repair* some of them, and that the damage he had been asked to repair was new.

It had taken me eight months. I had met him in diners and parking lots and once, memorably, in a laundromat. I had checked everything he gave me, and everything he gave me had checked out. The story ran on a Sunday, on the front page, under my name.

On Monday, Carrow House sued.

On Wednesday, my source was gone. Not fired, not arrested, not quoted in a rival paper denying everything. Gone. His apartment was dark, his phone was off, and nobody who knew him would say where he had gone, if they knew. Without him, the documents he had given me were only documents. Carrow's lawyers said the documents were themselves fakes, made up to smear an honest business. The paper's lawyers called it a difficult position. By the end of the year the paper had printed a correction that took up more space than some of my stories had, and I had been let go with a handshake and a box.

Everyone in the business knew what that meant. It meant I had made it up.

That was six years ago. The envelope on the counter tonight had come that afternoon, addressed in type to Ms. Iola Barnett. I had left it unopened beside the fruit bowl, because nothing good arrived in paper that heavy. Heavy paper meant lawyers, and lawyers were how the last story had ended.

I opened it anyway, because the electric bill was red.

It was from a firm I had never heard of, Aldine, Mercer and Voss, with an address in a city I had never been to. The letter was typed, polite, and longer than I expected.

Dear Ms. Barnett,

We act for a private client who wishes to engage a writer to record the recollections of an elderly gentleman. The sessions would take place at the gentleman's home, at his convenience and yours. Our client will pay three thousand dollars per session, for no fewer than ten sessions, with travel costs covered in full. You would be free to decline at any point.

We should say plainly that the gentleman is not famous, and that his recollections will not, on their face, seem credible. Our client does not ask you to believe them. He asks you to listen carefully, to write down what you are told in the way it is told, to send us a typed copy after each session, and from time to time to put to the gentleman a question our client will send you. Whether any of it is ever published is a matter for you and the gentleman. Our client has no interest in it.

Our client has followed your work for some years, including your reporting on Carrow House, and he knows how that ended. He asks us to tell you that it is the reason he chose you. He needs someone who checks everything and accepts nothing until she has, and who knows what it costs to be right when no one believes you.

Lastly, our client asks us to add that he has always believed you about Bookbinder.

I read that line four times. Then I put the letter face down on the counter, the way you would put down a hot pan, and stood with my hand flat on top of it.

Nobody knew about Bookbinder.

That was not a figure of speech. It was the name I had given my source in my own notes, because of the work he did and because I never wrote a real name down where someone could find it. It was in my own handwriting, in a notebook that had never left my bag. It had not been in the paper. It had not been said to my editor, who had only ever called him *your guy*. It had not been said to the lawyers, who had called him *the alleged source* until the word *alleged* was all anyone remembered.

Two people on earth had known that name. One of them was me, standing in my own kitchen with my hand on a letter. The other one had been gone for six years.

"Is that from the lawyers?"

Freda was in the doorway, phone against her chest, the call not ended, only muffled. She had her father's height and none of his patience. Her eyes were already on the letter under my hand. She read everything that way, upside down and faster than she let on.

"Different lawyers," I said.

"Worse?"

"Richer."

Freda came in and took an apple from the bowl, though she never ate the apples. She did not ask to see the letter, which meant she wanted to. I turned it face up and slid it across. There was no point hiding it. My daughter had been reading over my shoulder since she was four.

Freda skimmed it the way you skim a menu when you already know what you're having, and then she stopped at the bottom.

Below the typed signature of someone named R. Aldine, in a different ink, there was one more line, written by hand. The writing was old-fashioned, the kind taught when handwriting was still a subject in school, and it leaned a little too far to the right. The downstrokes shook, very slightly, like a picture hung on a wall that trucks drove past.

Please ask him what he thinks of 1865.

"Somebody's grandpa wrote that," Freda said.

"Maybe it's the gentleman."

"No, the gentleman's the one you're interviewing. This is the one paying." Freda tapped the line with the apple. "What happened in 1865?"

"The Civil War ended. Lincoln was shot."

"So he's a history guy."

"Apparently."

"Weird thing to pay for." Freda read the figures again. From the phone against her chest, her friend's voice said something small and impatient. "Three thousand dollars. Each time."

"I can read."

"Ten times is thirty thousand dollars."

"I can also add."

Freda looked at me, and for one second she was not sixteen at all. She was the child who had sat on the stairs six years ago while I cried in the kitchen and pretended to be on the phone. She had never mentioned it. Neither had I.

“Are you going to go?” Freda said.

“I don’t know yet.”

“You’re going to go.” Freda lifted the phone back to her ear, said “Sorry, my mom,” into it, in the voice that meant *my mom* was a long and tragic story, and went back to her room. The door closed. It didn’t slam. I had learned to be grateful for the difference.

The gutter guards came first, because I had said I would do them, and because sixty dollars was sixty dollars. It took twenty minutes. Then I opened a new window and did what I had not done for six years. I started checking.

Aldine, Mercer and Voss was real. That was the first surprise. It was registered, it was old, and it had a website with a street address, a phone number, and almost nothing else: no photographs of smiling partners, no list of the kinds of cases it took, no news. The kind of firm, I thought, that did not need to find clients, because its clients already knew where it was. There was an R. Aldine on the state bar list, admitted forty-one years ago, with no complaints against him. There was nothing else about him at all, which was harder to arrange than people thought.

I searched for Carrow House, which I had not let myself do in a long time. It was still there. It had had a good year. There was a photograph of the brass doors.

Then I searched for my source’s real name, the one I never wrote down, and found what I had found every other time I had looked, back when I still looked: an old address, an old phone listing, and after that, nothing. No obituary. No new address. No arrest. A man who had simply stopped.

At midnight I closed the laptop and wrote on the back of the envelope, by hand, the way I used to plan a story:

Bookbinder.

Who else knew?

I underlined *who*. Then, under that, because I was honest with myself on paper even when I was not anywhere else:

Electric. Car insurance. Freda's teeth.

Thirty thousand dollars.

It felt like picking up an instrument I used to play and finding that my hands still knew where to go.

In the morning, after the school run, I called the number on the letterhead.

A woman answered on the second ring. She said that Mr. Aldine had been expecting to hear from me, which I did not like. She said that the gentleman lived about two hours north, which was fine. And she said the first session could be as soon as Thursday at ten, which was too soon, and which I heard myself agree to.

"Can you tell me who your client is?"

"I'm afraid our client prefers not to be named."

"Can you tell me who the gentleman is?"

"He'll tell you himself, I expect," the woman said. "I'll let him know it's Thursday at ten. He said to tell you he'll have the kettle on."

"Does he know why your client wants his story?"

A pause, and the soft click of a keyboard.

"I don't think anyone does, Ms. Barnett," the woman said. "That's rather the point of hiring you."

On Wednesday night, over dinner, I told Freda I was going. Freda said, "I told you," and then, after a moment, "Is it safe?" which was not a question I had expected, and which I answered with more confidence than I had.

"He's an old man who wants to tell somebody about his life," I said. "I've interviewed a hundred of them."

"And the one paying?"

"Also old, apparently."

"Old and rich and weird," Freda said. "Text me when you get there."

"I will."

"Text me when you leave."

"Who's the mother here?"

Freda almost smiled. Her phone buzzed on the table beside her plate. She glanced at it, typed a quick reply with one thumb, and asked for the salt.

On Thursday I dropped Freda at school, stopped for gas, and drove north with the letter on the passenger seat, face down. The city thinned into highway and the highway into two-lane road, past farm stands closed for the season and a church with a sign that said *God answers knee mail*. I had printed the directions, because I did not trust my phone out here, and because I was the kind of person who printed directions.

At every red light I rested my hand on the letter, as if it might get up and leave.

The Old Man

The house was at the end of a gravel road, past a mailbox with no name on it, and it was smaller than I had expected. White clapboard, a porch with a bench and two chairs, a vegetable garden gone to seed for the winter. Somebody had raked the leaves into a neat pile by the fence and then, apparently, lost interest in doing anything else with them.

I parked behind an old blue pickup truck and sat for a minute with the engine off.

I texted Freda, *Here. Nice old house. Normal.* When the reply came, *ok*, followed a moment later by *text when u leave*, I put the phone in my bag, picked up the folder with my printed directions and the letter in it, and got out.

He was down the porch steps before I had the car door shut, and he stood by the open door a moment while I gathered my things.

He was taller than I had pictured, and straighter. Somewhere in his seventies, with white hair cut short and a gray cardigan buttoned wrong by one button, so that one side hung lower than the other. His face was lined in the way of people who had spent a lot of time outdoors and not worried about it. His eyes were a pale, washed blue, and they went over me once, not rudely, the way a mechanic listens to an engine.

"Ms. Barnett," he said. "You found it. People usually drive past the mailbox."

"I nearly did."

"Everyone does. I keep meaning to paint my name on it, and then I don't." He led me up the steps and held the door for me. "Tom Hale. The kettle's on,

as promised. I hope you drink tea, because I'm afraid the coffee here is a crime."

Inside, the house was mostly books.

They were on shelves that went to the ceiling, and in stacks on the floor beside the shelves, and on the stairs, one to each step, like they were climbing up to bed. There were books in English and books in languages I didn't recognize, paperbacks with cracked spines and old leather volumes with the titles rubbed off. A woodstove ticked in the corner. There was a worn armchair by the window with a lamp beside it, a small table with a chess game half finished and nobody to finish it, and a second, newer armchair across from it that had plainly been bought for company and not used much.

"Sit, please," he said. "That one. It's the one that doesn't eat people."

I sat. He went into the kitchen, and I heard the tick of the kettle, the clink of cups, and the particular care of someone who lived alone and did things in the same order every day.

I looked around, because looking around was a habit I had never been able to break. A calendar from the feed store, still on last month. A pair of reading glasses on the windowsill and a second pair on the table, as if he had lost the first and given up. On the wall, one framed photograph: a woman laughing on a beach, the colors faded to orange, the kind of photo that had been taken on film. A heavy old radio. A bird feeder outside the window, freshly filled. On the mantel, among the clocks and candlesticks, a small wooden frame stood empty, its glass polished clean, as if it were waiting for something.

He came back with a tray. Two cups, a teapot in a knitted cover, a plate of shortbread that had come out of a tin.

"It must be nice," he said, setting the tray down, "to have a daughter who worries about you."

I looked at him. I had not said one word about Freda. I was sure of it. I went back over everything I had said since I got out of the car, which was not much, and none of it was Freda.

"I'm sorry?" I said. "What? How do you know I have a daughter?"

"You sat in your car with the engine off and sent a text before you got out," he said. "Then you waited for the answer. You'd rather keep a stranger waiting on his porch than skip it, so it mattered. Somebody asked you to let them know

you'd got here safely, and you promised. A husband would have called." He poured. "There's a hair tie around the gearshift, and your own hair is pinned up with clips, so it isn't yours. Somebody with long hair rides with you, often enough to leave it there. And it's a school day, and you were here at ten, from two hours away, so you left at eight, which is when schools open. You drove her there first. Then she asked you to text her when you arrived, because a stranger's letter had sent her mother two hours up a gravel road, and she didn't like it."

"You were watching from the window."

"I watched you from the window, and then I came out to meet you. I'm old. It's what we do." He smiled, and it changed his face completely, took ten years off it. "Also, you have printed directions in that folder. Most people trust their phones. People who print directions have usually been let down before, and don't intend to be let down again."

"That's a lot to get from a text and a hair tie."

"When you've lived as long as I have," he said, "you learn to notice the things other people think don't matter. I suspect you already know that."

I took out my phone and set it on the table between us, and beside it, because I had been burned before, a small digital recorder I had owned for eleven years.

"Two?" he said.

"One of them always dies."

"Which one?"

"Whichever one I trusted."

He laughed at that, a real laugh, and picked up the notepad and pencil from the arm of his chair and settled them on his knee. The top page was already covered in doodles, the kind people make on the phone or while they wait: the same shape, over and over, some gone over so many times that the pencil lead shone. I saw it the way you see a stranger's doodles on a train. A five-pointed star, each one drawn in one long line, with a tiny letter tucked into each point. Greek, I thought, or something like it. While I checked the levels and said the date and time into the phone, the way I always had, his pencil found one of the stars and began, without his looking down, to go over it again.

"Mr. Hale," I said.

“Tom.”

“Tom. Before we start, let me explain how I work. With your permission, I’ll record our conversations. Anything that can be verified, I’ll verify: names, dates, places. If something you tell me doesn’t match the record, I’ll tell you, and I’ll ask you about it. I’m not trying to catch you out. It’s how I make sure that what I write down is accurate.”

“I know,” he said. “It’s why I agreed.”

“The letter said your memories would not seem credible.”

“Did it say that?” He seemed pleased. “Then they were honest with you. They won’t. Ask me your client’s question, and you’ll see why.”

“My client sent a question,” I said. I opened the folder, found the letter, and read out the handwritten line at the bottom.

“Please ask him what he thinks of 1865.”

He didn’t answer at once. He looked at the window, where there was nothing to see but the raked leaves and the fence and the gray sky over the field. His hand had gone back to the notepad, and the pencil was moving again, slowly, over the same star.

“What I think of it,” he said.

“That’s what it says.”

“It’s a strange way to put it.” He was quiet a moment longer. “I remember that spring as mud. People forget that. They picture it all in sunshine because the war was ending, and the pictures in the books are all taken on bright days, because you needed a bright day to take a picture then. But I remember mud. The inauguration in March, the streets were a river of mud, you couldn’t cross Pennsylvania Avenue without losing a shoe. And it rained all morning, and then when he stood up to speak, the sun came out. Right then. Everyone saw it. People said it was a sign.”

“Lincoln,” I said.

“Lincoln.” He said the name carefully, as if it were something that might break. “I didn’t think it was a sign. I remember thinking that it was only weather. I was wrong about many things that spring. That was one of the smaller ones.”

I wrote *sun, inauguration, March 1865, check* in my notebook. It was the kind of detail anyone could find in a library. It proved nothing. I noted, too, that he had said it the way you describe something you saw from where you stood, and not the way you describe something you read. That also proved nothing. People who told stories well could do that. It was my job not to be impressed.

“You talk as if you were there,” I said.

“I was there.”

I looked at him. He could not have been much past seventy-five. The inauguration he was describing had happened a hundred and sixty years ago.

He put the pencil down.

“I have lived before,” he said. “Not in the way people mean on television, with past-life regression and a woman with a crystal. I mean that I have been other people, one after another, for a very long time, and I remember them. Not perfectly. The way you remember your childhood. Some of it very clearly, and some of it gone, and some of it I would rather have lost.”

The woodstove ticked. Outside, a truck went by on the far road, and the sound of it came and went.

In my time I had interviewed a man who believed he had been abducted by aliens, twice, and a woman who believed her late husband spoke to her through the microwave. I had interviewed a state senator who believed he had never taken a bribe. I had found, over the years, that the useful thing was not to argue. You let them tell it. People who were lying tripped over their own stories, if you gave them room. People who believed something strange usually told it the same way every time, which was its own kind of information.

So I only said, “How long is a very long time?”

“Longer than I would like you to write down today,” he said. “But you asked about 1865, and 1865 doesn’t begin in Washington. It begins the summer before. July of 1864.”

“What happened in July of 1864?”

He picked the pencil up again, and set it down on the notepad, on top of the star, and folded his hands.

“I woke up,” he said, “in a field outside Washington, in a body that wasn’t mine yet. It was the hottest day I had felt in a hundred years. And somebody was shooting at me.”

Fort Stevens

• RECORDING · JULY 1864

The first thing I knew was the heat.

Not warmth. Heat, the kind that sits on your chest like an animal. I was lying on my stomach in dry grass, and the ground under me was hot through my shirt, and the air smelled of dust and powder smoke and something sweet and rotten that I did not want to think about yet. Somewhere to my left, very close, a man was shouting a name over and over.

“Kit. Kit! You hit?”

There is a rule I keep for the first hour of a life, and it has kept me alive more than once. Say as little as you can. Move as little as you can. Watch everything. You do not yet know your own name, or your own voice, or who around you is a friend. Every word you speak is a chance to be wrong.

So I did not answer at once. I opened my eyes and looked at my hands.

They were young hands, brown from the sun, the knuckles scraped, with hard yellow calluses across the palms where a plow handle or an axe had worn them. Farm hands. There was a rifle under them, long and heavy, its wooden stock dark with sweat. The sleeves above them were a coarse gray-brown cloth, homespun, the color of dry dirt. There was a hole in one elbow that somebody had darned with the wrong color thread.

And there was something wrong with my left leg. It did not hurt yet. It only felt heavy and far away, as if it belonged to someone lying next to me. When I turned my head I saw that the gray-brown cloth above the knee was dark and wet, and getting darker.

“Kit!”

A hand grabbed my shoulder and rolled me half over. A face above me, sunburnt, a thin beard, missing a tooth on one side. Perhaps twenty years old. Frightened, and trying not to be.

“I’m all right,” I said.

My voice came out lower than I expected, and it came out soft and slow, rounding the words the way his did. The body knows its own accent, if you let it. It knows its own language, too. I have woken in bodies that spoke tongues I had never heard, and the words were in the mouth before they were in my head. You let the body say it, and the mind catches up. You only have to not get in its way.

“Thought you was dead,” he said. “You just dropped.” Then he saw the leg, and his face changed. “Oh, Kit. Oh, they got you.”

He pulled off his belt and tied it above the wound and hauled it tight, and that was when it started to hurt, all at once, worse than anything this body had ever felt. I did not cry out. I think the body was too surprised.

“The heat,” I said, which was true, in its way.

“Lord, the heat.” He dragged me by the collar back behind a rail fence that had been knocked half flat, and crawled to his own place a few yards along it. “Keep your head down. Them sharpshooters in the fort can see a cat blink.”

I kept my head down, and I looked.

We were in a line of men strung out along the fence and behind the trees and in the ditches of a road, all of us in the same dirt-colored cloth, all of us lying as flat as the ground would let us. Ahead, across a stretch of open fields and the stumps of trees that had been cut down on purpose, rose a long, low wall of earth with the dark mouths of cannon in it. Above it, limp in the windless air, a flag. Stars and stripes.

It was a fort. And we were the ones outside it.

The men around me were talking in the low, tired way of soldiers who have marched too far in too little time. I listened, and I learned. They said *Old Jube* and *the Valley* and *the Monocacy*, and they spoke about a fight two days back where they had driven off some Yankees at a river and lost good

men doing it. They said *Washington*, again and again, the way you say the name of something you can almost touch. One man said the city was right there, past that fort, and that if they could just get over that one wall they could walk down the avenue and take their dinner in the President's house.

Another man said that if they could just get over that one wall, they would all be dead, and that he had watched men in blue filing into that fort since noon, and they didn't march like clerks.

"That's just militia," the first man said. "Clerks and old men."

"Them ain't clerks," said the second man. "Them's the Sixth Corps. I seen their flags."

The first man opened his mouth to argue, and then shut it again. After that nobody said much of anything. A few of them looked back over their shoulders at the road we had come in on, the way men do when they are working out how far it is to somewhere safe.

So. It was summer, it was the war between the states, and I was on the side that had come to take the capital and was beginning to understand that it could not. I did not know the year for certain until that afternoon, when a boy down the line read aloud from a newspaper he had taken off a dead man, and the date at the top of it said July of 1864. I did not know my own full name until the next morning, when I found a letter in my jacket, folded small, in a mother's careful hand. There was no address on it anywhere. Letters from home came across the river with smugglers, and nobody wrote down an address that could hang a family. But it began *My dear Christopher*, and it talked about the tobacco and the creek and the swamp, and by the end of it I knew that I was a Maryland boy, and a long way from home.

I want you to understand something, because it matters for everything I am going to tell you. I did not know what would happen next. I am not a prophet. I have never once woken up knowing how a thing would end. I only ever know what I have lived, and I had never lived this.

We lay in that field for two days.

The heat did not break. Men fainted and were dragged back into the shade. Water came up in buckets from a spring and never lasted. Every so often the fort's big guns would fire, and the ground would jump under us, and

a house or a stand of trees somewhere out in front would come apart. Our own sharpshooters had climbed into the upper windows of the farmhouses in front of the fort and into the tops of the trees, and they fired at anyone on the wall who gave them a clean shot. The men on the wall did the same to us. You learned to keep your head down, and you learned it fast.

On the second afternoon, the twelfth, I saw him.

I had dragged myself forward, a yard at a time, on my elbows, with the leg trailing, to a place behind a stone wall where I could see the fort more clearly. I told the boy with the missing tooth that I wanted a better look at their guns. In truth I wanted to understand where I was, and who I was fighting, and whether we were going to die here. The smoke drifted and thinned, and for a moment the whole length of the parapet was clear in the white afternoon light.

There were officers on the wall, in blue, with swords and field glasses, crouched low the way sensible men crouch when there are rifles pointed at them. And among them, standing up straight, taller than all of them by a head and more, was a man who was not an officer at all.

He wore a long black coat, a civilian's coat, and a tall black hat that made him taller still. He was standing on the top of the wall with nothing in front of him but air, looking out over the fields toward us, as calmly as a farmer looking at weather.

I remember that I noticed three things about him, and I remember the order I noticed them in.

First, that he was not a soldier. His coat was wrong, and the way he stood was wrong. A soldier on a wall under fire makes himself small without thinking. This man had never learned to.

Second, that the officers around him were frightened, and not for themselves. They kept glancing at him and then at each other. One of them had a hand half raised, as if he wanted to take hold of the man's sleeve and did not dare.

Third, that they were not frightened of him. They were frightened *for* him. Whoever he was, they could not afford to lose him.

A rifle cracked from one of the trees ahead of me. On the wall, a man standing near the tall one, an officer in blue, jerked and folded and went down out of sight.

The others moved then. Hands took the tall man by the arms and the coat. Someone was shouting. I could not hear the words at that distance, only the sharpness of them. For one moment longer he stood there, as if he were deciding whether to be offended. Then he stepped down behind the earth, and the wall was only a wall again.

I pulled myself up on the stones to see where he had gone, and the leg screamed at me, and I did it anyway. It was a foolish thing to do, with the sharpshooters on that wall. I have done it, in one form or another, in more lives than I would like to tell you. I wanted to see. I always want to see.

There was nothing to see. Only the wall, and the smoke, and the flag hanging in the heat. I let myself down again behind the stones.

Toward evening the men in blue came out of the fort, the ones that were not clerks. They came across the fields in long lines, and our skirmishers fell back in front of them, and for an hour the air was nothing but noise. When it was quieter, an older man from our company crawled over with a knife and cut the trouser away from the wound, and poured water from his canteen through it, front and back, and packed both holes with lint from his pocket and bound them tight with a strip torn off his own shirt. He knew what he was doing. He had done it before. I screamed when he pulled the binding tight, and I heard my own voice and did not recognize it.

It was full dark before anyone came back for me. By then the word was going down the line, man to man, in low voices: we were pulling out. No fires. No talking. Leave whatever you can't carry. I lay there with the belt biting into my leg and listened to men I did not know yet getting ready to leave me.

I heard it go. You can hear an army leave, even a quiet one: the wagons, the horses, the long shuffle of feet on a dry road, the voices telling each other to hush. Old Jube was going back the way he had come, back to the Potomac and over it into Virginia, and he was taking everyone who could walk.

I could not walk.

The boy with the missing tooth came and knelt by me in the dark. He said he was sorry. He said they had orders. He said someone would come, that there were people in Maryland who were friends to us, that they would find me and see me right. He put a canteen in my hands, half full, and a piece of hard bread, and he pressed my shoulder once, and then he was gone with the others.

I lay behind the wall and listened to the army go, and to the crickets come back after it, and to the sound of my own breathing.

I thought about the tall man on the wall. I did not know yet who he was. I thought I could guess. I thought that I had been, for one afternoon, a few hundred yards from the most important man in this country, close enough to see the shape of his hat against the sky, and that I had been lying in a field with a rifle, on the side that wanted him gone.

It was a strange thought. It did not seem to mean anything yet.

Near morning, a shaded lantern came along the wall and stopped over me. A woman's voice behind it said, very low, "It's him. He's alive."



The recorder's small red light was still on. I realized I had not written anything in my notebook for some time.

Tom Hale was looking at the window again. The sky over the field had gone a flat, pale gray. On the notepad on his knee, his pencil had stopped moving.

"That was Lincoln," I said. "On the wall."

"Yes."

"You said you didn't know."

"I said I didn't know yet," he said. "I found out later, the way everyone did. From a newspaper." He smiled, but it was not the smile from before. "You'll want to check it."

"I'll check it."

"Good," he said. "Check the surgeon too. The man who fell beside him. He was a doctor from Pennsylvania. He lived, I think. I was always glad of that."

I wrote it down. *Surgeon. Pennsylvania. Check.*

Outside, a bird landed on the feeder, looked at the window, and flew away again.

Playback

I texted Freda from the end of the gravel road, *Leaving now*, and got back a thumbs up, which in my daughter's language meant *received, and please don't make it a conversation*.

The drive south was slower than the drive north. There was an accident on the highway, and then there was traffic from the accident, and then there was the long stretch of gray afternoon where I found myself driving with the radio off, which I never did, going back over what he had said.

I did not believe him. I wanted to be clear with myself about that.

I had spent six years being very careful about what I believed, because the last time I had believed someone, it had cost me everything I had. I believed in things I could check. So I did what I always did with a story that was too good. I separated it into parts.

The part I could check: Lincoln at Fort Stevens. A man shot beside him. A Confederate army that came to the edge of Washington in July 1864 and then went away.

The part I could not check: that an old man in a cardigan had been lying in a field with a rifle, a few hundred yards away, in somebody else's body.

The first part was history. The second part was either a lie, or a delusion, or something I did not have a word for. And it was not my job to decide which. My job was to write down what he said, check what could be checked, and cash the checks.

That was what I told myself for the first hour.

For the second hour, I thought about how he had said *I was always glad of that*.



The house was lit up when I parked out front, every window, the way Freda always left it when she was home alone.

Freda was at the kitchen table with her laptop and a stack of chemistry worksheets, a pencil behind one ear and another in her hand. She looked up when the door opened, and for a second her face did something that looked like relief, and then she seemed to remember she was sixteen, and put it away.

"You're late."

"There was an accident on the highway. Not me. Somebody else's."

"I know. I looked at the traffic." Freda turned a page. "So is he crazy?"

I hung up my coat. I put the folder on the counter and my bag on the chair and the two recorders side by side on the table, the way I had always set them out after an interview, like a surgeon laying out instruments.

"He's very nice," I said. "He made me tea. He has about ten thousand books."

"That's not a no."

"He says he's lived before."

Freda put her pencil down.

"Like a past life? Like he was Cleopatra?"

"Like a lot of them. He says he remembers them. He says he was a Confederate soldier at the end of the Civil War."

"That's why they want to know about 1865." Freda looked at me with real interest now, which happened so seldom these days that I felt it like sunlight. "That's so weird. Do you believe him?"

"No."

"Do you think he believes it?"

I thought about that. It was a better question than most editors had ever asked me.

"Yes," I said. "I think he does."

Freda considered this. Then she said, “Well, that’s kind of sad,” and went back to her chemistry. It was the longest conversation we had had in weeks, and Freda had started it. I turned and opened the refrigerator, so that my face would not give me away.

There were two mugs in the sink. Two plates, rinsed, with crumbs on them.

“Did you have someone over?”

“Maddie came by after school. She wanted to look at my lab.” Freda did not look up. “She left like an hour ago.”

“That’s fine. I was only asking.”

“I know you were only asking.”

I made myself a sandwich I did not want and ate it standing up, and let it go. I had learned that with Freda, the way you learned it with a nervous source: if you pushed, the door shut. If you waited, sometimes, it opened on its own.

It had not opened in a while.



At ten o’clock, clearing the table, I checked my bank balance, the way I did every night.

There was money in it that had not been there that morning. Three thousand dollars, from Aldine, Mercer and Voss, with the note *Session 1* and nothing else. It had come in at four o’clock that afternoon, a couple of hours after I left his house. People who hired writers paid in thirty days, if you were lucky, or sent a check that took a week to clear. This client had paid the same afternoon.

I read it three times. I had checked that balance every day for six years, and I knew to the dollar what it had said that morning.

I paid the electric bill. Then I sat at the kitchen table with the house quiet around me and Freda’s music faintly through the wall, and I put on my headphones and played the recording back from the beginning.

I always did this. It was one of the few habits from the old job I had never broken, even on the gutter guards. You heard things on the tape that you did not hear in the room. In the room you were busy: thinking of the next question, watching the face, making sure the red light was on. On the tape, you were only listening.

I heard my own voice, too bright, saying the date. I heard the woodstove, and the cups, and his laugh when I said *whichever one I trusted*. And all through the first part there was a small dry sound I had not noticed at the time, like a mouse in a wall: his pencil, going around and around on the notepad.

Then I heard myself read out the client's question.

"Please ask him what he thinks of 1865."

And then nothing.

I checked the time on the playback. Eleven seconds. Eleven seconds of the stove ticking and a truck going by on the far road, and, very faintly, the pencil, going around. In the room it had felt like a pause. On the tape it was a silence, the long kind, the kind people leave when a question has gone somewhere deeper than they expected.

"What I think of it," he said at last.

I listened to the whole thing. The rain and the mud. The sun coming out when Lincoln stood to speak. The heat in the field. The bullet. The boy with the missing tooth. The tall man on the wall. The army leaving in the dark. His voice did not change much as he told it, and it did not perform. It was the voice of a man describing a place he had lived, not a story he had learned. It went slower in some places than others, and stopped sometimes to go back and correct a small detail, the way people do when they are remembering and not reciting.

Once I stopped the tape and played a line back. *It was the hottest day I had felt in a hundred years*. It was the kind of thing anybody says about a hot day. He was in his seventies. I wrote it down anyway, with a question mark, and let the tape run on.

Liars did not usually correct themselves. It made them look unsure. The good ones, the ones who had rehearsed, told it smooth.

That proved nothing either, I reminded myself. Some people were very good.



At eleven, I opened my laptop and started checking.

Lincoln at Fort Stevens was easy. There were books about it, and articles, and what was left of the fort itself, now a small grassy park in Brightwood, twenty minutes from my own front door. I had lived in Washington my whole adult life and never once been. Lincoln had come out to the fort on July 12, 1864, and stood on the parapet under fire, and an army surgeon standing near him had been shot. Everything Tom Hale had said about it was in the record.

That was the problem. Everything he had said about it was in the record. Anyone could have read it.

I found the surgeon's name in an old account: Cornelius Crawford, assistant surgeon, 102nd Pennsylvania. He had been shot in the leg. He had lived, and years later he had given his own account of that afternoon.

He lived, I think. I was always glad of that.

I sat back.

It was a small thing. It was a strange thing to say, that was all. If you had read about Fort Stevens in a book, the surgeon was a footnote. The book told you his name and that he was hit, and the book moved on to Lincoln, because the book was about Lincoln. You had to go looking to find out whether the surgeon lived. And if you had gone looking, you would know. You would not say *I think*.

You would only say *I think* if you had never looked it up at all. If the last thing you knew about that man was seeing him fall.

Except that he had known the man was a surgeon, and from Pennsylvania. So he had heard something, somewhere, a soldier's rumor or a line in a paper. He had heard who the man was, and never heard how it ended.

I wrote that down in my notebook, and then I drew a line through it, because it was the kind of thought that had gotten me into trouble before.

Then, after a moment, I wrote it down again underneath.

The inauguration was harder, but not much. It had rained on the morning of March 4, 1865, and the streets had been deep in mud. And a newspaper correspondent standing near the platform had written that as Lincoln rose to speak, the sun broke through the clouds, and that Lincoln himself had noticed it, and told a friend afterward that he was just superstitious enough to take it as a good omen.

Also in the record.

I closed the laptop at one in the morning and sat for a while in the dark kitchen.

On the refrigerator, under a magnet shaped like a strawberry, was the calendar where I kept the whole family's life in pencil: Freda's dentist, the gutter deadline, the car insurance. I took the pencil from the string and wrote in next Thursday's square, in small neat letters, *Hale, 10:00*.

Then, because on paper I never lied to myself, I wrote beside it a small question mark, and looked at it, and left it there.

Charles County

The email from Aldine, Mercer and Voss came on Tuesday morning. It was two lines long.

Ms. Barnett, our client thanks you for the first session and has one question for the next. Please ask the gentleman what color the thread was.

I read it three times, and then I had to go back through my own transcript to find out what it meant. It took me ten minutes. It was a single sentence near the start, when he was describing waking in the field, looking at his own sleeves: *There was a hole in one elbow that somebody had darned with the wrong color thread.*

I had typed that sentence myself on Friday, and sent it off to Aldine with the rest, and had not given it a second thought. Somebody else had read it and given it a great deal of thought. Somebody had read the whole transcript closely enough to find the one detail in it that nobody could possibly check, and had decided to ask about that.

It was, I had to admit, exactly what I would have done.



On Thursday the kettle was on again. The stairs still had a book on every step. The chess game by the window had moved on by two pieces, and I wondered who he played against, and then decided he played against himself.

I set out the two recorders. I said the date and the time. Then I read him the email.

“Blue,” he said.

He said it at once, without looking up and without thinking, the way you would say the color of your own front door.

“Union blue,” he went on. “Which was the joke of it, in that coat. His mother had run out of gray the winter before he went, and she used what she had, and she told him that if anybody asked, he should say he’d taken a Yankee prisoner and kept the thread for a souvenir.” He smiled a little. “I never met anyone who asked. Until now.”

“How do you know that?” I said. “If it happened before you were... him.”

“She told me.” He said it simply. “That August, sitting by my bed, mending the same coat. She told it as a joke we both knew. I laughed in the right place.” He looked down at his hands. “The body keeps what it knows how to do, Ms. Barnett. The accent, the hands, how to sit a horse. It doesn’t keep what it remembers. That, you have to be told.”

“It’s an odd question,” I said.

“It is.” He was quiet for a moment, and his eyes went, just briefly, to the mantel, and then back. “Your client reads carefully.”

“Yes.”

“So do you, I think. You had to look for it.”

“I had to look for it,” I admitted.

He nodded, as if that settled something, and did not say what.

“Where were we?” he said. “The wagon. Yes.” He settled back in his chair, and the pencil began to move again on the notepad. “A woman’s voice, in the dark. I was lying behind a stone wall with a belt around my leg, and she said, *He’s alive.*”



• RECORDING · JULY TO NOVEMBER 1864

The woman’s name was Margaret Keene, and she was my mother.

I knew she was my mother before I knew her name. She climbed down behind the wall where I lay, took my face in both her hands, and said, “Oh, Kit. Oh, my boy,” and wept against my shoulder while I lay there not know-

ing her at all. Her name I learned a few hours later, when a Union picket stopped the wagon on the road below Washington and asked for it.

There is no rule for that. I have been somebody's son many times, and it has never become easier. She had loved this boy for nineteen years. She had come forty miles, two days on the road and the last of it in the dark, through an army's leavings, on nothing but a rumor that Kit's company was outside Washington, to find him. And the boy she found was not there anymore, and the one she held instead had to decide, in that first moment, whether to tell her.

I have never told them. Not once, in all the lives. I tell myself it would be cruel to take their child away from them a second time. Some nights I think the truth is simpler, and that I am a coward. Maybe it is both.

So I said, "Mama," because that was the word the body wanted, and she held on tighter, and I let her.

There was a man with her. He lifted me from behind the wall and laid me in the back of the wagon on a pile of feed sacks as carefully as if I were made of glass, and he never once looked at my face. He was tall, not much past thirty, with a scar through one eyebrow and a face that gave away nothing at all. I heard her call him Damon. *Damon, the blanket. Damon, mind his leg.* He did everything she asked before she had quite finished asking it.

Much later, on the road, my mother told me it was Damon who had found me. He had stopped the stragglers on the road north and asked every one of them for Kit's company, and where its wounded had been left, and then he had walked the stone walls in the dark with a shaded lantern until he came to mine. "I don't know how he knew where to look," she said. "He always does."

It was a strange thing for a field hand to know. I decided there was more to Damon than anyone on that farm had noticed, and from then on I kept an eye on him.

Before we set off, he put sacks of new potatoes over me and around me until I was a lump among the potatoes, and I lay in the dark and the smell of earth and listened to the wheels.



Maryland was a Union state. That surprises people now. It had stayed in the Union, mostly because the Union had made sure of it, with soldiers at the rail junctions and soldiers in Baltimore and soldiers at the bridges. But the southern counties, the tobacco counties, the counties that ran down the long peninsula between the Potomac and the Chesapeake Bay, belonged to the Confederacy in every way but the one on the map. Their sons had gone across the river to fight for Virginia. Their letters went back and forth by boat at night. Everyone knew someone who hid someone.

It took us two days to reach home. We went south out of the city on back roads, and every few miles there was a picket, bored and hot, and every time Margaret Keene said she had brought potatoes up to sell in Washington, found the markets shut for the fighting, and was taking them home again, and every time she smiled at the soldiers like a woman with nothing under her potatoes. One of them took a handful of potatoes for his supper and let us go.

We stopped once to water the horse, at a crossroads tavern at a place called Surrattsville. A widow kept it. She came out on the porch to talk with my mother in low voices, and when she went back in, there were two more blankets and a jar of broth in the wagon that had not been there before.

At the time it seemed like nothing more than kindness, one mother helping another. I did not even ask her name.



The Keene farm lay a few miles from a village called Bryantown, in low green country cut through by creeks and a great dark swamp that the locals called the Zekiah. The Keenes grew tobacco, mostly, with some corn, and kept a few hogs. A white house with a long porch, a kitchen built separate from the house because of the heat and the risk of fire, a tobacco barn, and behind the barn, in a row, the small log cabins where the people lived who did the work.

The leg went bad on the road home. By the time we reached the farm I was burning with fever, and I spent most of August in bed.

A doctor came from Bryantown, a thin, nervous man who smelled of tobacco and camphor and said very little, and he looked at my leg and looked at my mother and said he could take it off above the knee, and then I would very likely live. My mother said no. He said then I would very likely die. My mother said we would see. He left some powders and did not come back for a week, and I think he expected to be called for my funeral.

I did not die. I lived because my mother sat up with me every night for three weeks, and bathed the wound with boiled water and salt when the doctor said not to, and because the bullet had gone clean through and missed the bone, and because this body was young and had been fed well all its life. And, perhaps, because I did not want to die yet. I had seen something from that field that I did not understand, and I have never been able to leave a thing I do not understand.

While I had the fever I was allowed to say strange things. Afterward I had to be more careful.

There is a craft to becoming someone who already exists. You must never say a name first. You wait until someone else says it, and then you use it as though you have always known it. You must never tell a story from your past; you let others tell them, and you laugh in the right places, and you say *I don't remember that* often enough that it becomes a joke about the war and your head. You learn where the cups are kept by watching who reaches for them. You learn which chair was yours by sitting in the wrong one and seeing the small hurt look on a younger sister's face.

My sister was named Lottie. She was fourteen, and she read novels in the hayloft that my mother did not approve of, and she decided very quickly that the war had made me quiet and sad and interesting, like a man in one of her novels. She brought me water and newspapers and the gossip of the county, and she was the first person in that life I loved.

It was Lottie who told me the story about the President.

It was going around, she said, that when the rebels were at the gates of Washington, old Abe Lincoln himself had gone out to the fort to watch, and

stood up on the wall like a fool in his tall hat, bold as anything, with the bullets flying, and a man was shot right next to him. And a young Yankee officer had shouted at him, *Get down, you fool!* Not knowing who it was. Or knowing, which was better.

"Is it true?" she said. "You were there."

"I was there," I said. "I didn't hear anybody shout."

"Well, I'm choosing to believe it," said Lottie, "because it's a better story."

I thought about the tall man on the wall, looking out at us like a farmer looking at weather, and I said nothing.



My father had died of a fever two years before. My older cousin Ned, who had gone across the river with Kit in sixty-two, long before Kit was me, was alive. We knew that because a letter came from him in the second week of September, a single sheet folded small, written in pencil, and opened and read and stamped by a Union officer before it was allowed to reach us.

He was a prisoner. He had been taken in the spring, in Virginia, along with several other boys from our company. They were being held at Point Lookout.

I did not know the name. My mother did. When she read it, she sat down on the porch steps as though her legs had been taken from under her.

Point Lookout was at the very bottom of our own peninsula, where the Potomac meets the bay. About fifty miles south of where we sat. A flat, sandy spit of land with nothing on it but a Union prison camp: no barracks, only tents, thousands of men living on sand behind a high board fence, with the water all around. In summer the sun came off the sand like the door of an oven. In winter, the wind came off the bay.

We are doing as well as can be expected, Ned wrote, though the rations are short and the water is bad, and Jem Carroll died of the flux on Tuesday. Tell Aunt Margaret not to worry. I think often of home. We hear the exchange will start again soon.

Nobody in the county believed the exchange would start again soon. The two governments had stopped trading prisoners the year before, and neither

one would give way. Everyone in the county believed the men at Point Lookout would stay there until the war ended or they died, and the second was happening faster than the first.

My mother read the letter aloud three times. Then she folded it up and put it in her apron pocket, and I watched her carry it there, touching it now and then, for the rest of the fall.



I noticed Damon in September.

That is not quite true. I had noticed him from the first morning, the way you notice the man who lifts you from behind a wall. But I had not *seen* him. That was the point of him, I understood later. He had made himself into something nobody saw.

He was the one my mother relied on for anything that mattered: the horses, the dealings with the tobacco buyer, which were all done by handshake and memory, the mending of anything broken. He spoke only when spoken to and said as little as a man could say and still answer. He never looked at me directly. I thought at first that it was fear, or the habit of that place, where a Black man who looked a white man in the eye could be whipped for it.

Then one afternoon I came into the kitchen yard on my crutch, more quietly than I meant to, and he was standing by the table where Lottie had left one of her newspapers. He was not touching it. He was only looking down at it. But his eyes were moving along the lines, left to right, and down, and left to right, the way eyes move when they are reading, and reading quickly.

He heard my crutch on the step. His eyes stopped. He picked up the bucket at his feet and went to the well, and when he came back past me, his face was nothing at all, as smooth and closed as a shut door.

That night, and for a good many nights after, I lay awake and turned it over.

A field hand on a Charles County farm, who had never been to school, because no one on that farm would have let him, reading a newspaper faster

than I could. And hiding it. Not from my mother. From me. As if he had seen something in me, since the war, that he did not trust.

I did not know what to make of it. There have always been a few people, here and there across my lives, who seemed out of place in their own skins. I noticed them the way you notice a word spelled wrong. Damon was one.



In October, Maryland voted itself free.

The new state constitution passed by a few hundred votes, and only because of the votes of Maryland's Union soldiers in the field. The men at home had voted against it. At the end of the month the governor declared it law. At midnight on the first of November, every enslaved person in Maryland would be free by law. Somewhere that night, people were celebrating. In our county, no one was.

On the last night of October, my mother did not come down to supper. Lottie cried, and could not say why.

In the morning, Damon was standing at the bottom of the porch steps in a clean shirt, with a bundle tied in a blanket over his shoulder. He had come to say that he was going. He said it to my mother, politely, the way he had said everything to her for twenty years, and she stood in the doorway with her arms folded and did not answer him.

Then he looked at me.

It was the first time. Just for a moment, one long moment, he looked straight at me, the way I had seen him look at the newspaper: reading me, quickly, left to right and down. I do not know what he found. I know that I felt, for the first time in that life, the particular cold feeling of being seen clearly by somebody who does not like what he sees.

Then he turned and walked down the lane toward the Washington road, and he did not look back.

"Good riddance," my mother said, and went inside, and shut the door hard enough that the glass rattled.

I stood on the porch on my crutch and watched him until the road turned into the trees.

I never expected to see him again.



The fire in the woodstove had burned down. I had filled most of a notebook.

“Did you see him again?” I asked. “Damon.”

He looked at me for a long moment.

“We’ll get there,” he said.

Carrow House

At noon he stopped and made soup. He would not let me help. It was a thick vegetable soup out of a big dented pot that had clearly made more pots of soup than anyone could count, and he served it with bread from the town bakery and apologized for the bread, which did not need an apology.

We ate at the kitchen table, and he asked me about myself.

He asked the way he did everything, without pushing. Where I had grown up. Whether I liked the city. How long I had been a reporter. What I used to report on. I had not meant to tell him much of anything, but the soup was good and the kitchen was warm, and it had been a long time since anyone had asked me a question and then actually waited for the answer.

So I told him about Carrow House.

I told it badly, the way people tell the worst year of their lives, which is to say all out of order and with too much in it. I told him about the call to the newsroom, and the first meeting in a diner where my source had ordered a grilled cheese and a cup of tomato soup and not touched either one. That became a joke between us, later: he always ordered the grilled cheese and the soup, and he never once ate them. I told him about the laundromat. I told him about that summer, which was the hottest I could remember, and how the air conditioning in the newsroom had broken in July and nobody fixed it until September.

I told him about my source's building, a brick walk-up over a dry cleaner's, with a landlord named Petrakis who complained about everything: the tenants, the pipes, the parking, the city. A woman on the second floor called Petrakis about noise so often that he had stopped answering her. The dry cleaner's

steam came up through the floor in the mornings, so the whole building smelled of hot cotton.

And I told him about the Sunday the story ran, and how my source had called me that morning from the phone at the dry cleaner's downstairs, because he never trusted his own, to say he had bought ten copies, and then felt foolish, because who was he going to give them to. After that came the Monday, and the lawsuit. I had told my source to stay away from Carrow that week, to take some sick days until it blew over, and he had said he would. We were supposed to meet on the Wednesday, at the diner, at noon. He didn't come.

"Gone how?"

"Gone. The phone was off. He wasn't at the diner, and he wasn't at home. Petrakis let the police in on the Friday, and the apartment was empty. Well, not empty. His things were there, some of them. But he wasn't. And his cat was shut in the bedroom, half starved, poor thing. Petrakis took it to the shelter and then complained to me for ten minutes about the smell. I remember he wanted to know who was going to pay for the carpet." I shook my head. "And that was it. That was the last anybody saw of him. By the end of the year the paper had printed the correction, and I was out."

"I'm sorry," he said.

"It was a long time ago."

"It doesn't sound like it."

I did not answer that. He took my bowl and filled it again without asking, and set it in front of me, and began to talk about something else entirely: the bakery in town, which had been run by the same family for three generations and was going to close in the spring because none of the grandchildren wanted it.



After lunch we went back to the living room. I asked him about Ned, the cousin at Point Lookout, and he went back to 1864.

He talked again about the letter from Point Lookout, and how his mother had carried it in her apron pocket all that fall. He talked about what it did to a family to have a son in a place like that, where you knew he was hungry and

could do nothing, where every letter might be the last one. He said the men in those camps wrote home as if they would be back by Christmas, even the ones who knew better. Everyone was hoping for the best.

“Ned wrote that he thought often of home,” he said. “He said to tell my mother not to worry. You don’t write that to people unless you mean to come back to them.”

He was looking at the window. My pencil had stopped.

“Then he meant to come home,” he said.

I looked up from my notebook. “Ned?”

“No.” He turned from the window. “Your man. With the cat.”

I did not understand him at first, and then I did.

“A man who is running away takes his cat,” he said, gently. “Or he asks someone to look after it. He doesn’t shut it in a bedroom and leave. He shut it in there the way you do when you’re going out for an hour and don’t want it under your feet. He meant to come back that evening.”

I laughed. It came out louder than I meant.

“Or he panicked,” I said. “People forget things when they’re running for their lives.”

“He may have panicked later.”

“What does that mean?”

“He could have gone out intending to return, and something happened after.”

“That doesn’t mean something happened to him. He could have changed his mind. He could have decided to leave town.”

“Yes,” he said. “He could have.”

I looked at him. He had agreed with me, but it had not made me feel any better.

“The police knew about the cat,” I said. “Petrakis told the whole building. It was in the report.”

“What did they make of it?”

“I don’t remember. They asked Petrakis when he’d last seen him. They asked me whether my source had said anything about leaving town.” I stopped. “I told them he hadn’t.”

“Had he?”

“No. That’s why I told them.”

He nodded. I could tell he was waiting for me to go on.

“They thought he’d run because of the lawsuit,” I said. “So did the paper. By the end of that week, I’d heard it so many times I was answering their questions as though I knew it too.”

“But you didn’t.”

“I didn’t know where he was.” I laid my hand over the open notebook. “I thought if he was hiding, he might call me when things settled down.”

“And did you expect him to?”

“For a while.” I gave a small, embarrassed laugh. “I kept the phone beside my bed. I was furious with him, which made it easier to think he was alive somewhere.”

He said nothing.

“I’ve told that story a hundred times,” I said. “The cat was always in it. Petrakis wouldn’t let anyone forget the cat. But I never stopped to think about what he’d done before he left the apartment.”

“The carpet,” he said.

“What about it?”

“Petrakis wanted to know who would pay for it. Was the cat’s litter box in the bedroom?”

“I don’t know.”

“If it was somewhere else, your man shut the cat away from it.”

“He might not have been thinking about that.”

“He might not.” He glanced at my notebook. “Petrakis was thinking about it by Friday. You could ask him what he found.”

“I haven’t spoken to him since. I think he sold the building.”

“Then you could start with the police report.”

I had looked at that report once, years ago, for anything that might tell me where my source had gone. I could not remember whether it said a word about the cat beyond where they had found it.

“He was supposed to meet me at noon,” I said.

“Perhaps that was where he was going.”

I looked toward the window. For years I had remembered the empty booth at the diner, the waitress coming to refill my coffee, the clock over the counter edging past twelve. Now I tried to picture him in his apartment that morning instead, shutting the bedroom door and leaving the cat behind it.

“That doesn’t tell us what happened to him.”

“No.”

“He could have decided not to come.”

“Yes.”

For a while neither of us spoke. Then I picked up my pencil.

“What did Ned write after that?”

He went on about Ned. I wrote it all down, and did not look at him again for some time.



On the drive home I tried to remember the name of the cat.

I had been in that apartment. Once, early on, before I knew better than to meet a source at home. The cat had come and sat on my notebook. It had been gray, with white feet. He had told me its name, and I had written half a page of notes that day, and I could see the page in my mind, and I could not see the name.

Nor could I remember whether I had ever asked what happened to it after the shelter.

It did not matter. It had been six years. It was a cat.

At the red light at the bottom of the hill, I took out my notebook and wrote, in the margin of that day’s page: *cat, bedroom, door shut. Meant to come back?* And then I left it there, and did not cross it out.

The Actor

No email came from Aldine, Mercer and Voss that week.

The second payment landed that same Thursday afternoon, the way the first one had, with the note *Session 2* and nothing else. I kept checking my inbox through the weekend and into the next week, for the client's question, and on Wednesday night I realized I was disappointed. I did not like that at all.

"No question this time?" he asked, when I had set out the recorders on Thursday.

"Nothing. Just the money."

"Hm," he said. He looked at the mantel for a moment, the way he had the week before, and then back at me. "Well. Perhaps your client is thinking."

"About what?"

"I couldn't say." He picked up the notepad. "Where were we? Damon had gone down the lane. And the farm went quiet."



• RECORDING · NOVEMBER 1864

The farm went quiet after Damon left.

Not all at once. For a week or two the others stayed, because it was November and cold and there was nowhere in particular to go, and because freedom on a piece of paper in Annapolis did not put food in anybody's hands. But one by one the cabins behind the tobacco barn emptied. A family went to Washington. Two of the young men went to Baltimore to look for work on the docks. An old woman named Hester, who had cooked in that

kitchen since before my mother was married, stayed, and my mother paid her in money for the first time, and neither of them ever spoke about it.

The tobacco was cut and hanging in the barn. The corn was half in. There was nobody to bring in the rest of it but my mother and Lottie and a man on a crutch.

In the second week of November we heard that Lincoln had won the election. He had won it easily, in every state but three. My mother read it in the newspaper and folded the paper up very small and put it in the stove.

"Four more years," she said. "Ned will die in that place."

Nobody at the table told her she was wrong.



That Sunday my mother decided I was well enough for Mass.

St. Mary's was a little brick church outside Bryantown, and on a Sunday morning it was the whole county in one room. You went for God, and you went to find out who had news from across the river, who had a letter from a son, whose barn had been searched by the provost men and what they had found in it. The women talked on one side of the churchyard after Mass and the men talked on the other, and the talk on both sides was the same talk, in lower voices than it would have been a year before.

There were six steps up to the door. I counted them from the wagon. My mother got down first and did not offer me her arm, because she knew I would not take it in front of the county, and Lottie walked beside me with her hands folded, as if she had not noticed anything at all. I took the steps one at a time, crutch and then foot, crutch and then foot. The talk in the churchyard went quiet while I did it, and started again, a little too loudly, when I reached the top.

That was the first time I understood what the leg was going to mean in that life. Every man in the county knew that Margaret Keene's boy had been shot in front of Washington. A wound is a kind of letter of introduction.

After Mass, the men came to me. Men who had never said a word to Kit came across the grass and shook my hand, and some of them stayed, and lowered their voices.

A farmer named Carrico, with a face like a walnut, held on to my hand a while. "My Tom's across the river with Mosby," he said. "Got a letter from him Thursday. Came over the river at night, the way they do." He looked at the leg. "He'd want me to say he's proud of you. So I'm saying it."

A younger man, who kept his hat in his hands the whole time, told me the provost men had been through Hardy's place on Wednesday, looking for a boat. "Turned the barn out," he said. "Pulled up the floor of the corncrib. Never found it." He almost smiled. "It's on the bottom of the creek, with a load of stones in it. You bail it out when you need it."

And an old man I did not know at all, with a gray beard down to his second button, leaned in close enough that I could smell the tobacco on him, and said, "When that leg's better, son, if you're minded to go back over, you come and see me. I can find you a boat, and a man who knows the river well enough to row it in the dark."

I thanked every one of them. I did not ask a single question. I did not need to. A man who is trusted does not have to ask; he only has to stand still and let the county tell him what it knows. By the time my mother was ready to go, I knew where at least one boat was kept, which roads the provost men watched, and that half the men in that churchyard were in the business of getting letters and people across the Potomac at night.

I was still standing in the churchyard with my weight on the crutch when I saw the stranger.

He was standing with old Dr. Queen, who was past seventy and lived some miles south of the village, and with Dr. Queen's son-in-law, a man named Thompson. He was not very tall. He had black hair, curled, and a black moustache, and skin so pale that it looked as if he had never been out in the weather in his life. His coat was better than any coat in that churchyard, and he wore it as if he had forgotten he had it on, which is a harder thing to do than it looks.

Lottie took hold of my arm hard enough to hurt.

"Kit," she said. "Kit. Do you know who that is?"

"No," I said. "Should I?"

“That’s John Wilkes Booth.” She said the whole name, the way you say the name of a place. “The actor. I have his picture. I have his picture *in my room*.”

She did. I had seen it. Actors sold their portraits in those days on little cards, the size of your hand, and girls collected them the way boys collected cigar bands. Lottie had three of this one, propped along her windowsill.

“What’s he doing in Bryantown?” I said.

“I don’t know. I don’t care.” She was standing on her toes. “He’s the most famous young actor in America. Everybody says so. When he plays Richard the Third he fights so wildly that the other actors are afraid of him.”

“Are they really?” I said.

She gave me the look she saved for when I was being a brother, and did not bother to answer, and went back to staring across the churchyard.

I watched Thompson bring him across the churchyard to a man standing by the gate: a slim man with a high forehead and reddish whiskers, about thirty, whom I knew as the young Dr. Mudd, who farmed and doctored a few miles up the road. The two of them shook hands. They talked for a few minutes, with their heads close together. I could not hear what was said. It looked like nothing, two men being polite on a church step.

Everything I tell you about Booth, I learned later, looking back. That morning he was only a famous man in a churchyard, and I was a farm boy with a bad leg and a sister pulling on my sleeve.

Then Thompson brought him over to us.



“Mrs. Keene,” Thompson said. “Mr. Booth is staying with my father-in-law. He asked to be introduced to the family of the young man who was at Fort Stevens.”

He was charming. I want to say that plainly, because it matters, and because nobody who writes about him now likes to say it. He was the most charming man I met in that life, and I have met more charming men than I can count.

He bowed over my mother's hand as if she were a duchess and they were in a ballroom and not a muddy churchyard. "Mrs. Keene," he said. "I've heard about your son all morning. Half the county is proud of him, and I think the other half is jealous of you."

My mother, who had not smiled at a stranger since the war began, smiled. Then he turned to Lottie. "And this is?"

"Charlotte," Lottie said, which nobody had called her in her life. And then, before anyone could stop her, "I have your picture."

I thought she would die of it. My mother closed her eyes.

Booth did not laugh at her. He looked delighted, as if it were the best news he had heard all week. "Then you have the advantage of me, Miss Keene," he said. "Which one? Not the one as Richard, I hope. They made my nose far too long in that one. I've had words with the man." He put his hand on his heart. "You must let me send you a better one. Signed. If your mother permits."

She went as red as a brick and adored him forever.

I remember thinking that was not bad. Not bad at all. He had taken a girl's worst moment, in front of the whole county, and in three sentences turned it into the story she would tell for the rest of her life.

Then he turned to me, and shook my hand, and held it a moment longer than a man needs to.

"I won't ask you about it," he said, looking at the crutch. "Everybody's asked you about it already, I expect. I'll only say I'm glad you came home."

"Thank you," I said.

"Mr. Booth has come down to look at land," Thompson said.

"Land, and horses," Booth said. "There'll be money to be made in Southern Maryland once this war is over, Mrs. Keene. Good land, good water, the river right there. I mean to buy before everybody else wakes up to it. And I need a good horse or two besides." He said it to my mother, but he was looking around the churchyard as he spoke, lightly, the way you look around a room you have just walked into. "Do you know of anyone selling?"

My mother looked at me. I knew what she was thinking. We had five horses and nobody to work them and no money for their feed through the

winter.

"We might," she said.

"Then may I call?" He smiled at her. "Tuesday, perhaps?"

He came to the farm on Tuesday.



I showed him the horses, because I was the man of the house, and because my mother did not want to be seen selling them.

I leaned on the fence and watched him while he looked at them.

He did not look at them the way a man looks at a horse he means to buy. He did not open a single mouth to see the teeth. He did not run his hand down a single leg. He walked around each one and patted its neck and said something kind about it, the way you would say something kind about a friend's baby.

"This one's a good fellow," he said, about the old bay. "He has a wise face. Don't you think he has a wise face?"

"He's sixteen," I said. "He's wise because he's old."

"The best reason." He laughed. "May I ride him?"

He rode well. I will say that too. He rode better than anyone I had seen in that county, easily, as if the horse were a chair. He took the bay down to the end of the lane and back at a canter, and pulled up by the fence, and swung down, and I saw that he had not once looked at the horse's paces. He had been looking at the lane. Where it met the road, and which way the road went.

He leaned on the fence beside me.

"How far is it to the river from here?" he said. "The Potomac, I mean."

"Twenty miles, about. Depends which way you go."

"And which way would you go? With a wagon, say."

"Down through Beantown, if it's dry. Across by the swamp road, if you don't mind wet feet."

"The swamp road," he said, as if it were the name of a song. "Does it flood?"

"In the spring. You can get through if you know where the high ground is."

"And do you?"

"Everybody here does."

"Are there soldiers on it?"

"Sometimes. On the main road, more often. At the crossings."

"And at night?"

"Fewer," I said. "They don't like the swamp in the dark any more than anybody else does."

He said all of it lightly, leaning on the fence, between remarks about the weather and the fine old house and the wise face of the bay, so that each question sounded like the natural next thing to ask. "For the land, you understand," he said. "A man wants to know how he'd get his crop to market."

Nobody in Charles County took a crop across the Potomac. Virginia was on the other side, and there was a war on it. And nobody who meant to farm asked which roads a wagon could use at night.

I said none of this. I answered every question, truthfully, because every one of them was something any child in the county could have told him. And I let him think I was a slow farm boy who had been shot and would believe anything he was told.

Then he turned around on the fence and looked at me, and I found out he had been watching me too.

"You stand," he said, "like a man who is learning a part."

For a moment I could not breathe.

I had been in that body for four months. I had fooled a mother, which is the hardest audience there is. I had fooled Lottie, and the priest, and every man in that churchyard. And in twenty minutes, leaning on a fence, a stranger had seen the one thing I had spent four months hiding.

Then he laughed, and put his hand on my shoulder.

"Forgive me," he said. "I see it in all of them. The boys who come home. They come back, and they don't quite fit themselves anymore, and they have to learn how to be who they were before. It's the saddest thing I know." He meant it. His eyes were wet. "Where did you get the leg?"

“Fort Stevens,” I said. “In front of Washington. In July.”

He went very still.

“Were you,” he said. “Then you saw him. They say he came out on the wall.”

“I saw a tall man in a tall hat,” I said. “I didn’t know who he was until later.”

“How close?”

“A few hundred yards.”

“And nobody fired at him.”

“Everybody fired at the fort,” I said. “Nobody knew who he was.”

“Nobody knew,” Booth said, softly, to himself, and looked out over the fence at nothing for a long time.



My mother gave him supper. It was the least she could do for a man who might buy her horses, and more than she could afford. She put out the good plates, which had not been down from the shelf since the spring, and Hester killed a chicken, and nobody said a word about what it cost.

He was easy at the table. He told my mother her biscuits were better than any in Baltimore, and asked Hester how she made them, and listened to the answer. He asked me nothing at all about the war, which I was grateful for, and nothing more about the roads, which I noticed.

It was Lottie, of course, who told him about Ned. She could not help it either.

“Our cousin’s a prisoner,” she said. “At Point Lookout. He wrote to us in September. In pencil, and a Union officer read it first, you could see where he’d stamped it. He says he’s all right. Jem Carroll’s dead, though. Jem was in his company. He died of the flux.” She said it all in one breath, the way she said everything. “But it doesn’t matter so much now, because the exchange is going to start again soon, everybody says so, and then Ned will come home.”

I watched the charm go out of his face like a lamp being turned down.

“It won’t,” he said. “It won’t start again. Grant has seen to that. He knows every man he sends back to us is a man back in the line, and he has

more men than we do, so he'll let ours die in the camps sooner than trade them." He put his fork down. "They're starving them, Mrs. Keene. At Point Lookout, at Elmira, at all of them. Not by accident. On purpose, by men who can count."

Nobody said anything. My mother's hand went to her apron pocket, where the letter was. Lottie looked at her plate.

"Somebody ought to make them trade," Booth said.

He did not say anything more than that. He picked up his fork again, and looked at Lottie, and saw her face, and changed the subject, very gracefully, the way you would lift a child over a puddle.

"Miss Keene," he said. "Do you know what I'm doing in ten days?"

She shook her head.

"I'm going to be on the stage of the Winter Garden, in New York, playing *Julius Caesar*," he said. "With both of my brothers. Edwin, and Junius, and me. The three of us, for the first time in our lives, on one stage, on one night." He opened his hands. "It's a benefit. We're raising money for a statue of Shakespeare, in the new Central Park. Our father would have liked that. He was an actor too, you know. The best of us, some people say."

Lottie nearly died of it.

"Which part do you play?" she asked.

"Mark Antony," he said. "Caesar's friend. The one who stands up after the murder and turns the crowd."

"And who does the murder?"

"Brutus." He smiled. "Edwin has Brutus. Edwin always gets Brutus."

He said it as a joke about brothers, and we all laughed. I laughed too. But I was sitting nearest him, and I saw his hand close on the napkin in his lap while he said it, and open again, and smooth it out flat on his knee. It took no time at all. Nobody else at that table saw it. I remember it because I thought, just for a moment, that he minded, and because it was the first thing he had done all day that he had not meant anyone to see.

He did not buy a horse. He said he would think it over and come back before Christmas. He rode away down the lane in the last of the light, sitting his

borrowed horse as if he had been born on it, and Lottie watched from the porch until he was gone.



He did come back, in the middle of December.

He stayed with Dr. Queen again, and on the Sunday he was at St. Mary's again, in the same good coat, and this time the whole churchyard knew who he was. After Mass there was a little crowd around him, and Lottie was at the front of it, and she did not wait to be introduced.

"How was the play?" she said. "Mr. Booth. How was *Julius Caesar*?"

He laughed, and looked around at all of them, and I saw him decide to give them a performance. He was very good at it. He did not tell it so much as play it, there on the church step, with his hands.

"You want the whole of it?" he said.

"Yes."

"Then you shall have it." He went back up onto the top step, where all of us would have to look up at him. An actor always knows where to stand. "Picture a theater, Miss Keene. Bigger than this church ten times over, all red and gold, and every seat sold a week before. People standing at the back. People in the aisles. My mother in a box above the stage, in her best black silk, come to see her three sons together. Our father never lived to see it. So she saw it for him."

He put his hand on the door frame behind him, as if it were the edge of a curtain.

"We came on together, the three of us, in the very first scene. And before any of us could say a word, the whole house stood up. Every soul in it, on their feet, for the Booths. So we did the only thing we could." He turned, and looked up at the church roof as if there were a box there, and bowed to it, slowly, with his hand on his heart. Half the women in the churchyard sighed. "We bowed to our mother."

Lottie had both hands pressed together under her chin.

"And then we played. And it went well. It went better than well." He lowered his voice, and the crowd leaned in to hear it. "Until the middle of it, with

my brother Edwin alone on the stage, and every eye on him. And from somewhere at the back of the house, a man stood up." Booth flung out one arm and pitched his voice high and wild, and it rang off the brick. "*Fire!*"

Somebody in the crowd gasped. A child started to cry and was hushed.

"You could hear it," he said, quietly now. "The whole house, all at once, starting to get up. Seats banging. A woman screaming somewhere upstairs. The sound a crowd makes just before it runs, and once it runs, people die on the stairs. It was no false alarm, you see. The hotel next door had caught fire." He paused, and let them wait. "And my brother walked down to the very edge of the stage, in his toga, and held up one hand. Like this." He held up his hand, palm out, and stood perfectly still, and so did we. "And he said, in the voice he uses for Brutus, as calm as a man ordering his breakfast, *Ladies and gentlemen. There is no danger. Please keep your seats.*"

He let his hand fall.

"And they sat down. Every one of them. He talked them down like a man gentling a horse. And the firemen put it out next door, and nobody was hurt, and we finished the play."

"Were you frightened?" Lottie said.

"Not for a moment." He smiled at her. "I was in the wings. I had my best speech still to come."

Everyone laughed. Somebody said it sounded like the Yankees ought to mind their fire engines. Somebody else said he'd read in the paper that it wasn't only the one hotel, it was a dozen of them, all over the city, the same night, and they were saying it was Southern men who did it.

Booth's face did not change at all.

"So I read," he said. "Afterward." And he turned back to Lottie and asked her whether she had ever seen a play, and the talk went on to other things.

I stood at the edge of it on my crutch and thought about his story. It had been beautifully told. He had given every part of that night its moment: the house on its feet, the bow to his mother, the shout, the seats banging, his brother's hand. He had played it for us as well as he had ever played anything. And the only part he had nothing to say about was the part that was in every newspaper in the country.

A man who has read something afterward usually has an opinion about it. Booth had an opinion about everything.

When the crowd broke up, I watched Dr. Mudd take him by the arm and walk him down the road toward Bryantown, with a man I did not know walking on his other side. I did not think anything of that either, at the time.

That afternoon he rode up our lane alone, in the rain, and asked my mother if he might have a word with her son.



He stopped there and reached for his tea. It had been sitting beside him since the churchyard, and it must have been stone cold, but he drank it anyway.

I realized I had been holding my pen above the page for some time without writing anything. The churchyard, the fence, the good plates on the supper table: I had been there, all of it, and now I was back in his living room, with the woodstove ticking and the little red lights on the recorders, and my hand had gone stiff.

“So he came down to buy a horse,” I said, “and you sold him the roads instead.”

“Not yet,” he said. “In November I only answered his questions. December was when I sold him the roads.”

I laughed before I could stop myself, and then I did stop, because he was not laughing.

“The fires,” I said. “In New York. Was that real?”

“You’ll look it up tonight,” he said. “I’d rather you did that than take my word for it. But yes.”

He was right. I would.

“And he knew?”

“I don’t know.” He turned his pencil over in his fingers. “That’s the honest answer. He told us all about the play, the brothers, the crowd, his mother in her box. He told the fire as if it were only a thing that happened to the Booths one night in New York. I used to think that meant he knew. Then I used to think it

meant he didn't care. I've had a long time to think about it, and I still don't know." He looked up at me. "You'd be surprised how much of it is like that."

I wrote *Winter Garden. Fires. Did he know?* at the bottom of the page, and underlined the last part twice, and we stopped for lunch.

The Pitch

At noon he made soup again, white bean this time, with a ham bone in it, and cornbread from a box that he apologized for. We ate it at the kitchen table and talked about nothing at all: the bakery that was closing, a fox he had seen in the field, a show Freda watched that I could not follow. He did not say Booth's name once.

Afterward we went back to the living room. I turned the recorders on and said the time.

"December," he said. "He came back in December, in the rain."



• RECORDING · DECEMBER 1864

We walked out to the tobacco barn, because it was the only place on the farm where two men could talk without being overheard, and because Booth said he wanted to see the crop.

He did not look at the crop. He stood in the doorway with the rain running off the roof behind him and the tobacco hanging over our heads in long brown rows, curing in the dark, and he looked at me the way he had looked at me on the fence in November. Then he asked me how my cousin was.

I told him the truth. A second letter had come at the beginning of the month. It was shorter than the first. Ned had been sick, it said, and was better now, and two more of the boys from our company were dead. The last line said, *Tell Aunt Margaret I am sorry to be so much trouble.*

My mother read it as good news. *He's better*, she kept saying. *He says so himself*.

He had not said so himself. That was the first thing I saw, the first time I held it. The September letter had been in Ned's own pencil, big and leaning, with the letters pressed hard into the paper, the hand of a young man who had left school at twelve. This one was in ink, small and upright and careful, the hand of somebody who had been taught properly and wrote letters for a living. Somebody in that camp had written it for him. A man who was really better would have held the pencil himself. And *I am sorry to be so much trouble* is not what a man says when he is getting well. It is what he says to the people who are nursing him, near the end, when he knows.

I did not tell my mother. I told myself she would learn it soon enough from someone kinder. Lottie found the letter in the apron pocket and read it and came to me in the hayloft, white in the face, and asked me what it meant. She had seen it too. She was a reader. I could not make myself tell her she was right, and I could not make myself tell her she was wrong, so I said nothing at all, and she understood that as well.

Booth listened to all of it without once looking away.

"I told your mother that somebody ought to make them trade," he said. "Do you remember?"

"I remember."

"I have spent the last month," he said, "working out how."

He came in out of the doorway, and stood close, and lowered his voice under the sound of the rain.

"I'm going to tell you something I have told very few men," he said. "When I've finished, you'll want to know why I told it to you. I'll tell you that too."



I am going to tell you what he said as closely as I can, and I am going to tell you why I listened. I am not asking you to agree with either of us. I am only asking you to stand in that barn with me, in December of 1864, and hear it the way I heard it.

"You know the war is lost," he said.

He said it plainly, which surprised me, because every other man in that county still talked as though Richmond would hold forever.

"Don't you?" he said. "You've been out there. You know better than these farmers."

I did not answer, and he took that as an answer.

"Hood's army is smashed at Nashville," he said. "It came over the wire this week. Sherman has walked straight through Georgia to the sea, and there was nobody left to stop him. Grant has Lee dug in at Petersburg and he is starving him out one railroad at a time." He counted them off on his gloved fingers. "And we have no more men, Kit. That's the whole of it. Every man who can carry a rifle is carrying one. There's nobody left at home to send."

"There are the prisoners," I said.

"There are the prisoners." He pointed at me, the way a teacher points at the one boy in the room who has been listening. "Fifty thousand of them. The very men who could hold those lines, sitting in Northern camps, dying of cold and flux and short rations. And the Union knows exactly what they're worth, and won't give them back."

"Grant won't trade them," he said. "He's said so. Every man he sends home is a man back in the line against him, and he can afford to lose his own in our camps sooner than let ours go. It is not cruelty. I wish it were. Cruelty you could appeal to. It's arithmetic."

"So you mean to change the arithmetic," I said.

He smiled at me then, the way you smile at a pupil who has got there first.

"There is one man in the North," he said, "whom they would trade anything for."



"Do you know how he goes about Washington?" Booth said. "The President?"

"No."

"With less guard than a general." He began to walk, up and down under the hanging tobacco, three steps and turn, the way I would later see him walk

a stage. "He has a cavalry escort he dislikes and a few policemen he puts up with, and he slips both of them whenever he can. He rides out in the evenings. He goes to the theater. He drives out to the soldiers' hospitals on the edge of the city, on country roads, with one carriage and a driver. He doesn't like soldiers around him. He says so. He is a stubborn man."

"And?"

"And I mean to take him."

I did not say anything. The rain went on.

"Not hurt him," Booth said. "Take him. At some quiet place on some quiet road, with a handful of good men and fast horses. Out of the city before anyone knows he's gone. South across the Navy Yard Bridge, down through Prince George's and into Charles County." He stopped walking and looked at me. "On roads you know in the dark. From one safe house to the next. Across the Potomac by night, in a boat that's waiting. Into Virginia, and on to Richmond."

"And then?"

"And then the government in Richmond holds him. Safe, and comfortable, and treated like the President he is. And it offers to give him back." He smiled. "In exchange for every Southern prisoner in every Northern camp."

"Every one," Booth said. "Point Lookout. Elmira. Camp Douglas. All of them, home by the spring. Your cousin home for planting." He took a step toward me. "Fifty thousand men back in the line, Kit. The North would have to talk. They'd have to. And a war that ends in talking is not a war that ends in Richmond burning."

"And if the President is hurt?"

"He won't be." He said it with complete certainty. "He can't be. A dead President is worth nothing to anybody. He'd be a martyr, and they'd hang every man in Maryland for it, and they'd be right to. A live one is worth an army." He spread his hands. "No one is to be hurt. I've told every man I've spoken to the same thing. You have my word."

I believed him. I have heard a great many men give their word, in a great many lives, and I know the sound of a man who means it. He meant it. And

it was a good plan. I stood in that barn and looked for the flaw in it, and I could not find one.



“Why me?” I asked him.

He had thought about that too. He had thought about everything.

The route, he said, ran within a few miles of our door. It ran along roads I had known since I was a boy, and I had just shown him in November that I knew every one of them, which roads flooded, which ones the soldiers watched, which ones a wagon could use in the dark. A house on the route with a wounded veteran in it was a house the provost men would search politely and leave. A man on a crutch was a man nobody looked at twice. “They’ll look at a boy with two good legs,” he said. “They’ll never look at you.”

And he said that he had watched me in November, and that I was not what I seemed.

“I don’t know what you are,” he said. “I thought at first you were only a boy the war had broken. But you listened to every question I asked you on that fence, and you understood why I asked it, and you answered as if you didn’t. I need men who can think. I have enough men who can ride.”

I did not answer for a long time.

The rain came down on the barn roof. Somewhere out in the yard Hester was calling the chickens in, in the voice she used for them, which was the only voice she ever raised.

I thought about Ned.

I had never met Ned. That is the truth, and it is the part I have never been able to explain to anyone. The boy whose body I was living in had grown up with him, and gone across the river with him, and fought beside him, and I had none of it. Only the letters. The pencil. *I am sorry to be so much trouble.* And my mother’s hand going to her apron pocket, over and over, all that fall.

I knew what that second letter meant, and I knew that a plan made in December would come too late for him, or very nearly. But there were two more boys from our company in that camp, and thousands of other women’s

sons, and if there was any chance at all for Ned, it was not going to come from waiting on Grant. It would have to come soon, and it would have to come from somebody doing something.

I thought about the other side of it, too. I am not a fool, and I was not a fool then. There were Union men in Southern camps. Everybody knew about Andersonville, down in Georgia, where the Yankee prisoners were dying faster than at any camp in the North. If the arithmetic was cruel, it was cruel in both directions, and a trade would send those men home too. Booth said that himself, when I raised it. I think he believed it mattered. I think he believed it mattered a little less.

And I thought about the tall man on the wall at Fort Stevens.

I am not a prophet. I have told you that. I did not know how the war would end, or when, or how many more men would die before it did. I only knew what I could see. And what I could see, that December, was a plan in which no one was meant to die, which might bring fifty thousand men home, which might end a war by talking. Against it, one stubborn man would be taken from his carriage by force and frightened, badly, for some weeks.

I have made worse trades, in other lives. I have made better ones.

“What would you need from me?” I asked.



He did not need much, at first. That is how these things begin.

He needed to know the roads. So in the evenings, while my mother thought we were talking about horses, I drew them for him on the backs of old tobacco receipts: the road south from the Navy Yard Bridge, the tavern at Surrattsville, the turn toward Bryantown, the long way around the swamp, the farms where a man could be hidden, and the landing places on the river where the boats went across at night. When he asked who took people across, I told him there was a fisherman down by Pope's Creek named Jones, whom everyone said had put half the Confederate mail across that river, and whom you would never in your life get to admit it. He needed to know whose hous-

es were friendly and whose were not. He needed a place to rest a horse, if it came to that.

He was going back to Washington before Christmas, he said. There was a young man there that Dr. Mudd had promised to introduce him to, a courier who carried letters back and forth to Richmond and knew every road between. He would write to me. I was to answer him at the National Hotel, where he kept a room.

“And your mother?” he asked.

“My mother,” I said, “thinks you’ve come to buy a horse.”

He laughed at that. Two days later he bought a horse at last, from Dr. Mudd’s next-door neighbor, a man named Gardiner, as if to prove me right. It was a big dark bay, and it was blind in one eye. Everyone in the county knew about it by the end of the week, because it was a poor horse for a rich man to buy, and nobody could understand why a man who rode like that would want it.

I would see that horse again.

On his last evening in the county, he stood on our porch in his fine coat, with the rain finally stopped and the fields gone blue in the cold, and he shook my hand.

“Home for planting,” he said.

“Home for planting,” I said.

Lottie watched him ride away from the upstairs window. My mother came out onto the porch and stood beside me, and put her hand in her apron pocket, and asked me what we had talked about all that time.

“Horses,” I said.

It was the first real lie I told in that life. Everything before it had only been pretending to be someone. This one was mine.

Point Lookout

He walked me out to the car at four o'clock, slowly, with one hand on the porch rail going down the steps. The light was already going. Somebody down the road was burning leaves, and the smoke hung low over the fields and made everything smell like the end of the year.

"How is your daughter?" he asked.

It was the kind of thing people asked. I nearly said *fine*, the way you do. But it had been a long day of listening to him, and he had listened to me at lunch the week before, and I found that I wanted to answer properly.

So I told him. I told him that Freda was good. That she was taking chemistry this year with a teacher named Mr. Ostrowski, who wore a bow tie every single day and had once set his own sleeve on fire in front of the class, and that Freda, who had said all through ninth grade that she hated science, now came home and explained things to me about moles and molecules whether I wanted to hear them or not. Last week it had been a long complaint about the scale at her bench, which read everything about two percent heavy, so that her whole lab came out wrong and she had to write an extra paragraph at the end explaining why. That she had grown two inches since spring and none of her jeans fit. That she had started doing her homework at the kitchen table instead of in her room, which was new, and which I was not complaining about, because it meant I got to see her. That every light in the house was on whenever I came home, like Freda was expecting a party.

"And her phone buzzed all through dinner on Tuesday," I said. "She turned it face down on the table without looking at it. She's been doing that. I

thought, well, at least she's not texting at the table. I've been trying to get her to stop that for three years."

He had stopped at the bottom of the steps. He was looking at me in the way he had, the mechanic listening to the engine.

"She knows what it is," he said.

"What?"

"When the phone buzzes. She doesn't need to look, because she already knows what it will say. And she doesn't want to read it." He said it gently. "Somebody is saying things to your daughter that she doesn't want to hear, and she doesn't want to be alone with them. That's why she works at the kitchen table now, where you are. And it's why every light in the house is on when you come home."

I stood very still by the car.

The thing about the lights had been a joke, one line in a long list, the way you say things about your children. I had not thought about it twice. He had picked it out of everything else I said and put it next to the phone.

"You don't know her," I said.

"No," he agreed. "But you do. And you'd noticed already, or you wouldn't have told me about the phone. You'd have told me about the chemistry teacher and stopped there."

I did not answer that. I got into the car. He stood at the bottom of the steps with his hands in his cardigan pockets, and when I had turned the car around on the gravel, he lifted one hand, and I lifted mine, and drove away down the road through the smoke.



I did not say anything to Freda that night.

All the way home, two hours, with the radio off, I had thought about it. I had thought about sitting her down and asking straight out, *Is someone bothering you?* It was easy to picture exactly how that would go. Freda would say *no, Mom*, in the voice that meant the conversation was over, and go to her room, and shut the door, and take her homework with her. And then she would not

be at the kitchen table anymore. And whoever it was would have her all to themselves.

So I came in, and said hello, and hung up my coat, and did not look at the phone lying face down beside the chemistry book. Freda had made pasta. There was some left in the pot for me, with a plate on top to keep it warm, which was not a thing Freda had ever done before. I ate it standing at the counter and said it was very good, which it was.

Then I got out my own laptop and sat down at the kitchen table across from my daughter, and went to work.



Point Lookout was real. I had known it would be.

It was all there, the way everything was always there, a few clicks down: the long peninsula between the Potomac and the Chesapeake, and at the very bottom of it, where the two waters met, a flat, sandy point that was now a state park, with campsites and a fishing pier and a lighthouse. People went there on weekends to catch rockfish. There were photographs of families on the beach.

In 1863 the Union had put a prison camp there. It was built to hold ten thousand men. At times it held nearly twice that. There were no barracks, only tents, on open sand, behind a high board fence, with water on three sides. Men wrote about the heat in summer and the wind off the bay in winter, about the bad water, about the rations. The exchange of prisoners had broken down in 1863, and after that, the men who went in mostly stayed until the war was over, or until they died.

About a mile up the road from the park, beside the highway, there was a tall granite obelisk. The United States government had put it up in 1911. It said that three thousand three hundred and eighty-four Confederate prisoners had died at Point Lookout and been buried there, and that their graves had been moved, more than once, and could no longer be told apart. They were all together now, under the grass by the road. Their names were on bronze plaques around the base.

Other websites gave other numbers, some of them much higher. None of them agreed with each other.

I sat back.

None of it proved anything. That was the first thing I wrote in my notebook, because it was the thing I needed to remember. Everything he had told me about Point Lookout was on the first page of results. A man with ten thousand books and a lot of time could have read all of it in an afternoon. He could have read it forty years ago. He could have built a whole life, a whole Kit Keene, on top of an afternoon's reading, and believed it by now.

But there were records. There were always records. That was the other thing I knew.

The prisoner-of-war records were at the National Archives, and somebody had scanned a great many of them, and a genealogy company had put them online behind a paywall, at twenty-nine ninety-nine a month. A month ago I would not have spent thirty dollars to find out anything at all. For a while I looked at the button. Then I paid it.

I searched for *Carroll*, for the boy Ned had written about, *Jem Carroll died of the flux on Tuesday*. There were more Carrolls at Point Lookout than I could check in a night, from Virginia and North Carolina and Maryland and Georgia, Jameses and Johns and a Jeremiah and several with only an initial. Any of them could be Jem. None of them had to be.

Then I searched for *Keene*, and there were Keenes, too, but no Christopher, and then I stopped and made myself think it through. Kit had never been at Point Lookout. Kit had been shot outside Washington and carried home in a wagon under a load of potatoes. If there had ever been a Christopher Keene, he would not be in these records at all. The one who would be was the cousin.

And I did not know the cousin's last name. Ned had called Kit's mother *Aunt Margaret*. He could have been a Keene, if he was the son of her husband's brother. He could just as easily have been anything else.

I wrote it down: *Ned's last name?* And underneath it, smaller: *Would a real one know? Ask him. Watch how fast he answers.*



"Is that him?"

Freda had come around the table and was reading over my shoulder. I had not heard her get up.

“Is that who?”

“The guy. Your guy. The Confederate.” Freda leaned closer and read the screen. “Point Lookout. Is that where he was?”

“His cousin. He says.”

“Oh.” Freda read a little more, frowning. “That’s so many people.” She was quiet for a moment. Then she said, “Did the cousin die?”

“I don’t know yet. He hasn’t told me.”

“You should ask him.” Freda straightened up. “Actually, don’t ask him. Let him tell you. You always say that, people tell you more if you wait.”

I looked up at her.

“I do say that,” I said.

“You say it all the time.” Freda went back around the table and sat down and picked up her pencil. The phone lay beside her chemistry book, face down, and it buzzed once, and she did not look at it. “Tell me if the cousin dies, okay?”

“Okay.”

We worked on, across the table from each other, until nearly eleven. Freda did her chemistry and I did nothing useful at all. I read about Point Lookout. I read about the exchange of prisoners, and why it had stopped, and who had stopped it. I read the same page about the obelisk twice. The phone buzzed three more times. Freda did not turn it over, and I did not look at it, and neither of us said anything about it, and every light in the house stayed on.

When Freda finally went up to bed, she stopped in the kitchen doorway.

“Night, Mom.”

“Night, baby.”

“Don’t call me baby.”

“Night, Freda.”

Freda almost smiled, and went up. I sat for a while longer, in the bright kitchen, with the laptop open in front of me and the house quiet. Then I turned off the lights, one by one, all of them, and went up too.

H Street

On the drive up I had decided how I would do it. I would not lead into it. I would not give him time.

So I set out the two recorders, and said the date and the time, and before he had quite settled in his chair, I said, “What was Ned’s last name?”

“Hurley,” he said.

He did not pause. He did not look at the ceiling the way people do when they are making something up, or at the floor the way they do when they are trying to remember. He said it the way you would say the name of the street you grew up on.

“Edward Hurley. His mother was Margaret’s younger sister, Ann. She married a Hurley from St. Mary’s County, a waterman, and died when Ned was small, and Ned was more or less raised at the Keenes’ after that. That’s why he called her Aunt Margaret and wrote to her instead of to anyone else. There was no one else.” He tilted his head. “You won’t find him as Edward, if you’re looking. The clerks at the camps wrote down whatever they heard. He’ll be Ned, or E., and they spelled Hurley three different ways.”

I wrote it all down. I could feel him watching me write it.

“You’ve been looking,” he said. It was not a question.

“I looked up Point Lookout.”

“And?”

“And it’s real,” I said. “And it’s on the first page of the internet, and anyone could have read it.”

“Yes,” he agreed, as if that were the right answer, and seemed pleased with me.

I wanted, very much, to ask him the next thing. *Did Ned come home?* It was right there. But I heard Freda in my head, *let him tell you*, and closed my mouth and waited.

He smiled a little, as though he knew exactly what I was not asking.

“In January,” he said, “I went to Washington.”



• RECORDING · JANUARY TO MARCH 1865

I told my mother I had found work in the city. It was nearly true.

The farm needed money more than it needed a lame boy. There was no cash for feed, no one to hire, and no crop worth selling until the tobacco went to market in the spring. Washington in the last winter of the war was full of work, and full of wages, and whatever I earned there I could send home. The government had grown enormous. Every office needed clerks, every hospital needed orderlies, every stable needed a man to muck it out. A Maryland farm boy with a bad leg and a decent hand could find something. If anyone asked about the leg, I was to say a wagon had rolled over it at harvest. Nobody in Washington knew that Kit Keene had ever crossed the Potomac. He had never been captured, so he had never been paroled, and the only papers with his name on them were muster rolls in a Confederate office somewhere in Richmond, where no Union clerk could read them. As far as the government was concerned, I was only a farm boy who limped.

I took a room in a tall narrow house near the Navy Yard, with a family from Charles County who knew my mother's people and asked me nothing at all. I found work copying invoices for a lumber merchant on the waterfront. And every day, on my way to work and on my way home, I walked past the end of the Navy Yard Bridge, and I watched the soldiers who guarded it.

That was my part. Booth had said so. Everything else could be planned in a parlor, but somebody had to know that bridge. What time the guard changed. How many men were on it at night. Whether they stopped every

wagon or only the ones that looked like trouble. Whether they were bored. I watched them for two months, through the mud of a Washington winter, which was mud from one end of the city to the other and came up over your boots on the Avenue itself, and I wrote down what I saw on the backs of the lumber merchant's invoices, in a code that was only a list of prices, and I found out they were very bored indeed.

In February, the exchange started again.

After nearly two years, the two governments came to terms, and the boats began to carry prisoners down the Chesapeake and up the James River to be traded. The first men from Point Lookout went in the middle of the month. My mother wrote to me the week it was in the newspapers. She wrote in a hand I hardly recognized, it was so quick. *They are sending them home, Kit. Ned will be on the next boat.*

He was not on the next boat. Or the one after. They went by lists, and nobody would tell a family whose name was on which list, or why. Every week my mother wrote to me, and every week the letter ended the same way: *Not yet.*

The week the first boats went, I stood at the end of the Navy Yard Bridge with my invoices in my pocket and did the sum that Booth had done for me in the barn. The plan was to force a trade. Now there was a trade, and nobody had forced anything. Grant had simply changed his mind. *Home for planting*, Booth had said to me on our porch, and it looked, that week, as if Grant might send Ned home for planting without us.

I told myself that the plan was still needed. That a few boats were not all the camps. That the exchange had stopped before and could stop again. All of that was true. But I noticed, even then, that I was telling it to myself rather often. And I noticed that I had not gone to Booth and said any of it. I watched the guard change, and wrote down the time, and went home.



Booth took me to H Street for the first time in the middle of February.

It was a plain brick house with three stories and an attic, on a plain street a few blocks from the Patent Office, with steps up to the front door. He

knocked, and the woman who opened it had a round, pleasant face, and dark hair parted in the middle, and a rosary in the pocket of her apron. She looked at Booth with a kind of fond exasperation, the way you look at a nephew who is charming and never on time.

“Mrs. Surratt,” Booth said on the step, before we had gone in, “this is Kit Keene. Margaret Keene’s boy, from Bryantown.”

Her face changed.

Her name, Surratt, meant nothing to me. I have told you the rule: never say a name first, and never pretend to know more than you do. So I smiled, and waited, and let her tell me.

“The boy in the potatoes,” she said. “At the tavern, in the summer. I never saw your face, only the sacks, and your mother’s. I gave her blankets for you.” She took my hand in both of hers. “Well. Look at you. Walking.”

It was the widow from Surrattsville. Her name was Mary Surratt. She had come to the city that autumn to take in boarders, and in December she leased the tavern out, and this was her house.



I had stopped writing.

“Mary Surratt,” I said. “The one they hanged.”

“Yes.”

I knew the name the way everyone knows it, from a line in a history book: the first woman the federal government ever executed. I had never once thought of her as someone who opened a door, or had a face, or gave a stranger’s mother two blankets on a hot day.

“You knew her,” I said.

“I ate at her table.” He was looking at the notepad, not at me. “You’re going to ask me whether she knew what they were planning. Everyone who has ever heard of her asks that. I’ll tell you what I thought that first night. Later, I’ll tell you what I came to think, and they aren’t the same, and I’d ask you not to hurry me from one to the other.”

I thought about hurrying him. Then I picked up my pen.



• RECORDING · FEBRUARY 1865

I want to tell you exactly what I thought of her that first night, because a great deal came to depend on it later, and because I have had a long time to wonder whether I was right.

I thought she was kind. I thought she was devout; she went to Mass every morning at St. Patrick's, a few blocks away, and the rosary was worn smooth. I thought she was a widow who had been left with debts by a husband who drank, and who was doing what she had to do to keep her children fed. And I thought she was a woman who had learned, over a long time, exactly which questions not to ask. Men came and went from her house at all hours. Her son rode off to Richmond and came back with papers sewn into his boots. She served them all supper and asked them how the weather had been on the road.

She knew. That is what I thought, that night. I did not know yet how much.



Her son was in the parlor. He was the courier Dr. Mudd had promised to introduce to Booth before Christmas, the young man who knew every road between here and Richmond. John Surratt was twenty years old, tall and very thin, with a sharp face and a little pointed beard he was plainly proud of. He had been a courier for the Confederacy since he was seventeen, carrying letters across the river and back, and he had never once been caught, and he could not stop telling you so. Not in words. In the way he sat, and the way he checked the window, and the way he lowered his voice to say ordinary things. John Surratt loved a secret more than he loved any cause a secret could serve. I have met that kind of man in every century. They are brave, and useful, and they will get you killed, because they cannot bear for anyone not to know how much they know.

The last time I saw John Surratt, he was standing on a stage in Rockville, Maryland, more than five years later, selling tickets to all of this. He never

said my name.

A little after we sat down, another young man came down the stairs with a newspaper and settled by the lamp. He had not been in the hall when Booth said my name at the door, and nobody introduced him, which is why I noticed him. His name, I learned later, was Louis Weichmann. He had been at school with John, and he boarded in the house and shared John's room, and he worked as a clerk in the War Department, in the office of the Commissary General of Prisoners. He was plump and soft-spoken and polite, and he said good evening to Booth, and to me, and went back to his newspaper.

He did not turn a page for the next half hour.

I watched him not turn it. He was listening to every word. He was not one of us, and he was not against us. He was a young man who had put himself in a room where interesting things were said, and who was remembering all of them, and who had not yet decided what he would do with what he remembered. I thought, *if this goes wrong, that one will talk*. I did not think it as a prophecy. I thought it the way you notice that a bridge rail is loose.

Walking back down H Street in the cold, I told Booth what I thought of Weichmann. He stopped under a streetlamp and laughed.

"Weichmann?" he said. "Weichmann is John's oldest friend. He's harmless."

"He's a clerk in the War Department," I said, "and he shares a room with a Confederate courier. Nobody is harmless who is in both of those places at once."

It was only later, lying awake in my narrow room by the Navy Yard, that I understood what office that was. The Commissary General of Prisoners. The office that kept the lists: every prisoner in every Northern camp, his name and his regiment and where he was held, and whether he was sick, and whether he was dead. My mother had written to that office twice already, that winter, in her best hand, and had never had an answer. Weichmann sat at a desk in that office every day. He could have found Edward Hurley of St. Mary's County in an afternoon. He could have told my mother whether Ned was on a list, or when.

I never asked him.

I wanted to. I lay there and wanted to more than I have wanted most things. But to ask, I would have had to give him my name, and Ned's, and my mother's, and the name of our county, and tell him why a farm boy with a limp cared so much about one prisoner at Point Lookout. And I had already decided that Weichmann was the one who would talk. So I did not give him my name. Not then, and not ever. From that night on, when I was in that house, I made sure that nobody said it where he could hear.

I chose the plan over my cousin. I did not put it to myself that way at the time. I have put it to myself that way since, a great many times.

But all of that was later. That night Booth only put his arm through mine, and said I was a gloomy devil and he was glad to have me, and talked about something else.



The others I met one at a time, over the next weeks.

George Atzerodt was a German, a carriage painter from Port Tobacco, down in our own county, with a thick accent and a bad beard and a laugh that was always a little too loud. He had spent the war rowing people across the Potomac at night, for money, spies and couriers and anyone who could pay, and that was why Booth wanted him: he knew the river, and he had a boat, or said he did. He drank. Mrs. Surratt would not have him in the house for long, because she found liquor bottles in his room. I liked him more than I should have. He was a man who would say yes to anything, cheerfully, as long as the thing was far away, and I thought, watching him, that if the thing ever came close, he would find he had somewhere else to be.

David Herold was twenty-two and looked sixteen. He had been a clerk in a drugstore, and he had grown up hunting partridges in the woods of Southern Maryland, and he knew those roads nearly as well as I did. That made us rivals, at first, in the way of young men. He would say *the road past Beantown*, and I would say *not in March, it floods*, and he would say *not if you take the ridge*, and Booth would laugh at us. He talked too much, and he

was a little in love with Booth, the way a younger brother is. There was no harm in him at all. I have thought about that many times.

Samuel Arnold and Michael O'Laughlen came down from Baltimore. They had been boys with Booth there, and both had served in the Confederate army, and both had come home. Booth had brought them in the summer before, long before me. O'Laughlen was small and dark and quiet and did what Arnold did. Arnold was the sensible one. He had a clerk's careful face and a soldier's impatience, and every time I saw him, he asked Booth the same question: *When?* He had been waiting since August. He was beginning to think it would never happen, and a part of him, I think, was beginning to hope so.

And then, in March, a giant came to the door.

He gave his name as Wood, the first time. The next time he came, Weichmann told me afterward, he was a Baptist preacher named Paine. His real name was Lewis Powell. He was twenty years old and over six feet tall, with shoulders like a doorframe, and he had been a Confederate soldier, and been wounded and captured at Gettysburg, and escaped, and ridden with the partisans in Virginia. He ate everything that was put in front of him, quickly, without looking up, the way men eat who have been hungry for a long time. He said almost nothing. When Booth spoke, Powell listened the way a good dog listens: completely, and without any thought of his own.

He was the only one of them who frightened me. Not because he was cruel. I never saw him be cruel. It was that there was nothing in him that would stop. Every one of the others had some small door in the back of his mind that he could go out of, if it came to that. Arnold's was his doubts, and Atzerodt's was his cowardice, and Herold's was his boyishness, and John Surratt's was his love of the game for its own sake. Powell did not have one. Whatever Booth asked, Powell would do, all the way to the end of it.

I noticed that Booth had noticed it too.



On the fifteenth of March, Booth gathered all of us together for the first and only time.

He took a private room upstairs at Gautier's, a fine restaurant on Pennsylvania Avenue, and ordered oysters and cigars and more to drink than anyone needed. That same night he had taken a box at Ford's Theatre, the President's own box, and sent John Surratt and Powell to sit in it and study it, with two girls from the boarding house along for cover. They came to Gautier's afterward, flushed and pleased with themselves, and John described the box to us the way you would describe a castle you meant to storm.

And then Booth told us the new plan.

He wanted to take Lincoln from the theater. In the box, during the play. Two men to seize him, one to gag him, and then lower him over the rail to the stage, carry him out the back door into the alley, and away. The audience would think it was part of the performance, he said, until it was too late. He was an actor. He knew that stage. He knew how long it took a crowd to understand what it was seeing.

He was magnificent, telling it. I do not think I have ever seen a man more alive. He walked up and down the little room with his cigar, lowering an invisible President over an invisible rail, and for a few minutes, I think, every one of us could see it.

Then Arnold put down his glass.

It was madness, Arnold said. A theater full of people. Gas lamps. Soldiers in the audience, half of them armed. A man of Lincoln's size, who would not come quietly, lowered twelve feet to a stage in front of a thousand witnesses, and then carried out through a door that anyone could run to. They would all be killed, or taken, before they reached the alley. If Booth had meant the road, the carriage, a quiet place in the country, then Arnold was still with him. But not this.

The room went quiet. Booth stopped walking.

Arnold told it afterward, in an account of his own, and I have read it more than once. He said that Booth said that any man who backed out now deserved to be shot. And that he, Arnold, said that two could play at that game.

I was in the room. That is about how it went. I would add only that when Booth said it, he was smiling, and that nobody laughed, and that I looked

across the table at Powell and saw that Powell was not smiling at all. He was looking at Booth, waiting to see if he meant it.

I spoke then. I had not meant to. I said that Mr. Arnold was right about the theater, and that the road was better, and that there were only two things we truly needed to know: when the President would next leave the city in his carriage, and whether the guard on the Navy Yard Bridge would stop a party of horsemen at night. And that I could tell them the second one already.

They all looked at me. Booth looked at me longest.

“Well?” he said.

“They won’t,” I said. “There’s an order that nobody crosses after nine o’clock at night. It’s written down, and the sergeants know it. But the war is nearly over, and they’re bored, and they’re watching for rebels coming into the city, not farm boys going home. A man riding south who says he’s going home to Maryland, they let him go. I’ve watched them do it.”

Booth began to smile again, slowly, and this time it was real.

I should have stopped there. But there was a thing I had been carrying for a month, and the wine had loosened it.

“And the exchange?” I said. “It’s started again. They’re sending men home from Point Lookout every few weeks. My mother reads the lists.”

The smile did not go anywhere. Booth only waved his cigar, as if I had mentioned the weather.

“A few boatloads,” he said, “when it suits Grant. It’s a Yankee trick, Kit, to make us feel grateful while they finish us. They’ll stop it again the day it stops suiting them.” He leaned on the table toward me. “We’re past trading prisoners. Take him, and the North has to talk to us, and the war ends. That’s what this is for now.”

It was not the reason he had given me in the barn.

I noticed it. And I told myself it was the same reason, only bigger, the way a man’s reasons grow when the stakes do. I have told myself that sort of thing in a great many lives. I am nearly always wrong.

“The road, then,” Booth said, and raised his glass to Arnold, and Arnold, after a moment, raised his.

The next day, word came. The President was to drive out to a hospital at the edge of the city on the afternoon of the seventeenth, to see a play performed for the wounded soldiers. On a quiet road. In his carriage. With almost no guard.

We had our chance.



He stopped there. The light outside had gone gray.

“You’ll look for me,” he said, “in what Weichmann told the court, and in what Arnold wrote down afterward. You’ll look carefully, because that’s what you do.”

“Yes.”

“You won’t find me. Nobody mentions me.” He turned the pencil over. “I kept my name out of Weichmann’s hearing, from that first night on. That was never enough, and I knew it; he had seen my face, and the cane. So I came to H Street as little as I could, and when I saw Booth, I saw him at the National, where nobody from that house was listening. And the ones who did know me had every reason to leave me out. Naming a man the government didn’t know about only made the plot bigger, and them guiltier.” He set the pencil down. “Now you know part of why.”



The house is still there. I looked it up that night, at the kitchen table, with Freda across from me doing her homework.

It was not 541 anymore. The city had renumbered the streets long ago, and it was 604 H Street now, in the middle of Chinatown, with a restaurant on the ground floor and a historical marker by the door. I had walked past it a hundred times. I had eaten there once, years ago, with people from the paper, and never looked up.

Then I did what I had come home meaning to do, and looked for Edward Hurley.

It was harder than I expected. Some of the Point Lookout records were on-line and some were not, and the ones that were had been typed up from handwritten lists by volunteers, and the index stopped and started. I found Hurleys. I found a Hurly and a Hurlee and an E. Hurley with no county beside it, which could have been anyone at all. The register for that winter, the site said, was one of the reels nobody had scanned yet. It was on microfilm at the National Archives, on Pennsylvania Avenue. I looked at the map. It was twenty minutes from my front door.

On the calendar, in the next free morning, I wrote: *Archives. Hurley.*

"Did the cousin die yet?" Freda said, without looking up.

"He hasn't said."

"You didn't ask him?"

"I didn't ask him."

Freda looked up then, and gave me a small, approving nod, like a teacher, and went back to her homework.

The phone lay face down beside the chemistry book. It buzzed once, a little after nine. Freda turned it over, and read whatever it was, and I watched her face go still and shut. Then Freda turned it face down again and picked up her pencil and wrote something very carefully in the margin of her worksheet, and did not look at me, and I did not look at her.

Somebody is saying things to your daughter.

I turned the page of my notebook, and did not turn it back, and did not ask.

The National

The client's question came on Tuesday, like the first one. It was one line.

Please ask the gentleman whether he ever went to the National Hotel.

I looked it up before I did anything else. The National had been the grandest hotel in Washington before the war, on Pennsylvania Avenue at Sixth Street, a short walk from the Capitol. Congressmen lived there. So did John Wilkes Booth, whenever he was in the city, in room 228. The building had been torn down in 1942.

So it was not an odd question at all. It was the most natural question in the world. Booth lived there, and the old man said he had been one of Booth's men.

I read it again anyway. It had taken the client two weeks of silence to ask it.

I had also called the National Archives. You could not simply walk in and ask for microfilm, it turned out. You needed a researcher card, and to get one you had to sit through an orientation, and the next orientation with a free seat was the following Monday. I put it on the calendar under *Archives. Hurley.* and felt, absurdly, as if the building were stalling me on purpose.



On Thursday I set out the recorders, said the date and the time, and read him the question.

"The National," he said. "Yes. Many times."

He did not look at the mantel this time. He looked at me, and for a moment I had the feeling that he was deciding something. Then he smiled and settled back.

“Tell your client yes,” he said. “And I’ll tell you about it. I think it’s what he wants to hear.”



• RECORDING · MARCH 1865

The National Hotel was the kind of place where a farm boy with a cane was invisible, and I was glad of it.

It took up most of a block. It had a great lobby with marble floors and brass spittoons and a gallery around the top where ladies could look down on the men without being looked at, and a barbershop and a telegraph office and a bar that never closed. Half the Congress seemed to live there. So did a good many people who wished the Congress would go home to their states and stay there. It had always been a Southern sort of hotel. Before the war the planters had stayed there when they came to Washington, and some of their friends still did, and in the bar you could hear things said about the President, in low voices, that would have got a man arrested in most of the city.

Booth held court there like a prince. He knew every clerk and every porter by name. He tipped them all too much. When he came down the stairs, people turned to look, and he let them, and pretended not to notice. He had a way of standing in that lobby with one hand on the newel post that I think he had learned on a stage.

I went there to bring him the bridge. Every week or so I would come up Pennsylvania Avenue from the Navy Yard, with my lumber merchant’s invoices folded in my coat, and ask for Mr. Booth at the desk, and he would come down and take me into the dining room and order me a dinner I could not have paid for in a month. And while I ate, I told him what the guards had done that week, in a low voice, and he listened and smiled and said *good, good*, and ordered another bottle.

It was on my third or fourth visit that I noticed the bill of fare.

It was a card on the table, the day’s dishes written out by hand. Most hotels printed them. The National’s were written fresh every morning, and

whoever wrote them had the most beautiful hand I had seen in that life: even and flowing and perfectly clear, with long, looping capitals, the kind of writing that was taught in the best schools and hardly anyone ever mastered. I remember that I picked it up and turned it to the light, the way you pick up a good piece of workmanship.

“Isn’t it something,” Booth said. “The headwaiter says it’s one of the new men. He won’t tell me which. He says if the guests find out, they’ll all want letters written, and he’ll never see the man again.” He laughed. “I told him I’d pay double for a love letter in that hand. I could use one.”

I put the card down. But I did not forget it.



I saw Damon a few minutes later.

He came through the door from the kitchen with a tray on his shoulder, in the white jacket that all the National’s waiters wore, and he walked the length of the dining room and set down four plates at a table by the window without a sound, and turned, and saw me.

It was a small thing. Nobody else in that room would have noticed it. His step did not change and his face did not change. But his eyes went to me, and stopped, and I watched them take me in the way they had taken in Lottie’s newspaper that afternoon in the kitchen yard: quickly, the whole of me at once. My cane. My good coat, which Booth had paid for. The ink on my fingers from the lumber merchant’s invoices. And the man across the table from me, laughing, with his hand on a bottle of wine.

Then he looked away, and went back through the kitchen door, and was gone.

“Somebody you know?” Booth said. He noticed everything that had to do with faces.

“A man who used to work on our farm.”

“Ah.” Booth lost interest at once. “Well, he’s done better for himself than most of them. The National doesn’t take just anybody.”

Damon came back to our table twenty minutes later, to clear the plates. Booth was talking, as he always was, and he did not look up. The waiters at

the National were not people to him. They were a kind of weather that brought food.

I looked up. I said, quietly, "Damon."

He stopped, with my plate in his hand. For a moment I thought he would not answer me at all. Then he did.

"M-Mister. K-Keene."

It took him a long time. The first sound stuck, and he waited for it with his jaw set, patiently, the way you wait for a stiff door, and then pushed it through. I had not known. On the farm I had never heard him say more than a handful of words at a time. I had thought that was caution, or the habit of that place. Some of it had been. Some of it, I understood now, sitting there, was this.

"Is Miss L-Lottie well?" he said.

It was the last thing I expected him to ask. I think it was the only thing he could have asked that I would have answered without thinking.

"She's well," I said. "She reads too much."

Something happened at the corner of his mouth that on another man would have been the start of a smile. "She alw-ways did."

He did not ask about my mother. He picked up the rest of the plates, and went away with them, and he did not come back to our table again that night. Another waiter brought the coffee.

I had it before the coffee came. One of the new men, the headwaiter had said, and would not say which. A hand that had been taught, and taught well, and practiced for years. And a man I had watched in a kitchen yard reading a newspaper faster than I could, and hiding it, who had come to Washington four months ago and walked straight into the best hotel in the city. It was not a hard sum. Damon wrote the bills of fare.

I was right about that. What I made of it was the likely thing; that somebody had taught him as a boy, in secret, at a risk to both of them I did not like to think about, and that he had hidden it for twenty years on our farm and was only now, in a free city, letting it show a little, on a card nobody would ever connect to him. It was the likely answer. It was even partly true.



I saw him every time I went to the National after that. I made a point of it. I told myself it was only habit, that I always want to see.

He was always busy and always silent, a tall man in a white jacket at the edge of the room, never quite looking at anyone. Guests talked in front of him as if he were a chair. And I saw, because I was watching, that he was listening to every word of it.

He listened most of all to Booth.

I could hardly blame him. Booth was not a quiet man, in the dining room of the National, with a bottle in him. He said things about the President, in front of me and anyone else who happened to be near, that I will not repeat to you. He said them in the beautiful voice he had been trained to use in the largest theaters in America, and he laughed afterward, and the men at the tables around us laughed too, or pretended not to hear. Once, when he said something about what should be done with the President's new friends, the freedmen, Damon was pouring water at the next table. I watched the water stop. Only for a second. Then it went on pouring, and the glass filled, and Damon moved to the next one.

I thought I understood that. A man who had been freed four months before, by a vote of a few hundred in a state that did not want to free him, standing in a room full of men who wished he were not free, and listening to the most famous of them talk. Of course he listened. In his place I would have listened too. I would have remembered every face in that room.

What I did not think about, not once, was what he made of me. The Keene boy, who had come back from the war different, whom he had watched all that summer and fall and not liked what he saw. Sitting now at John Wilkes Booth's own table, in a coat Booth had bought him, talking low, with papers in his pocket.

He had known Kit Keene all his life, and had watched the one who came home from the war for four months, and he had never, I think, had any reason to believe a single good thing about either of them.

I did not think about any of that. My mind was on the bridge, and the guards, and what I would tell Booth the next time I came.



He stopped there, and was quiet for a while.

"The menus," I said. "The handwriting."

"Yes?"

"You worked it out that night. That it was him."

"Before the coffee came."

"Then what did you get wrong?" I looked at my notes. "You said it was partly true."

He looked down at his notepad, and his pencil moved a little, going over something already drawn.

"The likely answer is nearly always the right one," he said. "That's what makes it dangerous. You stop looking the moment you have it." He smiled slightly. "I had it. So I stopped looking."

On the drive home I tried to think of a way to check the handwriting on a bill of fare at a hotel that had been torn down eighty years ago, and could not think of one, and was annoyed with myself for trying.

The Seventeenth

It rained the whole way up. By the time I reached the gravel road it had settled into the steady kind of rain that meant it was not going to stop, and he met me on the porch with an umbrella big enough for three people and walked me in under it.

I had my researcher card now. On Monday morning I had sat in a basement room at the National Archives, watching a video about how to handle old paper, and come out with a laminated card and a terrible photograph of myself. The reel I needed was kept in the stacks and had to be pulled for me. It would be ready the next Tuesday.

I did not tell him any of that. I set out the two recorders and said the date and the time, and then said, “March the seventeenth.”

“You looked it up.”

“Anyone who reads about the kidnap plot finds it. It’s the day it was supposed to happen.”

“Yes,” he said. He was quiet a moment, listening to the rain. Then he picked up his pencil. “I spent it under a bridge.”



• RECORDING · MARCH 17, 1865

Booth’s note came to the lumber yard at ten in the morning, carried by a boy who would not wait for an answer. It said, in his big, careless hand, *This afternoon. Your post. Bring the second horse.*

That was all. That was all it needed to say.

The President was to drive out that afternoon to Campbell Hospital, on the edge of the city to the north, to see a play performed for the wounded. Booth and the others would wait on the road near the hospital. When the carriage came, they would stop it, and take the reins, and one of them would climb inside with the President and keep him quiet, and they would drive south through the city as fast as the horses would go, and cross the Eastern Branch at the Navy Yard Bridge, and be into Maryland before anybody understood what had happened. Herold had gone on ahead, down the county road, to wait for them with what they would need.

My post was the bridge.

I was to be waiting on the far side, the Maryland side, with a fresh horse on a lead. When the carriage came across, I was to take them off the main road at once, onto the back ways I had drawn for Booth on tobacco receipts in December, the ridge road and the farm lanes and the long way around the swamp, where no cavalry patrol would think to look for a carriage. By morning we would be at the river.

I borrowed the second horse from the family I lodged with. I told them Booth wanted to buy it and would pay tomorrow. And a little after one o'clock, I led it across the Navy Yard Bridge, past the bored sentry, who did not even look at me, and found a place on the far bank, under the trees at the edge of the road, where I could see the whole length of the bridge and anyone coming across it.

And I waited.



I have waited for a great many things, in a great many lives. I have waited for battles and for births, and for ships that did not come, and once for three days in a cellar for a city to stop burning over my head. Waiting does not get easier. You would think it might. It only gets more familiar, the way a bad tooth does.

The afternoon went on. Wagons came across the bridge from the city, and the sentry waved them through, and I watched every one. Carts, a farmer's wagon full of empty barrels, two officers on horseback, a hearse. Every time I

heard wheels on the planks, my heart went up into my throat and stayed there until I saw what it was.

I tried to imagine it. I could not stop trying. The road by the hospital. The carriage slowing for the mud. Powell's great hand on the bridle. The tall man inside, in his black coat, looking up in surprise as the door opened. Frightened, badly, for some weeks. That was the trade I had made in the barn, in my own head. Fifty thousand men home, against one stubborn man frightened for some weeks.

I had not let myself imagine his face before. Sitting under those trees, I found I could not stop.

Three o'clock. The guard changed at the far end of the bridge, exactly when I had written down that it would.

The new sentry noticed me. The old one never had. This one was young, and his uniform still had the creases from being folded, and he walked the length of the bridge twice, looking at the trees where I sat. On the third time he came off the end of it and down the bank toward me with his rifle across his body, and I understood that a man who has been sitting under a tree for two hours with a second horse, saddled, on a lead, is a man a new sentry is going to ask about.

I had perhaps thirty seconds while he came down the bank. I used them to read him.

New uniform, so new to the army. A new man wants to be seen doing his job. He came toward me instead of calling out, so he was not frightened, only curious and a little proud of himself. His boots were caked to the ankle in red clay, so he had walked out that morning from the camp on the Maryland side, where the roads were worse than ours. And he had a good farm boy's walk, flat-footed, and when he passed my horse he ran his hand down its neck without thinking about it. He was from the country. He had horses at home. He missed them.

"What's the other horse for?" he said.

I did not tell him I was waiting for anyone. A man who says he is waiting for someone is asked who. I told him the horse was lame, and let him look.

He crouched and picked up the off foreleg, the way I had known he would, because he had horses at home, and he found the stone I had wedged between the shoe and the frog an hour before, because I knew the guard changed at three, and a fresh man looks at everything. He dug it out with his thumbnail and held it up and looked at me as if I were a fool.

"I didn't have a pick," I said. "I was letting her rest it. My brother'll kill me if she's lamed. It's his."

He laughed, and put the stone in my hand, and told me to walk her slow for a mile and she'd be fine, and went back up the bank to his bridge feeling that he had done his job, and a kindness besides.

That should have been the end of it. It would have been, if I had walked her slow for a mile. I did not. I could not leave my post. So I led her a little way down the road, where he could see me do it, and then back again, and sat down under the same trees.

Four o'clock. He noticed. He walked the bridge, and at the end of it he stopped, and looked down the bank at me for a long moment, and walked back. At half past four he did it again. The third time, he came down.

"Thought you were walking her home," he said.

"I'm waiting for my brother," I said. It was the one answer I had promised myself I would not give, and I heard myself give it. "She's his horse. He's coming out from the city with the wagon. I'm not to go home without him."

"What's his name?"

"Tom."

"Tom what?"

"Tom Kelly," I said, which was the first name that came, and belonged to nobody.

He looked at me, and at the horse, and up the road toward the city. He was not a fool. He was only young.

"Bridge closes going south at nine," he said. "Orders. If your brother's not across by then, the both of you can sleep on that side." And he went back up the bank, and this time, when he walked his bridge, he looked at me every time he turned.

Five o'clock. The light began to go.

And then I heard it. Heavy wheels, a long way off on the city side, coming fast, faster than anything had come all afternoon, and horses ahead of them. I was on my feet before I knew it. A closed carriage came onto the far end of the bridge, black, with its curtains drawn, and two riders in front of it, and it did not slow down for the sentry.

It was exactly what I had been told to wait for. My hands went to the lead rope and got the knot wrong, twice. I could hear my own heart over the wheels. I remember thinking, very clearly, that the man inside that carriage was about to look out through the curtain and see me, and that I would be the first face he saw in his new life as a prisoner, and that I had not decided what my face would do.

The riders were in blue. That was the first thing. Booth's men would not be riding ahead of it in Union blue. They were cavalry, with their sabers, riding easy, as if they had every right to the road, and the sentry did not stop them because he was saluting. The carriage came off the end of the bridge and past me close enough to touch, and the curtain swung open with the jolt, and inside there was a surgeon in a bloody apron, holding a lamp over a man on a stretcher.

An ambulance, going out to the camp on the Maryland side. That was all.

I sat down again under the trees, because my leg would not hold me, and the sentry at the end of the bridge watched me do it.

It was nearly dark when a single rider came across the bridge at a hard trot, and my heart went up again, and then I saw that it was John Surratt, alone.

He did not stop. He slowed only enough to lean down from the saddle as he passed, and I saw his face in the last of the light. He looked like a boy who had been slapped.

"He never came," John said. "He never came near the place. He went to the National instead." His voice cracked on it. "Go home, Keene. It's blown. Go home."

And he kicked his horse on, south down the dark road toward Surrattsville, and was gone.

"That your brother?" the sentry called down from the end of the bridge.

“No,” I said. “A neighbor. My brother’s not coming.” And I led the borrowed horse up the bank and back across the bridge toward the city, under his eyes, at a walk, the way an honest man walks, and I did not look back once. It was the longest walk of that day.



I did not go home.

I should have. Everything that was sensible in me said so. Instead I led that borrowed horse on through the streets of the Navy Yard, and up through the city toward Pennsylvania Avenue, because I had to know. I always have to know. It was more than a mile, and my leg had stiffened from the waiting, and I did not care.

It was full dark by the time I reached the National. The street in front of it was still busy: soldiers, a great many of them, in a cheerful mood, and people coming away from something in the way crowds do after it’s over. I asked a newsboy what had happened.

A regiment from Indiana, he told me, had captured a rebel flag at some fort in North Carolina, and today they had presented it to the governor of Indiana, who was staying at the National. And the President had come to see it done. He had come instead of going to some hospital, the boy said, because the governor was a friend of his. And at four o’clock he had come out on the balcony, right up there, and made a speech.

At four o’clock, I had been sitting under the trees by the Navy Yard Bridge, imagining his face.

I went around to the side of the hotel, where the kitchen was. I do not know why. I think I already knew who I would find there.

There were four or five of the waiters outside the kitchen door, in their white jackets, taking the air the way kitchen men do on a break, talking in low voices. They were talking about the President. I could hear it in the way they were standing before I could hear a word. Something had happened to them that afternoon, all of them, and they were still standing in the middle of it.

Damon was among them. He was not talking. He was listening to the others, with his arms folded, and his face in the light from the kitchen door was a face I had never seen him wear. On the farm it had always been shut. Tonight it was open. It was the face of a man who had heard something he had waited his whole life to hear said out loud.

Then he looked past the others and saw me.

I knew what he saw. I have thought about it many times since. A man he knew to keep company with John Wilkes Booth, standing in the dark at the side of Booth's own hotel, on the night the President had come there. Mud to the knees. The clay of the Maryland side on his boots, from a riverbank, not from any street in the city. Sweat on his face, in March. And a saddled horse on a lead beside him, fresh, with nobody to ride it.

A horse for someone who had not come.

His face closed. It closed the way I had seen it close in the kitchen yard, when he heard my crutch on the step: smoothly, completely, like a door.

He said something to the others, and they went in. He did not. He came a few steps toward me, into the edge of the light, and stopped.

"The P-President was here," he said. "This afternoon."

"I heard."

"He sp-spoke. From the b-balcony. About the rebels, and their p-plan to make soldiers out of their slaves." He looked at me steadily. "D-do you want to know what he said?"

I did not answer. He told me anyway.

"I have always thought that all men should be free; but if any should be slaves, it should be first those who desire it for themselves, and secondly those who desire it for others. Whenever I hear any one arguing for slavery, I feel a strong impulse to see it tried on him personally."

He said it all the way through without a single stumble. Every word. As clear as a bell, as if he were reading it off the page. I learned long after, from men who knew about such things, that it is often that way: that a man who cannot get his own words out can sometimes say another man's perfectly, all in one breath, as if they were a song.

He had heard it once, from the street below a balcony, a few hours before. And he had it word for word.

“G-good night, Mister Keene,” he said. And he went back in through the kitchen door, and shut it.

I stood there in the dark with the borrowed horse for a long time.



It fell apart after that, the way those things do, all at once and then slowly.

Arnold and O’Laughlen went home to Baltimore within the week. Arnold wrote Booth a letter at the end of the month, telling him to wait, to go and see how Richmond felt about it first, to do nothing rash. I did not know about that letter then. Everyone in the country knew about it a month later. The police found it in Booth’s trunk.

John Surratt rode south to Richmond on some errand of his own and was gone for more than a week. Atzerodt went back to drinking. Powell went back to wherever Powell went. Booth raged for a few days, and then went quiet, and then left the city for a while.

I went back to the lumber merchant’s invoices, and told myself it was over.

My mother’s letter that week ended the way they all did. *Not yet.*



He put the pencil down.

I knew that line. I had seen it before, printed large on a museum wall somewhere, one of those quotations they hang over a doorway. I had read it a dozen times and never once thought about who had been standing in the street when it was said.

“How do you know it word for word?” I asked. “It’s famous. It’s the kind of thing people put on posters.”

“I didn’t learn it from a poster,” he said. “But that wasn’t the point of the story.”

“What was the point?”

He looked at the window, at the rain running down it.

“He had heard the President of the United States say it,” he said. “Out loud. In the street, in front of everyone, about men like him. And I had spent that same afternoon sitting under a bridge, waiting to steal the man who said it.”

The Register

The National Archives building on Pennsylvania Avenue looks like a bank that has decided to become a temple. I had driven past it most of my life. On Tuesday morning I went in through the researchers' entrance on the side, showed my laminated card with its terrible photograph, put my bag in a locker because bags were not allowed, and was given a pencil, because pens were not allowed either.

The microfilm room was dim and cool and almost silent. There were rows of readers, big gray machines with screens like old televisions, and at most of them sat somebody bent close, turning a crank. A retired man was telling the desk clerk about his great-grandfather. A graduate student had three boxes of reels and the face of someone who had not slept. My reel was waiting for me at the desk. I threaded it the way the video had shown me, and turned the crank.

The pages went by in a gray blur and then slowed. They were registers. Big ledger books, photographed page by page a long time ago, with columns ruled by hand: name, rank, company, regiment, where captured, when captured, and at the end a wide column headed *Remarks*. The handwriting changed every few pages as one clerk went off duty and another sat down. Some of them wrote beautifully. Some of them I could hardly read.

The names were in rough alphabetical order, and there were so many of them. I had known the numbers from the website. Ten thousand men, twenty thousand. What I had not known was what it would be like to turn a crank for forty minutes and still be in the *Hs*.

I found the Hurleys at a quarter to twelve.

There were three. A John Hurley from Georgia, exchanged in March. A Hurley with no first name at all, only an initial I could not make out. And one line that stopped my hand on the crank.

Hurly, E. Pvt. A Virginia infantry regiment, a company letter, captured in May of 1864. And in a column I had not expected, somebody had written *resid. St. Mary's Co., Md.*

I sat and looked at it.

He had said the clerks spelled it three ways. He had said I would not find him as Edward. He had said St. Mary's County, a waterman's son, raised on his aunt's farm across the county line. It was all sitting there on the screen in a dead clerk's handwriting, the way he had told it.

I made myself move my eyes to the end of the line. The *Remarks* column.

Died Feb. 6, 1865. Chr. diarrhoea.

The flux. The thing that had killed Jem Carroll.

I wrote it down exactly as it was, spelling and all, the regiment and the company and the date. Then I sat with the pencil in my hand for a long time, in the dim room, with the gray page glowing in front of me.

It did not prove anything. I told myself that first, because it was true. Anyone could have found this. A man with a lot of time and an interest in the war could have sat at this same machine thirty years ago and found a private named Hurly who died of dysentery at Point Lookout, and built a whole family around him: an aunt, a cousin, a farm, a mother with a letter in her apron pocket. It would be a strange thing to do. People did strange things.

But on the drive home I found I was thinking about the date. The sixth of February. The first boats had taken men away from Point Lookout to be exchanged a week later, in the middle of the month. I had read that on the website. A week.



"Did the cousin die?" Freda said.

She said it without looking up, the way she had said it every night for weeks, the way you ask about the weather. Then she looked up, because I had not answered.

"Yes," I said.

Freda put her pencil down. "Oh."

"In February. At the camp. About a week before they started sending men home."

"Oh," Freda said again, more quietly. She was quiet for a moment. "Did he tell you?"

"No. I found it. At the Archives."

"So he doesn't know you know."

"No."

Freda thought about that. "Are you going to tell him?"

"No," I said. "I'm going to wait and see if he tells me. And what date he says."

Freda looked at me for a long moment, the way she sometimes did lately, as if she were seeing me from the outside for the first time.

"That's kind of cold," she said.

"It's careful."

"He's old, Mom. What if it's his real cousin, and it's sad for him?"

"Then he'll tell me."

"You're treating him like a story." She picked up her pencil again, and did not look at me.

I did not have an answer for that. I wrote the date on an index card, *Feb. 6*, and turned it face down, and put it in the back of my notebook, where I would not have to look at it.



On Thursday he talked for most of the morning about the week after the seventeenth: the plotters scattering, the letters from Baltimore, the lumber yard. I listened, and wrote, and did not ask about Ned.

I could see him noticing that I did not ask. Once he looked up from the notepad and studied my face for a moment, and I held still under it, and he looked down again.

After lunch, he told me.



• RECORDING · MARCH 1865

The letter came at the end of March. My mother sent it on to me in Washington with nothing of her own inside it. That was how I knew before I opened it.

It was in the same hand as Ned's December letter: small and upright and careful, in ink. The man who had written for Ned when Ned could not hold a pencil had written one more time, on his own account. He was a schoolmaster from Virginia, it turned out, and he had been in the next tent. He wrote that Edward Hurley had died on the sixth of February, of the flux, very quietly, in the night. That he had not suffered much at the end. That he had spoken often of his Aunt Margaret, and of a cousin called Kit, and of a farm near a swamp. That he had been buried with the others, near the water, and that the schoolmaster was sorry it had taken so long to write, but paper was hard to come by, and he had been waiting to be exchanged himself, so that he could post it from the South, where it would not be read by strangers first.

He had been exchanged in the middle of February. On one of the first boats. The sick were meant to go first, he wrote, and he believed that Ned's name would have been called.

I read it standing up, in the hall of the house by the Navy Yard, by the light from the street. Then I read it again. Then I folded it and put it in my coat, and I went out, and walked for a long time, I do not remember where.

I had known since December. I had known from the moment I saw that careful handwriting where Ned's big leaning pencil ought to have been. Knowing is not the same. I have known a great many things, in a great many lives, and it has never once been the same.



He stopped. Outside, somebody's dog was barking a long way off, and the woodstove ticked.

I did not reach for the notebook. There was no need. I knew what was on the card in the back of it, and I knew what Freda would say if she could see me

now.

“The sixth of February,” I said.

He looked at me for a long moment, the way you look at someone who has just done something you did not expect of them. Then he smiled.

“You found him,” he said.

“On Tuesday. At the Archives. *Hurly, E.* No *e.* St. Mary’s County.” I heard my own voice, and it was not quite steady. “Died February sixth. Chronic diarrhoea.”

“And you didn’t tell me.”

“No.”

“You waited to see what date I would say.” He nodded slowly. “That’s what I would have done.”

“It doesn’t prove anything,” I said. “You know that. Anyone could have found that line. You could have found it yourself, years ago.”

“Yes,” he said. “Anyone could. And if I had, I would have known the date too, wouldn’t I?” He did not sound disappointed. He sounded, if anything, pleased with me. “Good. Keep doing that.”



I wanted to leave it there. I found I could not.

“You knew in December,” I said. “You told me. You read that letter and you knew he was dying. And you still thought that kidnapping the President of the United States was the answer.”

“Yes.”

“You’re not stupid. I’ve spent seven Thursdays with you. You’re the least stupid person I’ve ever met.” I put my pen down. “So explain it to me. Not the arithmetic. Booth’s arithmetic. You. Why would a man like you walk into that?”

He was quiet for a long time.

“Because it made sense,” he said at last. “That’s the honest answer, and it’s the one nobody wants. You want me to tell you I was fooled, or angry, or young. The body was young. I was fooled, and I was angry. But I wasn’t stupid, and it wasn’t madness. Every step of it made sense from where I stood.”

He held up a hand and counted on his fingers.

“There were tens of thousands of men in those camps, on both sides, dying of what killed Ned. The one man who could end the exchange war was the President. He couldn’t be persuaded, and he couldn’t be voted out, because we had just watched him win. So you ask what can move him. And the answer, if you are a certain kind of clever young man in a certain kind of winter, is: take him. Not hurt him. Take him, and hold him, and trade him. It had been done before, with kings. Men have been ransomed for as long as there have been men.” He lowered his hand. “Every step of it made sense. And every step of it was a step further from anything a decent man would do. Both of those were true at once. That’s the part I want you to understand. Not that I was wrong. Anyone can be wrong. That I could see it all, clearly, and walk down it anyway.”

“Why?”

He looked at me, and for a moment he seemed about to say something else entirely. Then he looked at the window instead.

“Because I thought I could steer it,” he said. “I had done it before. Many times, in many lives: got inside something that was already moving, and leaned on it until it went a better way. Sometimes it worked. Sometimes it half worked. And a few times it went so badly wrong that I have spent whole lifetimes trying not to think about them.” He picked up the pencil again. “But you remember the times it worked. You always do. So I told myself that if I was inside, I could keep it a kidnapping. Keep anyone from getting hurt. I have been clever for a very long time, and clever men always think they can walk right up to the edge and stop.”

I wrote it down. On the drive home I thought about how sure he had been, and about Ned, and I could not decide which was sadder.

Five Hundred Guns

I had thought about it all week. On the eighth visit, before I had even taken off my coat, I said, “The drawings.”

He was setting down the tray. He stopped with it halfway to the table.

“The roads you drew for Booth,” I said. “On the tobacco receipts. In December, in your mother’s house. You told me you drew him the way south: the tavern, the swamp, the farms where a man could hide, the landing places on the river. In your own hand.” I sat down. “Booth kept everything. The police found Arnold’s letter in his trunk. It was in the papers within a week. It’s in every book.” I looked at him. “So where were your drawings?”

He set the tray down very carefully. Then he smiled, the real one, the one that took ten years off his face.

“You’ve been waiting all week to ask me that.”

“Since Tuesday.”

“Good,” he said, and sat down. “That’s the right question. That’s April the tenth.”



• RECORDING · APRIL 1865

The guns woke me.

It was not yet light. The first one shook the window in its frame and brought me up out of bed with my heart going before I knew where I was, and for a moment I was on the field in front of Fort Stevens again, with the sun on my face and somebody shooting at me. Then the second gun, and the

third. And I lay back down in the dark and listened, and counted, and understood.

They were coming from the Navy Yard, a few streets away, and from the forts around the city, and they were not coming at random. Each gun fired, and then the next, at the same slow, even pace, like a clock. Nobody fires like that at an enemy. That is how you fire when there is no enemy left, when you want the whole city to hear it and count.

I counted to a hundred and got up and dressed. The guns went on. By the time I was out in the street, it was full of people in their nightclothes and coats, and a man was shouting that Lee had surrendered, Lee had surrendered to Grant in Virginia yesterday, and it was over.

Five hundred guns, the newspapers said afterward. The Secretary of War had ordered it. Up by the President's house, around Lafayette Square, the windows broke.



I will not pretend to you that I felt only one thing that morning.

I stood in the street by the Navy Yard, with people I did not know shaking my hand and weeping and passing bottles, and I felt the war end in me like a fever breaking. It was over. Nobody else would lie in a ditch in Maryland with a belt around his leg. Nobody else would write home in pencil from a sand spit and die of the flux a week before the boat. I had wanted that more than I can tell you.

And I felt, under it, cold and clear, the other thing. That the plan was dead. There was no one left to trade prisoners to, and no Confederacy to hold a President for ransom, and no reason on earth for any of it anymore. Booth's great scheme was a pile of paper. And some of the paper was mine.

I stood there in the crowd with the guns going and thought about my drawings.

I had drawn Booth the whole road south, on the backs of my mother's tobacco receipts. The Keene farm was on them. Our lane was on them. Every friendly house between Washington and the river was on them, in my hand, on paper with my mother's name written at the top. And I knew Booth. He

kept everything. He kept letters from women he had forgotten and bills he would never pay, all together, in a big leather trunk in room 228 at the National. He was the most careless man with paper I have ever known. He thought that nothing could touch him. Actors often do.

If anything ever went wrong now, anything at all, the first thing anyone would open was that trunk.

I did not know yet what could go wrong. The plan was dead. But I have lived a long time, Ms. Barnett, and I have never once seen a man like Booth simply put a thing down because the reason for it was gone.



Later that morning the men from the Navy Yard came out of the gates with their band, hundreds of them, workmen in their aprons and shirtsleeves, and started up the Avenue toward the President's house through mud that came over their shoes, and half the Navy Yard neighborhood went with them. I went too. I did not decide to. The crowd simply took me, and by the time we reached the President's house there were thousands of us, packed across the lawn and into the street, calling for him.

A window over the door opened, and he appeared at it.

It was the first time I had been near enough to see his face. At Fort Stevens he had been a tall hat on a wall, and at the inauguration a small dark figure on a platform across a sea of mud.

He did not make a speech. He said he would make one later, if they came back, and that he did not want to spoil it by saying anything now. And then he asked the band to play "Dixie." The crowd didn't understand at first. You could feel them not understand. Then he told them, in a high, dry, country voice that carried to the back of that crowd without seeming to try, that he had always thought "Dixie" one of the best tunes he had ever heard, and that the other side had tried to take it for themselves, but that he had put the question to the Attorney General, and had been told it was now our lawful prize. That we had fairly captured it.

And the crowd laughed. Thousands of them. And the band played "Dixie," to the President of the United States, on the morning the war ended,

and I stood in the middle of all those Union people and heard it and could not breathe for a moment.

I thought: that is a man who has already forgiven us. And I had spent the winter planning to steal him.

I went to the National that night. The whole city was out. There were bonfires in the streets and rockets going up over the river, and bands on every corner, and I walked through all of it and hardly saw it.



Booth was in his room. He had been drinking all day. He was not loud, the way he usually was. That was the first thing that frightened me.

He was sitting in the chair by the window with the curtain pulled back, watching the rockets go up over the city, and he did not turn around when I came in. On the table beside him there was a bottle of brandy, most of the way down, and a pistol. It was a small pistol, a single-shot pocket pistol, the kind a gentleman carries, and it was lying there on the table next to the brandy as if it had been set down in the middle of a thought.

I looked at it and understood what kind of pistol it was. The kidnapping had been armed; there were carbines hidden in a ceiling at Surrattsville for the road south. But you cannot hold a carriage with a pistol that fires once, or keep a prisoner quiet with it. It is good for one thing only, at arm's length.

"Kit," he said, without turning. "Have you come to celebrate?"

"I came to see how you were," I said.

"I'm very well," he said. "I'm better than I have ever been." He laughed. It was a bad laugh. "You heard him? This morning? Asking for 'Dixie'? Our song. He's taken our song, Kit, and he's giving it back to us like a present. Like a man gives a bone to a dog."

"He was being kind," I said.

Booth turned around in the chair then and looked at me. I have had a long time to learn men's faces, and I can read most of them. His, that night, I could not read at all. That frightened me more than the pistol.

"Was he," Booth said. It was not a question.

He turned back to the window, and I sat down in the other chair, because I did not want to leave him alone with that pistol.

For a long time neither of us said anything. Then he began to talk, and none of it was about the kidnapping. It was about Rome.

“Do you know what they did to Brutus, Kit?” he said. “They cursed him for a season. That’s all. The men who kill a tyrant are honored for a thousand years.”

“Not in the play,” I said. “In the play they run him out of Rome, and he falls on his own sword in the last act. You were there. You played Antony.”

Booth laughed, and poured, and went on about Caesar, and I listened. He fell asleep in the chair a little after midnight, with the rockets still going up and the bottle empty. I told myself it was the brandy. I told myself it was an actor talking about a play he had been in. I have told myself a great many things.

When he was asleep, I opened the trunk.

It was not locked. Of course it was not locked. It was full, the way I had known it would be: shirts, costumes, a wig, a bundle of playbills, a box of cartridges, letters tied in bundles with string. I found my receipts in the second bundle, folded in half, between a bill from a tailor and a letter from a woman in Boston. Eleven of them. I counted them twice, because I had made eleven. The road south, the farm, the lane, the landing places, in my hand, on my mother’s paper.

There was another letter in that bundle, from a village outside Baltimore, in a hand I knew. It was signed *Sam*. It was Arnold’s, telling Booth to wait, to be careful, to see how Richmond felt first. I held it in my hand for a long moment. I could have taken that too.

I didn’t. It was not mine to take. That is what I told myself. The truth is that if I had taken everything, Booth would have noticed the next morning, and known who had been in his room. If I took only my own, eleven slips of paper out of hundreds, he would never know they were gone.

So I left Sam Arnold’s letter in Booth’s trunk, and I put my eleven receipts inside my shirt, and I closed the lid, and I let myself out.

In the corridor, at the top of the back stairs, a waiter in a white jacket was standing with a tray of empty glasses, as if he had been waiting there for somebody to come out of a room.

He did not say anything. Neither did I. I went past him and down the stairs with my eleven receipts against my chest, and I felt his eyes on my back the whole way down.



“You burned them,” I said.

“In the stove at the lumber yard, the next morning. All eleven.” He looked at his hands. “It’s why you won’t find the Keene farm in any book. It’s one of the reasons you won’t find me.”

“And Arnold’s letter.”

“Was in every newspaper in the country within the week. It helped put him in prison for four years.” He met my eyes. “You asked me if I was clever. I was clever that night. I made sure nothing would ever lead back to my mother’s house. I did it quickly and quietly and well. And I left a man I had drunk with, who had argued for the sensible road, to take what came.”

“You couldn’t have taken it. Booth would have known.”

“That was my reason,” he agreed. “It was a good reason. I’ve never been sure it was the real one.”

I wrote it down. Then I wrote underneath it, smaller: *Pistol. April 10. Check.*

The Last Speech

We ate lunch without talking much. I could tell he was somewhere else, and I let him be there. When we went back into the living room, he stood at the window for a while with his hands in his cardigan pockets, looking out at the field, before he sat down.

“The next night,” he said, “he gave the speech he had promised them.”



• RECORDING · APRIL 11, 1865

Booth came for me at the lumber yard at six o'clock. He was sober and freshly shaved and very cheerful, and that frightened me more than the brandy had.

“Come and hear the great man,” he said. “He’s going to tell us what he means to do with us.”

Powell was with him, a step behind, the way he always was, too big for his coat, saying nothing. And Herold came along too, trotting to keep up, talking. We walked up to the President’s house through streets still hung with flags from the night before, and bunting, and candles in every window. The whole city was lit. People had put candles in every pane of glass they owned, so that the houses seemed to be made of light.

The crowd on the lawn was bigger than the one that morning. It filled the grounds and ran out into the avenue, thousands of people, soldiers and clerks and families, and a great many Black men and women, standing together in a group near the front, dressed in their best, as if for church. Booth steered us

through the crowd until we were quite close, under the tall window over the north door, near the front. He wanted to see.

I saw Damon before the speech began.

He was standing with the others near the front, a little to one side, very straight, in a dark coat that was not a waiter's coat. He had come on his own time. He was watching the window the way you watch a door you have been waiting a long time to see open.

He had not seen us yet. I made sure to stand where Booth's shoulder was between us.



The window opened, and the President appeared at it, and the crowd roared so that you felt it in your chest.

He had a sheaf of papers in his hand. A man stood behind him and a little to one side with a candle, holding it up so that he could read. And every time he finished a page, he let it fall, and a small boy darted out from behind him and caught the pages as they came down, and gathered them up off the floor. His son, somebody near me said. Tad.

He read it. He did not orate. I had heard great speakers, in other lives, men who could make a crowd weep or riot, and I had heard Booth, who could do both before supper. This was not that. It was a tired man in a window reading a careful, difficult paper about Louisiana: how the state had written a new constitution, and whether it should be let back into the Union, and on what terms. Most of the crowd had come for a victory speech. They got a lawyer's argument. I felt them grow restless around me, and shift, and murmur.

Then he came to the part about the vote.

Some people were unhappy, he said, that the new government of Louisiana had not given the vote to the colored man. And then he said, in that same dry, reading voice, that he himself would prefer that it were given now to the very intelligent, and to those who serve our cause as soldiers.

It was one sentence in the middle of a long speech. He did not raise his voice for it. Half the crowd, I think, did not even hear it for what it was.

The group near the front heard it. I watched it go through them. Nobody cheered. It was too big a thing to cheer. A woman put her hand over her mouth. An old man took off his hat and held it against his chest, as if a flag were going by.

And Damon closed his eyes.

That was all he did. He stood very straight in his good coat in the candlelight and closed his eyes, the way a man does when he has been carrying something heavy a long way and has finally been told he can set it down. Not here yet. Not today. But the door was open. For the first time in his life, a President of the United States had stood at a window and said it out loud.

Beside me, Booth said, "That means citizenship."

He said a good deal more than that, in words I will not use in your house. And then he said, not loudly, but in the trained voice that could carry to the back of any theater in America without seeming to try:

"That is the last speech he will ever make."



I have told you that I was clever in that life. It did not take cleverness to understand that sentence. A child would have understood it. But I will tell you how it fell into place for me, standing there, because it all fell at once, and it was the worst moment of that life.

The pistol on the table the night before, the kind that fires once. I had carried one in another life. I knew how short its reach is: a few steps, no more. A man who carries one means to walk right up to someone, close enough to touch. The brandy, and the quiet, and the talk about Brutus. *The men who kill a tyrant are honored for a thousand years.* The kidnapping dead, and Booth not grieving for it at all, only waiting, the way an actor waits in the wings. And now this: the last speech he will ever make.

He was not going to take the President anywhere. There was nowhere left to take him. He was going to kill him.

I turned my head and looked at Powell. Powell was looking at Booth. He was not shocked. He was not anything. He was waiting to be told.

And past Powell, through a gap in the crowd that had opened when people shifted to leave, I saw Damon.

His eyes were open again. He was looking straight at us. At Booth, who had just said it, and at Powell beside him. And at me, standing at Booth's elbow, in the coat Booth had bought me, as close to him as a brother.

He had heard it. Booth's voice was made to carry, and it had. I saw on his face that he had heard every word, and I saw him look at me and put it together with everything else he had seen of me since the farm.

Then the crowd closed again, and he was gone.



I walked back down the avenue with them afterward. I laughed when Herold made a joke. I said good night to Booth at the door of the National and shook his hand.

I did all of that on purpose.

I lay awake all that night in my room by the Navy Yard, and I went through it the way I would go through any problem, one door at a time.

I could go to the police. And say what? That an actor, drunk and angry, had said something ugly about the President in a crowd? Half of Washington had heard somebody say something ugly about the President that week. The Provost Marshal had drawers full of such reports. They would ask me how I knew John Wilkes Booth so well. And the answer to that was a kidnapping plot, and the answer to that was a rope. For me, and for Arnold and O'Laughlen in Baltimore, and for a widow on H Street who had given my mother blankets, and for the people in Charles County who had hidden me, and for my mother. And they would still not have Booth, because Booth had done nothing yet, and he was the most famous young actor in America, and he would laugh at them.

I could run. Go home, and sit on the porch in Bryantown, and wait, and read about it in the newspaper.

Or I could stay exactly where I was. At Booth's elbow. The man he trusted, the man who knew the roads. If he meant to do it, he would need the others, and he would need a time and a place, and he would tell me, because I

was one of his. And then I would know when, and where, and who. And I could stop it. Not with the police. Myself. Quietly. The way I had taken back my drawings: so that nobody would ever know anything had happened at all.

It was the cleverest of the three. I lay there until the window went gray and could not find the flaw in it.

There was one. There were two, in fact. The first was that I was not the only clever man watching Booth.

The second was that the other one had just seen me standing at his elbow.



“You stayed,” I said. “On purpose. To spy on him.”

“To be inside when it happened. Yes.”

“That’s insane.”

“It was the only door that led anywhere,” he said. “The police door led to the rope and didn’t stop him. The home door led to the newspaper. Only that one went through the room where he would decide.” He looked at me. “Tell me which you’d have chosen. Honestly.”

I opened my mouth, and closed it again.

Once, six years ago, I had chosen it myself. A source inside Carrow House, who could have walked away and didn’t, because inside was the only place you could see what they were doing. I had told him to stay, for those eight months. I had told him it was the only way.

I did not say any of that. I wrote down *April 11*, and underlined it, and after a moment I wrote, underneath, *the other one*, and looked at it, and did not ask.

Lafayette Square

The client's question came on Tuesday.

Please ask the gentleman whether he ever spoke to the waiter again.

I read it standing at the kitchen counter, and then I read it again, and then I went and got the transcripts.

It was a strange question. Everything the client had asked so far had made a kind of sense. The color of a thread, which nobody could check. The National Hotel, where Booth lived. Those were a skeptic's questions, the questions I would have asked myself, trying to catch a man in a lie. But the waiter was nobody. The waiter had said perhaps twenty words of his own in the whole story. Out of everything in eight sessions, the President and Booth and the plot and the guns, the client wanted to know about the waiter.

I wrote it on a sticky note and put it on the front of my notebook, and under it, in small letters, *why?*



On Thursday I was an hour late. The school had asked me to come in first thing, and it had not gone well.

He read the sticky note before I had my coat off. He read it upside down, across the table, while I was still setting out the recorders. I saw him do it.

"*Why*," he said. "Good."

"You tell me."

"I don't know," he said. And for the first time since I had known him, I believed he did not. He sat back and looked at the empty frame on the mantel for

a long moment. “Your client likes Damon,” he said at last, slowly. “Or he wants to know whether I did.” Then he shook his head, as if setting it aside for later. “Tell him yes. More than once. Tell him I’ll get there.”



It was nearly noon by then. He put the soup on, and at lunch I told him about the school.

I had not meant to. It came out sideways, the way things do, because the soup was good and because it had been a bad week. I told him that the car had started making a noise like a spoon in a garbage disposal, and the mechanic had charged me four hundred dollars to tell me it was a loose heat shield. That the carpet man had sent back chapter nine of his memoir with a note asking for more about the Berber shortage of 1987. And that Freda’s school had called on Wednesday, the chemistry teacher, Mr. Ostrowski, the one with the bow ties, to say that two lab write-ups had come in almost word for word the same, numbers and all, in a class where everybody weighs their own and writes their own, and he had to treat them both as copied until he knew whose work it was, and one of them was Freda’s. He had told both girls weeks ago, it turned out, the day the write-ups came in, and word had gone round the class. The school had only called now because neither girl would say anything, and that morning I had sat in a plastic chair outside the vice principal’s office for forty minutes to be told so in person.

“And Freda says she didn’t,” I said. “And she won’t say anything else. Not who, not how. She just goes quiet.” I stirred my soup. “She’s not a cheater. She’s the most annoyingly honest person I know. She told her dentist she doesn’t floss.”

He did not say anything. He listened, the way he always did, and when I had finished he asked how the car was now, and whether the gutter people paid on time, and he did not say one word about Freda or the school or the lab. I was almost disappointed. Then I was annoyed with myself for being disappointed, and then the soup was gone, and we went back into the living room.



• RECORDING · APRIL 12 AND 13, 1865

I had decided to stay inside. Now I had to find out what inside was going to do.

Booth told us nothing. That was the first thing I learned. On the twelfth and the thirteenth he was everywhere in the city and with all of us, cheerful, restless, buying drinks, and he said nothing at all about the President. He did not need to. Whatever he was going to do, he had not yet decided when, and a man like Booth does not share a plan until he has the ending.

So I did what I could do. I listened to his questions.

A man's questions tell you what he is thinking far better than his answers do. Booth asked me a great many things over those two days, the way he had asked me about horses and roads on a fence in Charles County, lightly, between other remarks, so that each one sounded like nothing. He asked me the fastest way from Lafayette Square to the Navy Yard Bridge, at night, for a man on a horse who did not know the city. He asked me whether the Kirkwood House, at Twelfth Street and the Avenue, had a back way out onto the alley. He asked me, laughing, whether I thought Andy Johnson drank as much as they said, and whether a man like that answered his own door at night.

And on the afternoon of the thirteenth, in the dining room of the National, he read me a paragraph from the *Star* about the Secretary of State.

Mr. Seward had been thrown from his carriage eight days before, when his horses bolted. It had been in all the papers. His jaw was broken and his arm, and he was lying in bed in his house on Lafayette Square, across from the President's house, badly hurt and under a doctor's care. Booth read me the paragraph about how he was getting on. Then he folded the paper and said, "Poor old man. Who doctors him, do you know?"

I said I did not. He said it did not matter, and changed the subject.

I sat there with my coffee and laid his questions side by side. Each one alone was nothing. Together they were not.

Every one of them was about the night, and every one was about getting away. And not one of them was about the President. Booth did not need my

help with the President. Whatever he meant to do there, he meant to do himself, in a city he knew street by street. The questions were for other men.

A man on a horse who did not know the city: that was not Booth. That was Powell, who could not find his way across Washington in daylight. And Lafayette Square, yes, the President's house faced it, but nobody plans a stranger's escape from a house he will never get into. The other house on that square that mattered that week was Seward's, with Seward in it, flat in bed with a broken jaw and a doctor coming and going. A man who asks for the doctor's name is looking for a reason to be let in at the door.

The Kirkwood: everyone in Washington knew that the new Vice President, Andrew Johnson, had rooms there. And the man who asked me whether Andy Johnson answered his own door at night was not asking about his drinking.

The President. The Vice President. The Secretary of State.

I knew how that government was put together. Kill only the President, and the Vice President takes his oath the next morning, and nothing changes; the war is still won. Kill the Vice President too, and the law calls for a new election, and the man whose office sends word to the states to hold it is the Secretary of State. Kill all three in one night, and for a few days nobody would be quite sure who was running the country at all. Booth did not mean to kill a man. He meant to cut the head off the government, all at once, in one night, and see what grew back.

It was, I have to tell you, a clever plan. It was the first truly clever plan I ever saw him make. It frightened me more than anything he had done.

And it meant he would need three men, in three places, at the same moment. Himself, for the President. Powell, for Seward, because Powell would do anything and Seward's house would need a man who would. And for Johnson, one of the others. Atzerodt, most likely, who knew nothing about the city and would go where he was told.

I knew who. For two of them, I knew where. I did not know where the President would be, or when.

I thought of writing it down and leaving it, unsigned, at the door of the President's house. Everyone in Washington knew he got threats by the sack-

ful and laughed at them. A letter would go on a pile.



I went back to the National late on the night of the thirteenth, to see if Booth had come in. He had not. The clerk said he had gone out to see the illuminations.

The whole city was lit again that night, brighter than before. The government had ordered it: every public building covered in candles and gaslight and transparencies, and the private houses doing the same, so that the streets were as bright as noon. I had walked through it to get there and hardly seen it.

I went through the lobby toward the stairs, and passed the doors to the dining room, which was closed for the night and dark except for one lamp at the far end, on the headwaiter's desk.

Damon was sitting there. Writing.

He was in his shirtsleeves, with the white jacket over the back of the chair, bent close to the lamp, and he was writing slowly and very carefully. I stood in the dark of the doorway and watched him, and he did not look up. He wrote to the bottom of a page. He read it through. Then he crumpled it, and put it in his pocket, and took a fresh sheet, and began again from the beginning.

I watched him write it three times.

The third time he did not crumple it. He read it through twice, and blotted it, and folded it, and put it in an envelope, and wrote something on the front, and sealed it. Then he sat for a moment with his hand flat on it, the way you rest your hand on a thing you are afraid of losing. And then he put on his coat, not the white jacket but his own dark one, the one I had seen him wear on the lawn two nights before, and came toward the door where I stood.

I stepped back into the lobby, behind a pillar, and let him pass.

He went out the front of the hotel into the bright street, and turned west, up the Avenue, toward the President's house, walking fast with the envelope held inside his coat.

I started after him. I had gone perhaps three steps across the lobby when the street door opened again and Booth came in out of the light, flushed and bright-eyed from the illuminations. He saw me at once, and came straight over, and took my arm.

“Kit,” he said. “Come up.”

There was no way to pull free of him without telling him why. So I went up the stairs with Booth’s arm through mine, and by the time I could have looked, Damon was long gone into the crowds and the light. I never saw where he turned.

I thought about it afterward, lying awake. A man writing at midnight, in the best hand in Washington, three times over until every word was right. Sealing it. Resting his hand on it. Walking it out himself into the night, instead of trusting it to the post, holding it against his chest.

In the end I settled on the likely answer, which was that he was in love with someone. Someone up that way, on the west side of the city, who worked in one of the big houses there. A man only writes a letter three times for one reason, in my experience, and I had a great deal of experience. It was an answer I could sleep on, and so I took it.



He stopped there, and looked at the notepad for a while.

“I should tell your client,” he said, “that that was not speaking to him. I only watched.” He smiled a little, not happily. “I watched a great deal, that week. You’d think I would have seen more.”

I was writing. *Seward, carriage accident, April 5. Check. Johnson, Kirkwood House. Check. Illumination, April 13. Check.*

I looked up. “You worked out all three targets. From some questions and a newspaper.”

“From his questions. Anybody could have. Nobody else was listening to them.”

“And you still didn’t know when.”

“No,” he said. “Nobody knew when. Not even Booth. Not until the next morning, when he went to collect his mail.”

He put the pencil down.

“That’s Friday,” he said. “I think that’s enough for today.”

It was only two o’clock. I did not argue. I packed up the recorders, and on the drive home I found that I kept thinking, for no reason I could name, about a man writing the same letter three times.

Good Friday

I brought the box with me on the tenth visit.

It was an ordinary banker's box, the cardboard kind with handholds cut in the ends, and it had lived on the top shelf of my closet for six years under a bag of winter hats. *CARROW* was written on the lid in marker, in my own handwriting from a worse time. I had taken it down the week before, on the night the client's question about the waiter came, for no better reason than that odd questions made me want to go back over old ones.

I had not meant to bring it. But it was on the passenger seat on Thursday morning, and I did not take it out again.

He saw it when I came in and did not ask about it. He made the tea. I set out the recorders and did not turn them on, and while the tea steeped I found I was talking.

"I went back through it this week," I said. "The old stuff. I haven't opened it since I left the paper."

"Did it help?"

"No. It made me feel like I was thirty-eight again and about to be fired." I took the lid off anyway. "It's mostly paper. My notes. Copies of the documents he gave me, the ones they said were fake. The correction, which I kept, because I'm like that." I lifted out a thin folder. "And the police report. It took me three months and a records request to get this, and when I got it, it was two pages long and they'd spelled his name wrong."

I told him about it the way you tell someone about a bad time you have mostly gotten over: all at once, jumping around, with too much in it.

The officer who took the report had been named Delacroix, and he had called me *ma'am* in a way that made clear he thought I was a crank. The report said that the tenant had not been seen since approximately Wednesday, per the landlord. It said there were no signs of forced entry, no signs of a struggle, and that the tenant's vehicle was not at the address, which I could have told them, since he did not own a vehicle and never had. Petrakis had given the police a statement too, which was mostly about money. The tenant was two weeks behind on the rent. A moving company had been booked for the Saturday, a small outfit from across the river, and the movers had shown up and knocked and gone away again, and then sent Petrakis a bill for the trip, which he wanted the police to know he did not intend to pay. There was a list of what the officers had seen in the apartment, one line to a thing: *bed, unmade. Kitchen, dishes in sink. Framed family photographs on living room wall. Desk. No computer observed. Cat (1) in bedroom, door closed, removed by landlord.*

"Two weeks behind on the rent," I said. "I didn't know that at the time. I'd have lent it to him. He never said." I put the report back in its folder. "And the movers. He'd told me he was going to move after the story ran, somewhere Carrow couldn't find him. I thought he meant eventually. He'd already booked them."

"For the Saturday," he said.

"For the Saturday." I shook my head. "Anyway. It didn't help. I don't know why I brought it."

I closed the box, and put it on the floor by my chair, and turned on the recorders.

He did not say anything about any of it. He poured the tea, and looked at the box on the floor for a moment, and then he looked at the window.

"The fourteenth," he said. "Good Friday."



• RECORDING · APRIL 14, 1865

It was Good Friday. I want you to remember that, because nobody does. The churches were full that morning. The Catholics in the city were at their long

service, and Mrs. Surratt would have been at St. Patrick's, the way she was most mornings, and the Protestant churches were open too, for the ones who kept the day. And the rest of the city was still half drunk on the end of the war, and the flags were still up, and the theaters were all playing, because it was Washington, and Washington had never been as pious as it pretended.

I did not go to church. I went to the National at ten o'clock, to find Booth.

He was not in. The clerk said he had gone out early, to the barber's, and would be back for his mail. I stood in the lobby for a while, not knowing what to do with myself. The dining room was being laid for luncheon. I looked for Damon among the waiters, the way I always did by then, and he was not there. I asked the headwaiter, in passing, as if it were nothing, and he said the man had asked for the morning off, which he never did, and had gone out early.

I thought: the woman on the west side of town. And I was glad for him, a little. And I put it away.

At a little after eleven I saw Booth come down the Avenue from the barber's, freshly shaved and in a very good humor, and turn up Tenth Street. And I followed him.

I do not know why I did it. I had been with him for two days waiting for him to tell me when. I think I had simply run out of patience with waiting. He did not look back. He walked the way he always walked, as if the street had been laid down for him that morning. And he went a block up Tenth Street and in at the front of Ford's Theatre.

He had his mail sent there. All the actors in Washington did; Ford's was a kind of home to them. I knew that. I had walked him there a dozen times. So I crossed to the other side of Tenth Street, and stood in the doorway of a shop across the way, and watched the door.

He was inside for no more than a few minutes. When he came out, he had a letter in his hand, and he was not reading it.

I have told you that I could not read his face on the night of the tenth. I could read it now. He stopped on the steps of the theater with a letter in his hand that he had forgotten he was holding, and he looked up at the front of

that building, at the upper windows, the way a man looks at a house he has just been told is his.

Then he went down the steps, and walked away down Tenth Street toward the Avenue, fast, and did not see me.

I stayed where I was.

A minute later, a young man came out of the theater's front door onto the steps, bareheaded, in shirtsleeves, and called across the street to a man he knew who was passing. He called it cheerfully, the way you call good news, the way a man calls it who has tickets to sell.

"The President's coming tonight," he called. "And General Grant! Tell everyone!"

The man he called to waved his hat. A woman who was passing turned to look. A boy ran off down the street, already shouting it.

I stood in the doorway across Tenth Street and watched the news go out into the city from the steps of Ford's Theatre, the way a stone goes into a pond.

Tonight. Here.



He stopped.

The woodstove ticked.

"That's how he found out," I said. "Collecting his mail."

"That's how he found out. It's in every book. He went to get his letters, and they told him."

"And you were across the street."

"I was across the street." He picked up his cup, drank, and made a face. "Cold," he said, and put it down. "I had three names and three places, and now I had a time. The only one who didn't know what I knew was the one man who could have stopped all of it by simply staying home." He looked at me. "Nobody was going to tell him. That was the thing I understood, standing in that doorway. The whole city was about to know he was coming. And the one thing nobody in it was going to tell him was *don't*."

He was quiet for a moment.

“Except one,” he said. “But I didn’t know that yet.”

The Afternoon

He did not make soup that day. He made sandwiches, and we ate them standing in the kitchen, and neither of us suggested sitting down. The box with *CARROW* on the lid stayed on the living room floor by my chair, where I had left it. I saw him glance at it once, through the doorway, and then away.

When we went back in, he did not sit. He stood by the window.

"I had ten hours," he said. "I want to tell you how I spent them, because I spent them well. That's important. I don't want you to think what happened that night happened because I was slow." He was quiet a moment. "My leg was slow. I was not. Those are different things, and that night the difference mattered."



• RECORDING · APRIL 14, 1865, AFTERNOON

The first thing I did, a little after noon, was decide.

I had three men and three places and a time. I could not be in three places. I had to choose one, and I chose the theater, for two reasons. Booth was the only one of the three who would not lose his nerve; Powell would do anything, but Powell would do it only because Booth had told him to, and Atzerodt would go wherever the most brandy was. And Booth was the one I could get near. I was his friend. I could walk up to him anywhere in that city and he would smile and put his arm through mine.

It meant leaving Mr. Seward to his sons and his soldier nurse and a locked door. I knew that. I told myself that without Booth the others would lose

their shape. I was half right.

So I would stop Booth. And I would do it the way I had taken back my drawings: quietly, so that nobody would ever know anything had almost happened.

The second thing I did was follow him.

When he came away from Ford's he went straight down to the Avenue and round behind the National, to a livery stable on C Street, a man named Pumphrey's, where he usually hired a horse. I stood across the street and watched him through the big open doors. He talked with Pumphrey a long time. He did not get the horse he usually had. They brought out a small bay mare instead, quick and nervous, with a white star on her forehead, and he walked round her twice and ran his hand down her legs, which he had not bothered to do with any horse in Charles County, and then said something and left her there, and came away. As he went out into the street, Pumphrey called after him, loud enough for the whole street to hear, not to tie the mare to anything, because she would break her halter.

A fast horse, chosen carefully, for later in the day. I thought about the Navy Yard Bridge. I thought about the sentry who stopped the ones coming in and let the ones going out go home, and about the backs of my mother's tobacco receipts, which I had burned, but which I had drawn in the first place, and which Booth had studied for three months.

He did not need the receipts anymore. He knew the road. I had taught it to him.



A little after two, he went to H Street.

I did not go in. I stood on the corner, down the block, where I could see the steps. There was a hired buggy at the curb, with a horse and a young man holding it: Weichmann, who I had never let hear my name. Booth went up the steps and in at the door, and he was inside for a few minutes, no more. Then he came out alone and went away down the street, and did not look at the buggy.

A little while after, Mrs. Surratt came out and down the steps in her bonnet and shawl, ready for a drive. She was carrying a small package, done up in paper and string, about the size of a man's two fists. She put it in the buggy without looking at it. Then Weichmann helped her up and they drove away, south, toward the Navy Yard and the bridge and the county. Toward the tavern.

I stood on that corner and thought about that package for a long time.

I did not know what was in it. I want to be honest with you about that, because it came to matter a great deal, later, to a great many people. I did not know, and I could not have known, from the corner of the street. I only knew that Booth had gone into her house and talked with her, and that she had come out after him with a package, and was driving that afternoon to a tavern on the road he would take that night, and that she had put it in the buggy without looking at it.

A woman who asks no questions she does not want the answers to. I had thought that of her the first night I met her. I thought it again, standing on that corner, and I did not like it any better.



At four o'clock I was on the Avenue near Willard's, because I had lost him for an hour and the Avenue was where you found people. Near Twelfth Street a tall Black man in a dark coat crossed the Avenue fast, toward the Kirkwood House, fast enough that a cab driver shouted at him. I noticed him the way you notice anyone moving faster than a crowd, and forgot him, because just then I found Booth. He was on the bay mare now, sitting her the way he sat every horse, as if he had been born on it, talking down from the saddle to a man on the sidewalk, an actor I knew a little, named Mathews. He handed Mathews an envelope. Mathews put it in his coat.

I have read since what was in it. Everyone has. It was a letter to the editor of the *National Intelligencer*, explaining to the country why he had done what he was about to do, and Mathews was to take it to the paper the next day. He was writing the reviews before the play had opened.

And while I watched, an open carriage came down the Avenue from the direction of the President's house, with a soldier driving and trunks strapped on the back, and a stocky man with a short beard in the back seat beside a woman in a traveling bonnet. People on the sidewalk pointed. Somebody cheered. It was General Grant and his wife, leaving the city.

Booth turned the mare's head and watched the carriage go by, and I watched his face. I had seen that face laugh, and rage, and play a whole theater fire on a church step. I had never seen it look the way it did then: like a man who has turned to the last page of a play and found it torn out. Then he wheeled the mare and went after the carriage at a walk, and drew up alongside it, close, and looked into it, at the general and his wife, for longer than any stranger should. Mrs. Grant drew back in her seat. Then the traffic closed between us, and I lost him again.

I went down to the railroad station later, because I had understood, and I needed to be sure. The Grants had taken the train north. They were going to see their children in New Jersey. They were not going to the theater.

Only the President, then. And his wife, and whoever they asked to sit with them in Grant's place. And no general in that box, with a general's instincts and a general's aides.



At six I went to Ford's and bought a ticket.

That was the third thing I did, and I was proud of it. I stood at the box office window and asked the man for a seat in the dress circle, and while he found me one I looked past him at the plan of the house pinned to the wall behind his head, the way a man looks at a picture while he waits. The dress circle ran round the theater in a horseshoe, one floor up. At the right-hand end of it, the stage end, there was a narrow door, drawn on the plan as a little break in the line. That door led into a short passage, and the passage led to the two boxes that had been thrown together to make the President's box.

One door. Anybody going into that box had to go through it. I bought the seat nearest to it that he had.

“You won’t see much of him from there, sir,” the man said, handing me the ticket, meaning the President. “Wrong side.”

I said that was all right.



I will tell you my plan. It was a good one.

I did not mean to fight him. I was a lame boy with a cane, and he was one of the finest swordsmen on the American stage and had a pistol in his coat. I did not mean to go to the guard, because there would be a guard, and a guard would ask how I knew, and we have been through where that door led.

I meant to be loud.

Booth needed, more than anything, not to be seen. He needed to walk through that crowded dress circle as if he were nobody, one more gentleman going to the back for air. And he was the most famous young actor in America. If a man stood up in that dress circle, with the whole house there, and called out *Mr. Booth! Mr. John Wilkes Booth, as I live!* and came limping toward him with his hand out, delighted, making a fuss, then every head in that half of the theater would turn. Every one. Women would stand up to see him. The ushers would come. And he could not go through that little door with three hundred people watching him do it. Not then. Perhaps not that night at all.

It would not stop him forever. I knew that. But the Grants were gone, and the war was over, and the President might never be so easy to reach again. Every night I could buy was a night for somebody else to notice what I had noticed. It was the best plan I had, and I still think it was a good one.

It needed only one thing. It needed me to be in that dress circle when Booth came in.

At about half past eight I was standing on the pavement outside Ford’s, in the crowd, with my ticket in my pocket, when the President’s carriage came up Tenth Street. The play had already begun. The President was late.

I watched him get down. He was tired. You could see it in the way he stood a moment on the pavement, as if deciding. His wife on his arm, and a young officer and a young lady I did not know, and he went in through the

front doors past me, near enough to touch. And a minute later, through the open doors, I heard the orchestra stop in the middle of whatever it had been playing, and start “Hail to the Chief,” and the whole house come to its feet with a roar.

I went in after them, and up the stairs, and found my seat, and turned it a little, so that I could see the door.

I sat there for an hour, with the play going on below me and people laughing, and I did not take my eyes off that door, or off the stairs from the lobby.

I was not the only one near it. There was a chair by the passage door, and a policeman in it when I sat down. After the first act he got up and went away down the stairs, and the chair stayed empty, and it did not fill again. And a few seats along from me, near the door, sat the President’s man, a footman in livery, with his hat on his knee. I noted them both. A guard who was gone, and a servant who was not a guard.

And at a little after half past nine, somebody touched my shoulder from behind, very lightly, and said, in a low voice that had to wait for its first word:

“M-Mister Keene.”



He stopped there.

I waited for him to turn around, to tell me who had spoken. When he didn’t, I became aware of the quiet in the living room and the notebook in my lap. I had stopped taking notes without noticing. The last thing on the page was one word in the margin, written very small: *loud*. I had underlined it twice.

“That was a good plan,” I said. I had meant to ask what happened next.

“It was a very good plan,” he said. “I’ve had a long time to look for the hole in it, and I’ve only ever found one.”

“Someone else was watching the same door.”

The Message

“Go on,” I said.

He looked at the clock on the wall. It was twenty past three.

“I’ll tell you what he said,” he said, “and then I’ll tell you what each of us saw. Everything I saw gave me a reason to believe him. And everything he’d seen of me gave him a reason to send me away. We were wrong about each other, Ms. Barnett. But I understand why he did it. That’s what makes it unbearable.”



• RECORDING · APRIL 14, 1865, A LITTLE AFTER HALF PAST NINE

I turned in my seat, and Damon was standing in the aisle behind me, bent a little toward me, the way a servant bends to a gentleman.

He was in his white jacket from the National. That was how he had got in. I understood it at once, and I admired it, even then. A Black man in the dress circle of Ford’s Theatre on a Friday night would have been stopped at the foot of the stairs and asked his business. But a hotel waiter in a hotel jacket, with a folded note in his hand, looking for a gentleman, is not a man. He is a message. The ushers had let him up without a second look. The people in the seats around me did not look at him at all.

He held out a folded note, the way a waiter holds out a bill on a tray.

“F-from Mister B-Booth, sir,” he said, very low, under the laughter from the stage.

Then he straightened up, and stepped back, and stood waiting, with his hands behind him, the way a servant waits to see whether there will be an

answer.

I unfolded it. It was Booth's hand. I had seen that hand all winter, on letters and cards and the backs of playbills, big and fast and slanting, the hand of a man who has signed a great many autographs and enjoyed every one. Four lines, written in a hurry:

Kit. The Dutchman has lost his nerve. I have gone to the Kirkwood to see to it myself. Come at once. The theater will keep. J.W.B.

I read it twice. For a man in a hurry, there was not a blot on it. In the aisle, Damon's hand came out from behind his back, an inch, no more, the way a waiter reaches for a plate before you have quite finished. Then it went back.

I noticed the blots, and let them go. The play had half an hour left in it, the Kirkwood was four blocks off, and I had a bad leg. At four o'clock that afternoon I had watched him hand Mathews a letter to the newspapers explaining the whole thing. A man who puts his reasons in a letter to the *Intelligencer* does not worry about four lines to a friend. And he had sent them by the one messenger nobody ever looks at.



I want to tell you what I thought, in the next half minute, because I thought very clearly, and every step of it felt sound.

First: that the note was Booth's. I knew the hand. And it knew things nobody knew who was not inside: the Kirkwood, the Vice President, that there was a man assigned to him, and that the man was a German, the kind to lose his nerve.

Second: that Booth had trusted Damon to carry it. And if he had, then everything I had seen in six weeks turned over and showed a second face. Damon had been at Booth's elbow, one way or another, since the first night I saw him at the National. Waiting on Booth's table. Listening to every word Booth said. Standing at the top of the back stairs at midnight outside Booth's room, as if he had been waiting there for somebody to come out. On the lawn when Booth said *the last speech he will ever make*. Taking the morning off, today of all days, the day Booth learned the President was coming. Everywhere Booth went, Damon had been, a few steps off, unseen.

And Booth, I knew, tipped every waiter in that hotel too much, and knew them all by name, and thought of them as furniture. What better man for an errand, on a night like this, than one nobody would ever look at twice? Booth was vain, and careless with paper, but he was not a fool. A waiter from the National, who could go anywhere in a white jacket, carrying messages, watching doors. It was exactly what I would have done.

And he knew where to find me. Nobody had told Booth I would be at Ford's that night. So somebody had been watching me for him, and there was his waiter, standing in the aisle.

I had thought the letter at midnight was a love letter. That turned over too.

Third: that the message made sense. That was the worst of it. It fit everything I knew. Atzerodt losing his nerve was the most likely thing in the world; I had thought, the first time I met him, that when the thing came close he would find he had somewhere else to be. And if he had, then Booth was exactly the man to go and do it himself. The Kirkwood was four blocks away. The play had more than half an hour to run. Booth knew every line of it. He could be at the Kirkwood and back before the third act turned. Two in one night, instead of one. That was Booth. That was the man who had walked up and down Gautier's with his cigar, lowering an invisible President over an invisible rail.

And fourth: that if Booth was at the Kirkwood, then Booth was not here. He was four blocks away, alone, in a hotel, going up a staircase toward the Vice President. And if I could reach him there, I could stop both of them. Johnson and the President. In one place. Tonight.

If I stayed, I kept the door and lost Johnson, and Booth would come back up those stairs with one murder behind him and nothing left to lose. If I went, I might stop both.

I would check. I was not a fool either. I would ask at the Kirkwood desk before I did anything at all, and if Booth had not been there, I would know the message was false, and I would come straight back.

It took me perhaps half a minute to think all of that. I got up, and took my cane, and went past Damon up the aisle toward the stairs.

At the top of the stairs I looked back.

Damon had not followed me. He was standing against the back wall of the dress circle, near the corner, not far from that narrow door at the end, with his hands behind him, still and patient, like a servant waiting for his gentleman to come back. Waiting, I thought, for Booth.

It was exactly where I would have put him.

Then I went down. I missed the second stair and caught the rail.



He stopped.

“And what had he seen?” I said. “Damon.”

“He saw a man he had known on a farm, who came back from the war changed, and cold, and whom he had never liked. Who went to Washington in the winter and began to eat his dinners at John Wilkes Booth’s own table, in a coat that Booth had paid for. Who came to the side door of the National on the night of the seventeenth of March, the night the plotters were supposed to take the President, with mud to his knees and a saddled horse on a lead with nobody to ride it. Who stood at Booth’s elbow on the lawn when Booth said *the last speech he will ever make*, and did not so much as turn his head. Who came out of Booth’s room at midnight with his shirt full of papers.” He held up his hand, and turned it over, and looked at it. “And who, on the night the President came to Ford’s Theatre, had bought the seat in the dress circle nearest to the only door into the President’s box, and sat in it for an hour, with his eyes on that door and on the stairs, and did not watch the play.”

He put his hand down.

“What would you have thought I was?”

I did not answer.

“He thought I was the one who would hold the door,” he said. “Booth’s man, placed there to keep the way clear. And he was right about everything he had seen. Every single thing. He was only wrong about me, and there was no way on earth for him to know that, because the only thing that had changed was inside my head.” He smiled, very slightly.

“So he sent you to the Kirkwood.”

“The Kirkwood.” He picked up the pencil and turned it in his fingers. “In Booth’s own hand. I would have sworn to that note in any court in the country. He had carried Booth’s letters to and from the hotel desk all winter, dozens of them. That was enough for him. It was the best forgery I have ever held, and I have held a few.”

“Do you still have it?”

“It went into a gutter on Tenth Street that night, in pieces. A letter in Booth’s hand, calling me to come and help him, was not a thing to be found with.” He turned the pencil over. “I’ve spent a long time wondering how he knew about Atzerodt. That he’d lose his nerve. Booth never said it in front of him. I’m nearly sure of that. He must have watched Atzerodt the way he watched all of us, and worked it out for himself.” He shook his head. “He was right about that too.” He put the pencil down. “And he knew about the card. I have never worked out how he knew about the card. But that’s the Kirkwood, and we aren’t there yet.”

I looked at the clock. It was nearly four.

“You checked,” I said. “At the Kirkwood. You said you would check.”

“I did check.” He stood up, slowly, one hand on the arm of the chair. “And it was true. That’s next week, Ms. Barnett. I find that I’m tired.”

I wanted to argue. Then I looked at his face and did not.

On the porch, while I was finding my keys, he said, “The box.” He nodded at it, under my arm, the one with *CARROW* on the lid. “You brought it for a reason. You just haven’t found the reason yet.”

“I told you. I don’t know why I brought it.”

“No,” he agreed. “But you will.”

The Kirkwood

I did not bring the box the next week. I thought about it, standing in the closet with the light on, and left it where it was.

But on the Monday I looked up Petrakis. It took me twenty minutes. He had sold the building four years ago, and the dry cleaner's was a smoothie place now, and he lived with his daughter in a split-level house in Silver Spring. The daughter answered and said he didn't talk to reporters, and then Petrakis took the phone from her and said he would talk to whoever he liked.

He remembered me. He remembered the carpet, and he told me again who had never paid for it, and I let him.

Then I asked about the cat.

"Pearl," he said at once. "Gray, white feet. Nice cat. Stupid, but nice."

Pearl. I wrote it down, and something in my chest let go that I had not known was holding on.

"The police found her shut in the bedroom," I said. "Did he do that often?"

"Only when somebody came up. Every time that door opened, out she went, down the stairs and into the cleaner's, and then I'm the one on my knees under the pressing machine. Twice I did that. After the second time I told him, somebody comes to your door, you put the cat away first. And he did. He was a good tenant, except the rent."

I did not say anything for a moment.

"So if she was shut in," I said, "somebody had come up."

"Sure. Somebody came up." I could hear a television somewhere behind him, and his daughter asking who it was. "Six years, and you call about the cat?"

“Mostly about the cat.”

“You found him? You know where he went?”

“No,” I said. “I don’t.”

I did not tell him about Pearl that Thursday. It had been his idea to ask. I wanted, this once, to be the one who knew what the answer meant.

He was waiting on the porch when I drove up, already in his coat, as if he had been standing there a while, with the umbrella furled though it was not raining. He did not make small talk. He did not make tea. When I had set out the recorders and said the date and the time, he began before I had finished writing it down, as if he had been saying it to himself all week and was only now letting me hear.



• RECORDING · APRIL 14, 1865, A QUARTER TO TEN

The Kirkwood House stood at the corner of Twelfth Street and the Avenue. It was not grand, the way the National was. It was a plain, busy, respectable hotel, the kind congressmen stayed in when they did not want to be seen spending money, and it was four blocks from Ford’s. I did those four blocks faster than I had walked anywhere since Fort Stevens. My leg did not like it. I did not ask it.

The lobby was bright and nearly empty. A clerk at the desk. Two men in chairs with newspapers. And through an open door on the left, the bar, with the noise of a Friday night coming out of it.

I went to the desk. I made myself slow down before I got there, and lean on the cane a little, and smile. A lame young man with a pleasant face, asking after a friend.

“Has Mr. Booth been in?” I said. “The actor. John Wilkes Booth.”

The clerk’s face did what everyone’s face did at that name. “Mr. Booth? Yes, sir, he was in.” He was pleased to know it. “Left his card for Mr. Browning. That’s the Vice President’s secretary.” He lowered his voice, the way people do when they are telling you something about the great. “Wanted to know was Mr. Johnson at home.”

So it was true.

I stood at that desk and felt it go through me. Damon had not lied. Booth had been here, asking for Johnson. Everything in the note had held.

I would have asked when in the next breath. I never got to the next breath.

Through the open door of the bar, over the clerk's shoulder, I saw Atzerodt.



He was at the far end of the bar, alone, in a dark coat, with a glass in front of him that was not his first. His hat was pushed back. His face had the loose, shining look of a man who has been drinking for courage for an hour and has found it does not come from there. As I watched, he leaned across the bar and said something to the bartender, low, and the bartender looked at him oddly and shook his head and moved away to someone else.

I found out later what he had asked. Everyone did. It came out at the trial. He had asked where the Vice President's room was, and what sort of man he was.

And upstairs, I knew, one floor above the Vice President's rooms, was a room Atzerodt had taken that morning in his own name. I did not know then what he had left in it. They found it the next day: a loaded revolver under the pillow, and a long knife between the sheets and the mattress, and Booth's bankbook in the pocket of a coat.

I did not need to know that, standing in the lobby. I only needed to look at him.

I have told you what I thought about Atzerodt the first time I met him: that he would say yes to anything, cheerfully, as long as it was far away, and that if it ever came close, he would find he had somewhere else to be. Looking at him through that door, I saw that I had been right, and also that I had not been right enough. He had not found somewhere else to be. He was sitting forty feet below the Vice President, with a room upstairs and a weapon in it, and he was drinking. A frightened man who drinks can go either way. He can

drink himself out of it. Or he can drink until the fear goes quiet for ten minutes, and in those ten minutes he can climb a flight of stairs.

Booth was not in the bar or the lobby. He had asked whether Johnson was in and left a card, the way a man checks a door before he comes back to open it. So either he was coming back, or he was upstairs already. Either way, the man with the room and the knife was sitting in front of me.

So I did the only thing that made sense. I went into the bar.



Atzerodt saw me in the mirror behind the bar before I reached him, and I saw his face do three things, one after another. Fear, first, because anyone coming toward him that night was something to fear. Then he knew me, and there was relief: Keene, the lame boy, the one who knew the roads. And then, right behind the relief, a terrible hope.

I did not sit down. I leaned on the bar beside him with my cane between us, and I did not look at him. I looked at the bottles, the way two men do who are not together.

“He says leave it,” I said.

I said it quietly, the way I had heard Booth say things all winter, as if it were already settled and I were only passing it along.

Atzerodt turned his head and stared at me.

“Leave it,” I said again. “It’s off. He said to find you and tell you. Go get your horse and go home. Go anywhere. Don’t go upstairs, don’t go back to your room. Just go.”

That was the lie I told him. I had worked it out on the four blocks from Ford’s, in case I needed it, the way you work out a move before you know if you’ll need to make it. It was not a clever lie. It did not need to be. It only needed to be the thing he most wanted to hear, said by someone he believed was close to Booth. Nobody questions the thing he most wants to hear. I have used that in a great many lives. I am not proud of how often.

He did not question it. I watched it go into him like warmth. His shoulders came down. He let out a breath that he must have been holding since eight o’clock.

“He is not angry?” he said. His accent was always thicker when he drank. “I told him. At the house, tonight. I told him, I did not come for killing. I came for the other thing, the taking. Not this. I told him.”

“He’s not angry,” I said. “Go.”

He put money on the bar, too much of it. He picked up his hat. He went out of the bar and through the lobby and out the front doors onto the Avenue without once looking at the staircase, and I stood at the bar and watched him in the mirror until he was gone.

He said afterward, in the statements he gave after they arrested him, that he had refused Booth. That he had never meant to go through with it. I believe that was true, as far as it went. He had refused the moment somebody gave him leave to.



I stood there for a moment, with my hand on the bar.

The Vice President was asleep upstairs. I learned later that he had gone to bed early that night. He did not know, and he never knew, that a drunk carriage painter with a knife in his room had sat forty feet below him, working up to it, and that a lame boy had sent him home. It is not in any book. It is not in the trial record. The record says only that Atzerodt lost his nerve, and drank, and left. That is true. That is exactly what happened.

It was the only thing I did that night that worked.

And standing there, with the noise of the bar going on around me, I thought: *where is Booth?*

He had sent me here to help with Johnson. The note said he had come to see to it himself. He was not in the bar, and Atzerodt had not seen him, or he would have said. He was not upstairs either. The house was quiet, and a clerk does not sit calmly at his desk under a floor where the Vice President is being killed. If Booth had meant to come, he would have been here before me. He had a fast horse, and I had a cane.

I went back to the desk.

“Mr. Booth,” I said to the clerk. “When he left his card. What time was that?”

The clerk thought about it. "This afternoon, sir," he said. "Three o'clock, maybe. Half past. Mr. Browning had it by five." He looked at me, curious now. "Were you to meet him?"

This afternoon.

I have told you that knowing a thing is not the same as knowing it. That was a night I learned it again. It all turned over in me at once, the whole half minute in the dress circle, every step that had felt so sound, like a card turned face up on a table.

Booth had not come to the Kirkwood tonight. Booth had never been coming. The card was six hours old, and it was true, and it had been chosen because it was true, because I would check, and it would hold. Somebody had wanted me out of that dress circle. Out of the seat by the only door. And had found the one message that would move me, and made it true enough to check.

Written in Booth's hand, down to the last stroke, and not a blot on it. I had noticed that in the dress circle and let it go. Anyone can write four clean lines in a hurry, once. But a man copying another man's hand does not hurry at all. He sits up with it, and gets every letter right, and it comes out clean because it has to.

He was not Booth's man. Booth's man would never have sent Booth's backup away from the door. There was only one reason to empty that seat.

He thought I was guarding it.

And he was standing by it now, in his white jacket, against the back wall, alone. And Booth, who had not been at the Kirkwood, was somewhere I had just walked away from.

I looked at the clock over the desk. It was eight minutes past ten.

I went out through the doors onto the Avenue and turned east, toward Tenth Street, and I ran. I had not run since July. I had a cane and a leg with a Union bullet hole through it, and I ran.



He stopped. His hands were shaking. I had never seen them shake.

“I’m going to stop there,” he said, “for a minute.”

He got up and went into the kitchen, and I heard the tap run, and run, and after a while stop. I sat in the living room with the woodstove ticking and the two red lights on the recorders, and I did not follow him, and I did not turn them off.

Tenth Street

He came back after ten minutes with a glass of water he did not drink. He set it on the table by the notepad and sat down, and his hands had stopped shaking, and he put them flat on his knees anyway, as if to keep them there.

“Four blocks,” he said. “I had done them in six minutes on the way there. I did them in seven on the way back, running, because the leg had spent everything it had on the way there. I’ve gone over it more times than I can tell you. There was nothing in those seven minutes I could have done faster.”



• RECORDING · APRIL 14, 1865, A QUARTER PAST TEN

Tenth Street was quiet when I turned into it. That is what I remember first. A quiet street at night, gaslit, with carriages waiting along the curb for the end of the play, and the drivers dozing on their boxes, and a boy selling something at the corner. The front of Ford’s was lit and its doors were open to the street, and I could hear the play from the street, faintly, one man’s voice.

I knew that play. Everyone did; it had been running in one theater or another for years. And I knew where in it we were. I had sat through the first two acts from my seat by the door, listening with half my mind. We were in the third act. One of the actors was alone on the stage, and I could hear his voice rising toward the line that always got the biggest laugh of the night.

I was thirty yards from the doors. I was running on a leg that had stopped being a leg some blocks back and become only a thing I threw forward and landed on.

The laugh came out through the open doors like a wave breaking. The whole house, all at once, the way a house laughs at the one line it has been waiting for.

And inside it, very small, very flat, a single crack. Like a stick broken over a knee.

Most of the people on Tenth Street did not hear it. The drivers did not stir. I heard it because I was listening for it, and because I had heard a great many pistols in a great many lives, and there is no other sound in the world quite like one fired indoors.

For a moment nothing happened. Then small things happened, all along Tenth Street, the way they do. A carriage horse threw up its head, and its driver did not wake. The boy at the corner stopped calling whatever he was selling and turned to look at the doors. My foot came down wrong, and the leg went, and I caught myself on the wheel of a hack and hung there. And inside, the laugh went on for a second longer than it should have. Then it broke off, raggedly, the way a laugh does when half the people laughing have stopped and the other half have not yet understood why. And then, in the silence after it, a woman screamed.

I have heard that scream in my sleep for a hundred and sixty years.



I got to the doors. I got into the lobby. People were beginning to come out of the inner doors toward me, not running yet, only standing up and turning, with their faces open and stupid, the way faces are in the first second before they understand. I pushed through them. I got to the inner doors and I could see the stage, down the long slope of the house, bright under the gas.

A man was on the stage.

He was down on one knee, in the middle of it, as if he had fallen, and he was getting up. He had something in his hand that caught the light, and a flag was trailing from somewhere above him, torn half off the front of the box, hanging. He got to his feet. He turned toward the audience, toward all of us, and he raised the thing in his hand, and he shouted something.

I could not hear the words. The screaming had started by then, and the noise of a thousand people getting to their feet at once. People told the newspapers afterward that it was *Sic semper tyrannis*, thus always to tyrants, the motto of Virginia. Some of them heard that. Some heard *the South is avenged*. Some heard nothing at all. I heard nothing. I only saw his face, from the back of the house, lit from below by the footlights, the way I had seen it a dozen times on a stage, playing a king.

It was the happiest I ever saw him.

Then he turned and ran across the stage, limping, and into the wings, and was gone.



I knew where he was going.

That was the one thing I still had. I knew him. I knew the mare with the white star, and I knew he had not tied her at the front. The front of the theater was on Tenth Street, with a hundred people in it. The back of the theater opened onto an alley, and the alley ran out to F Street and to the dark, and that was where a man would leave a fast horse, with somebody to hold her, because Pumphrey had told him she would break her halter if he tied her.

I could not go through. Between me and that stage were a thousand people on their feet, and half of them were already pouring down the aisles toward it, and men were climbing up over the footlights. The quickest way to the back of Ford's was around the outside.

I turned around in that lobby and fought my way back out through the doors against the crowd that was beginning to come out behind me, and down the steps, and along the front of the building, to where the narrow passage ran between Ford's and the building next door, back toward the alley.

It was dark in the passage. I ran into the wall once and did not feel it. I came out at the far end into the alley behind the theater, and the back door of the stage was standing open, and there was light coming out of it and noise.

And there was a boy on the ground, holding his head. And there were hoofbeats going away fast up the alley toward F Street, and then nothing.

I stood in the alley with my cane.

I had taught him that road. The Navy Yard Bridge, the sentry who stopped the ones coming in and let the ones going home go home. The ridge road. The long way round the swamp. The farms where a man could be hidden. I had drawn every inch of it on my mother's tobacco receipts, and I had burned the receipts, and it did not matter in the least, because he knew it all by heart.

The boy on the ground was crying. I helped him up. He was the boy who held horses for the actors; I had seen him before, running errands around the theater. Booth had struck him with the handle of a knife, he said, to make him let go of the reins. He did not know why. He kept asking me why. I did not tell him.



When I came back around to Tenth Street it was full.

It had filled the way water fills a lock, all at once, from every direction. People had come out of Ford's and people had come out of every house and saloon and boarding house on the street, and soldiers were arriving, running, from somewhere, and nobody knew anything, and everybody was shouting what they knew. The President was shot. The President was dead. The President was not hurt at all. It was a rebel army. It was an actor. It was Booth, it was Booth, somebody had seen him, it was John Wilkes Booth.

Across the city, in the same minutes, though I did not know it yet, Powell was standing on the steps of the Seward house on Lafayette Square, with a little package in his hand, telling the young Black servant who opened the door that he had brought medicine from Mr. Seward's doctor, and that he had orders to put it into no hands but the patient's. The servant told him he could not go up. Powell went up anyway, heavy on the stairs, and the servant followed him, protesting all the way.

Seward's son Frederick met him on the landing, and told him his father was asleep, and to give him the medicine. They argued there, at the top of the stairs, in low voices, for a minute or more. Then Powell turned as if to go down, and turned back with a revolver in his hand, and pulled the trigger, and it misfired. So he beat Frederick Seward over the head with it until the

gun broke, and went through the bedroom door with a knife. There was a soldier nurse in that room, and a daughter, and then another son, and then a messenger from the State Department who had come in the door at the wrong moment, and Powell cut every one of them who came near him, and reached the bed, and stabbed the Secretary of State in the face and the neck as he lay there with his broken jaw and his broken arm. Then he ran down the stairs and out into Lafayette Square, shouting *I'm mad! I'm mad!*, and got on his horse. Herold, who was meant to be holding it and guiding him out of a city he did not know, had heard the screaming and ridden away.

Seward lived. The metal brace on his jaw, they said, turned the knife. Nobody in that house died. I have always counted that as the one piece of luck in the whole night, and it was not mine.

Powell had ridden to Seward's door on a big dark bay that was blind in one eye. It was the horse Booth had bought from Gardiner in December, the poor horse for a rich man that the whole of Charles County had laughed about. Soldiers found it a little after midnight on the eastern edge of the city, lathered and riderless. Within a week they knew where it had been bought, and who had sold it, and that Dr. Mudd had been standing beside Booth when he paid for it.

And at the Kirkwood, the Vice President was asleep upstairs, and in the bar below him the stool where Atzerodt had sat was empty.

I had spent my ten hours well. I had bought a ticket and chosen a seat and watched a door for an hour, and walked away from it on a forged note, and the old man I had left to his sons and a locked door had been stabbed in his bed. That was what I had done with my ten hours.



Then the doors of Ford's opened wider, and the crowd went quiet in a wave, and I saw that they were carrying him out. A knot of men came down the steps, slowly, carefully, carrying something between them, and the crowd fell back and went silent in a wave that ran out ahead of them down the street. I saw a long body, and a head held in a man's hands, and a pair of long legs.

Somebody was shouting to clear the way. Somebody was shouting, *Where can we take him? Where?*

Across the street, a door opened, at the top of a flight of curving steps, in a narrow brick house, and a man stood in it with a candle, and called to them to bring him in there.

They carried him across Tenth Street and up those steps and in, and the door closed.

I stood on the pavement across from that door, in the crowd, with my cane.

And after a while I understood that the man standing next to me, very still, in a white hotel jacket, was Damon.

The Vigil

• RECORDING · APRIL 14 TO 15, 1865

We did not speak for a long time.

The soldiers came, a whole company of them at the double, and pushed the crowd back from the house and out of the street, and made a line. We were pushed back with everyone else, the two of us, and we ended up against the front of a building on the Ford's side of the street, almost opposite those curving steps, and we stood there. Neither of us left. There was nowhere either of us could have gone.

The crowd never went home. It grew. It stood in the street all night and hardly made a sound. Every so often a carriage came, and a man got down and was let through the line and went up the steps and in: a general, a senator, a member of the Cabinet, one of the President's secretaries. And every time the door opened, the whole street leaned toward it, and the door closed again, and the street settled back.

The upstairs windows were lit. Somebody said he was in a room at the back, on the ground floor, in a bed too short for him, so that they had to lay him across it slantwise. Somebody said the surgeon general was there. Somebody said there was no hope. Somebody said there was. Once or twice a doctor came out onto the steps for air, with his sleeves pushed up to the elbow, and went back in.

Damon stood beside me in his white jacket, which was too thin for the night. The fog was coming up off the river. He did not move. He watched the door.



It was past midnight when I spoke.

“You sent me to the Kirkwood.”

He did not turn his head. After a long time, he said, “Y-yes.”

“Because you thought I was holding the door for him.”

“You were s-sitting by it.” Each word pushed through. “For an hour. Watching it. Not the play.”

“I was waiting to stop him.”

He turned then, and looked at me, and I watched him read my face in the light from the windows across the street. Left to right, and down. The way he had read the newspaper in the kitchen yard, and me on the porch the morning he left. He did it slowly this time. He was looking for the lie.

He did not find one. I saw the moment he did not find one. Something in his face went, very quietly, the way a wall goes when the mortar has been washed out of it for years and it is only now, all at once, that anyone sees.

“H-how?” he said.

So I told him. Not all of it. The seat by the door. The plan to stand up and shout Booth’s name, so that the whole dress circle would turn and look and he could not go through. He listened without moving.

Then I told him what I had worked out on the pavement in the last hour, because I could not stop myself working things out, not even that night.

“And you stayed,” I said. “After I left. You never meant to stop him with your hands. You meant to tell the President’s man. The footman in livery, by the door. One servant to another. The only man in that dress circle who might have listened to a waiter.” I watched his face. “But he did not listen, or you could not get it out in time. And once the note was delivered you were only a Black man standing in the dress circle of Ford’s Theatre, with no gentleman to wait on. So an usher came and told you to go down. You went down to the lobby, to wait at the foot of the stairs, where every man going up had to pass you. And you were there when he came in from the street.”

He did not answer. He did not have to.

“Did you try to stop him?”

His jaw set. I watched him wait for the first word, the way I had watched him wait for it at the National, with that terrible patience. It would not come. His mouth worked, and nothing, and nothing, and he closed his eyes.

And I understood. I did not need him to tell me. Booth had come in off the street, and walked across the lobby past a waiter in a white jacket, and the waiter had opened his mouth to say *stop*, or *help*, or *that man*, or anything at all to anyone in that lobby. And the first sound had caught, the way it always caught. And by the time he got it out, Booth was up the stairs.

“Yes,” he said at last. Very quietly. It came without a stumble.

Then he told me the rest, in short pieces, looking at the house across the street and not at me.

“I stood in his way. At the foot of the stairs.” A breath. “The usher knew him. He took my arm and moved me to the wall, so the gentleman could pass.” Another. “I had the word ready. I never got it out. He was on the stairs by then, and the usher still had my arm.”

I had pictured him standing in that lobby, waiting for a word that would not come. I had not pictured the usher’s hand.

For a while I could not say anything at all.



We stood there a long time after that without saying anything.

I will tell you the rest of what was said between us, because it was not much, and I have remembered all of it.

Somewhere around three in the morning he said, without looking at me, “Y-you were his.”

“Until Tuesday. Yes.”

“B-before Tuesday.”

“Yes.”

“Then you p-put the gun in his hand,” he said. “As much as anyone.”

It was true. I had given Booth the road, and the bridge, and three months of my best thinking, and the mare with the white star was carrying him down every mile of it now, in the dark, while we stood there.

“Yes,” I said. “And you took away the one man who was between him and that door.”

That was true too. I watched it land. I was not sorry I had said it, and I was sorry. Both.

Neither of us said anything else for a long time.



Toward morning the sky went gray. It was a dark and gloomy morning, and rain set in, a thin, cold, steady rain that came down on all of us, and nobody left. The crowd had changed in the night. There were a great many Black men and women in it by morning, more than there had been at midnight, standing together in the rain, very quiet, and many of them weeping. I have never forgotten that. They had come from every part of the city, in the dark, and they stood there without umbrellas, and they did not make a sound.

Then the door at the top of the steps opened, and a man came out. Not one of the great men. A doctor, one of the younger ones, in his shirt, with his coat over his arm. He stood at the top of the steps for a moment in the rain, looking at nothing.

I saw it, and Damon saw it, at the same moment. I know that, because we said it at the same moment, very low, both of us:

“His sleeves.”

The doctor’s sleeves were rolled down and buttoned at the wrist. All night, every doctor who came to that door had them pushed up to the elbow.

Damon turned and looked at me. We stood there in the rain.

I had put him down, on the farm, as a word spelled wrong. Standing there, I had the strangest feeling that he was spelled wrong in the same way I was.

Then the word came down the steps, and ran out into the crowd, and went up Tenth Street and down it, the way the news had gone out from the steps of Ford’s the morning before. And the bells began. First one church, somewhere up toward the Avenue, and then another, and then all of them, all over the city, in the rain.

He had died at twenty-two minutes past seven. I learned that later.



Damon took off his hat and held it against his chest. He stood like that for a long time, with the rain on his face.

Then he put the hat back on, and turned to go.

“What will you do?” I said.

He stopped. He looked back up the street, toward the Avenue, toward the window where the man in that house had stood four nights before, in the candlelight, and talked about what came after the war. About votes, for the men who had worn the uniform.

“W-what comes next,” he said. “S-somebody has to s-see to it.”

And he walked away up Tenth Street, through the crowd, in the rain, in his thin white jacket, and did not look back. I watched him until I could not see him anymore.

I did not see him again in that life.

The Tape

He stopped, and did not start again.

My pen was still above the notebook. The last thing on the page was *the sleeves*, and under it a line that ran off into nothing where my hand had stopped. The woodstove had burned down to a red glow. The window had gone blue. I did not know when that had happened.

He was sitting with his hands flat on his knees, the way he had put them there two hours before, looking at the floor between his feet. He was not crying. I had half expected him to, and would have known what to do if he had. People cried in interviews all the time. You waited, and you did not look away, and you did not touch the recorder.

He was not crying. He looked like a man who had carried something up a very long flight of stairs and set it down at the top, and did not yet know whether he could stand up again without it.

I reached over and turned off the recorders. First the phone, then the old one. The two red lights went out.

Never once, in my whole career, had I turned off a recorder before the subject said they were done.

He looked up at the sound of the click, and saw what I had done, and for a moment something moved in his face that I did not have a word for.

"Thank you," he said.



I stayed another half hour. I did not ask him anything. I made the tea, for the first time, in his kitchen, finding the cups by opening the wrong cupboards first, and brought it to him, and he drank it, and after a while some color came back into his face.

At the door, in the dark, with my bag over my shoulder and my keys in my hand, I said, "Are you going to be all right?"

It was not a question I had ever asked a source.

"I'm always all right," he said. "That's the trouble." He tried to smile, and very nearly did. "Drive carefully. It's late for that road."



It was nearly eight when I got home.

The house was lit, every window. I sat in the car for a minute in the driveway, looking at it, before I went in.

Freda was asleep at the kitchen table, with her head on her arms on top of a chemistry textbook and her pencil still in her hand. Her phone lay face down beside the book. There was a plate by her elbow with a sandwich on it, cut into triangles, with plastic wrap over it, and a sticky note on the plastic wrap that said *MOM* in capital letters.

I stood in the doorway and looked at her for a long time.

Then I took the blanket off the back of the couch and put it over Freda's shoulders, carefully, so as not to wake her. She stirred and said something that was not a word, and did not wake. I sat down across from her and ate the sandwich, in the bright kitchen, with every light in the house on, and did not turn any of them off.



That night I did not sleep.

At eleven I woke Freda enough to walk her up to bed, one arm around her, the way I used to when she fell asleep in the car, and she said "you're back" and "how was the guy" and was asleep again before I could answer. At midnight I sat down at the kitchen table with my headphones and my laptop and began

typing up the transcript, because the lawyers wanted it by Monday and because I did not know what else to do with myself.

It was very strange, typing it. In the room, I had been inside it. At the kitchen table, with my fingers on the keys, I was outside it again, the way I had always been outside every story, and I could hear it for what it was.

It was too good.

That was the thing I kept coming back to, at two in the morning, and at three. Not the facts. The facts were the easy part; I had checked a hundred facts for him by now and they were all right, and none of them proved anything, because anyone could learn facts. It was the rest of it. The seven minutes on the bad leg. The boy on the ground in the alley asking why. The doctor at the top of the steps with his sleeves rolled down. A man standing beside him in a thin white jacket who could not get out the one word that mattered.

I had interviewed liars. Good ones, some of them. Liars tell a story from the outside. They know how it ends, so they build toward it. They give you the big moments large and clear, the shot, the leap, the famous words, because those are the parts they have read about.

He had not heard the famous words. He had been in the lobby, with a crowd screaming, and he had not heard them. He had seen the man's face, and it was the happiest he had ever seen it.

A liar would have heard the words.

At three, I stopped typing and looked it up. I searched every way I could think of for a doctor rolling down his sleeves on the steps of the Petersen House. For anyone who had noticed it, or written about it. There was nothing. There were a hundred accounts of that morning and none of them mentioned it. It was exactly the kind of detail nobody could check. Like the color of the thread.

For a long time I sat with that.

I thought: either he is the best liar I have ever met in my life, or

I did not finish the sentence. I sat at the kitchen table in the lit house and looked at the words on the screen, and I did not finish it.



At four I finished the transcript and read it through once, the way I always had, for typos. When I got to the part about the sleeves I stopped, and read it twice.

I saw it, and Damon saw it, at the same moment. I know that, because we said it at the same moment, very low, both of us: "His sleeves."

I thought about the client, whoever he was, reading this on Monday. Somebody who read carefully. Somebody who had asked about the color of a thread, and the National Hotel, and whether the old man had ever spoken to the waiter again. I wondered what he would make of the sleeves.

I attached the file to an email to Aldine, Mercer and Voss, and wrote *Session 11* in the subject line, and sent it.

Then I sat in the kitchen with every light on until the windows went gray, and it was Friday, and somewhere upstairs Freda's alarm began to go off, and went on going off, the way it did every morning, until I went up the stairs to wake her.

The Blue Coat

The payment for Session 11 landed on Monday afternoon, four days late, which it had never been. Nothing had come on Thursday.

I looked at it on my phone in the parking lot of the grocery store, and then looked again, and then sat in the car with the engine off and the groceries getting warm in the back. It was six thousand dollars. Twice the rate. The note on the transfer, instead of the session number, said: *Our client asks you to take all the time the gentleman needs.*

There was no question with it. There was no email at all.

That afternoon I called the number at Aldine, Mercer and Voss, the one I had called in the beginning. The same woman answered on the second ring. I said there must have been a mistake in the payment. The woman said there was no mistake. I asked whether the client had a question for the next session. The woman said the client did not, and that he had asked her to say, if Ms. Barnett called, that he had read the transcript with great attention, and that he was grateful.

“Grateful for what?” I said.

“He didn’t say, Ms. Barnett.”

I hung up, and sat in the car a while longer.

In eleven sessions the client had never once said anything about the story itself. He had asked his odd, narrow questions, one at a time, like a man picking a lock. He had never said whether he believed it, or liked it, or what it was for. And now he had read the part where a lame boy and a waiter said *his sleeves* in

the same breath on a street in 1865, and he had doubled my money, and he was grateful, and he did not have a question anymore.

I put the car in gear and drove home, and put the groceries away, and did not tell Freda about the money, because I did not know how to explain it.



I told him on Thursday. I read him the note from my phone.

He listened without moving. When I got to *take all the time the gentleman needs*, he looked at the mantel, at the empty frame with its polished glass, for longer than he had ever looked at it before. His face did not change. But he was quiet for a long time.

“Well,” he said finally. “That’s kind of him.”

“Is it?”

“I don’t know yet.” He turned back to me, and some of the usual dryness came back into his voice. “I find I don’t know a great many things about your client. I’m not used to that.” He picked up his pencil. “The fifteenth of April. Everybody in Washington was looking for someone. I was one of the someones.”



● RECORDING · APRIL 15, 1865

I did not go home that morning. I walked.

The city had changed in the hours we had been standing on Tenth Street. The flags from the victory were still up, but somebody had already begun hanging black crepe over them, and by noon the whole of the Avenue was black and white, the bunting of Monday and the mourning of Saturday on the same buildings. The saloons were closed by order. The theaters were closed. Soldiers were everywhere, at every corner, stopping men and asking their names.

And they were arresting people. Anyone. Everyone. A man who had said something careless about the President in a barbershop. A man who looked like Booth. Every actor in Ford’s company, and the stagehands, and the Ford

brothers who owned the theater. Anyone who had ever been seen with Booth. Hundreds of them, in those first days, until the jails were full. The ones they thought mattered most were put in irons below decks on ironclad ships in the river.

I knew, walking through it, that I was one of the people they wanted. I did not yet know how much.

I found out that afternoon.

The family I lodged with by the Navy Yard met me at the door. Their faces told me before they said a word. Two men had come that morning, detectives, in plain clothes. They had not asked for me by name. They did not have my name. They had asked whether a young man boarded there who walked with a cane. A young Marylander, lame in one leg. They had a description, the detectives said, from the desk clerk at a hotel, of a lame young man who had come in at ten o'clock on Friday night asking for John Wilkes Booth. They were going house to house along the streets to the bridge. Everyone knew by then that Booth had gone out that way.

The family had told them no. They had lied for me, to men from the War Department, the morning after the President was murdered, because my mother's people had hidden their sons in the war. They told me so, standing in the hall. They were shaking.

"You have to go," the woman of the house said. "Not for your sake. For ours."

She was right.



I sat on the edge of the bed in my narrow room and went through it, one door at a time, the way I always did. I had perhaps an hour.

What did they have? Not my name. I had kept it out of every mouth that could have given it to them: out of Weichmann's hearing, off Booth's papers. They had a clerk's description. A lame young man, a Maryland voice, a cane, asking for Booth. That was all, unless Weichmann had given them more.

But it was enough. A lame young man was a thing you could see from across a street. I could not hide the leg. I could not walk ten steps without it

announcing me. Every soldier on every corner of Washington was looking for Booth and for a lame young Marylander, and I was the second of those, and I could not stop being him.

Unless I was someone else who limped.

Washington in April of 1865 was full of lame young men. That is the thing I saw, sitting there. The hospitals were overflowing. There were thousands of wounded soldiers in that city, on crutches and in slings and on canes, in the streets every day, going to and from the hospitals and the pension offices and the railroad depots. Union soldiers. Nobody looked at them twice. Nobody could. There were too many of them.

A lame young man in a good civilian coat, asking after Booth, was a suspect.

A lame young man in Union blue was furniture.

I went down to the rag shops on Seventh Street, where the soldiers sold what they did not need and the dealers sold it on to the next soldier, and for two dollars I bought an army coat that had belonged to somebody bigger than me, faded, with a darned place at the elbow. I looked at the darn for a long moment in the shop. It had been mended with the right thread.

The dealer looked at the cane and the leg. "Discharged?" he said.

"In the winter," I said. "I sold mine the week I got home. I never wanted to see it again." I put the two dollars on the counter. "And then this morning."

He nodded. He did not need the rest. Half the men who had come into his shop that day, he told me, had said the same thing, or near it. They were going to line the Avenue when the President was carried up it, and they wanted to be in blue when they did. He threw in a forage cap for nothing.

I thanked him. I did not leave my own coat with him. A good coat left behind is a thing a man remembers. I carried it out rolled under my arm, and that night it went in the canal.

And I walked out onto Seventh Street in the uniform of the army that had shot me, with my cane, into a city full of soldiers looking for a lame young man, and not one of them looked at me.



I did not leave the city that day. I could not. The bridges were closed, all of them, and the roads out were stopped by cavalry, and every boat on the river was being searched. And there was something I had to know first.

I had to know where Booth was going.

I knew that he had crossed the Navy Yard Bridge. The sentry, a sergeant, had told the officers who questioned him that a man on a bay horse had come across late that night and given his name, and said he was going home, into Maryland, and that he had let him through. And another man, a little after, on another horse. He had let him through too.

A man going south, who says he is going home. I had written that down, on the back of an invoice, in March. They let him go.

So he was in Maryland. On my road. And there was one house on that road that he knew as well as any house in the world, because I had drawn the lane to it for him, in December, on the back of my mother's tobacco receipts.

I sat in the blue coat in a saloon doorway on Seventh Street, with the city going past me in its black crepe, and understood that John Wilkes Booth, with half the Union army behind him, might at that moment be riding up the lane to my mother's door.



He stopped.

"You went home," I said. It was not a question.

"I went home." He turned the pencil in his fingers. "Getting out of Washington that week is a story by itself. I'll tell you next time. I'm going to tell you how I found him, Ms. Barnett. Booth. I knew where he was going before the army did. I sent a frightened man home from the Kirkwood, and I found Booth. Those were the two things I got right that week." He looked at me.

“The second didn’t make any difference to him, in the end.” He put the pencil down. “Next week.”

I wrote *Seventh Street, rag shops, blue coat*, and then, underneath, because I could not help it, *the right thread*.

The Gate

On the thirteenth visit there was the hardest frost yet, white to the fence line, and the woodstove was already going hard when I came in. He had put a second blanket over the back of my chair. He did not mention it, and neither did I.

“Getting out of Washington,” I said, when the recorders were on. “You said it was a story by itself.”

“It was a very short story, in the end,” he said. “The army took me.”



• RECORDING · APRIL 16 AND 17, 1865

By Sunday morning half the Union army seemed to be going into Southern Maryland. That was where everyone believed Booth had gone, and everyone was right. Cavalry went down the roads in columns, and infantry after them, and wagons after the infantry, carrying feed and rations and tents for the men who would be searching the swamps. The roads south were closed to everyone. Everyone but the army.

I stood at the edge of a wagon yard near the Navy Yard, in my faded blue coat and my forage cap, with my cane, and watched the teamsters loading up for Bryantown.

It is a strange thing, but true, that nobody on this earth is less questioned than a wounded soldier who looks tired. I limped up to the last wagon in the line and asked the teamster, in the flattest voice I could make, whether he was going down past Bryantown, because I'd been given leave to go home and my people were down that way, and I'd walked as far as I could on this leg. He

looked at the leg. He looked at the coat. He jerked his head at the back of the wagon, and I climbed up among the sacks of oats, and we went out over the bridge that afternoon in a long column of wagons with cavalry on both sides of us, and nobody looked into the back of that wagon once.

I had left Washington in July under a load of potatoes. I came back into Charles County in April under a load of oats. I thought about that, lying there. I did not think it was funny yet.



The teamster put me down at a crossroads a mile short of Bryantown, and I walked the rest of the way home across the fields.

Bryantown was full of soldiers. I could see their tents from the ridge, and their horses in the fields, and smoke from their fires. They had come in on Saturday, the day after, a detachment of cavalry, and taken over the village. The tavern was their headquarters. Every farm for miles was being searched.

Ours had been searched on Sunday morning. I learned that on the porch, from my mother, before she had even let go of me. Soldiers had come, an officer and six men, and gone through the house and the barn and the empty cabins, politely enough, and asked whether any strangers had come by, and gone away.

"They didn't ask about you," she said. "Not your name. Nobody's asked your name." She held my face in both her hands again, the way she had in the ditch. "Kit, what are you wearing?"

"A coat," I said. "I'll tell you."

I never did.

She did not ask me anything else. She had her own grief that week, and it was not the President. The schoolmaster's letter about Ned had come to her first, before she sent it on to me, and she had read it on the porch and folded it up and put it in her apron pocket with the others. I could see the corner of it. She had not taken it out since.



It was Lottie who told me about the gate.

She found me in the barn that evening, where I had gone to be alone, and she sat down on a hay bale across from me with her arms around her knees, the way she had sat when she brought me newspapers in the summer. She was fifteen now. She had grown up in the winter, the way girls do, all at once. She looked at the blue coat and did not ask about it either.

“Somebody came to the gate,” she said. “Saturday night.”

I kept my face still.

“I was in the hayloft,” she said. “Reading. I wasn’t supposed to be. It was nearly dark. And two men came up the lane on horses, slowly, from the Bryantown road. They didn’t come to the house. They stopped at the gate.” She looked at me. “One of them got down to open it. And he fell.”

“Fell.”

“Fell down. When his foot touched the ground. Like his leg had gone out from under him. And the other one got down and helped him up, and he stood there holding onto the gate. Holding onto it like it was all that was holding him up.” She was quiet a moment. “And they looked at the house for a long time. Mama had the lamp lit in the kitchen. And then the one who fell said something to the other one, and the other one got him back up on his horse, and they went away. Not back to the road. Down across the field. Toward the swamp.”

“What time?”

“After dark. Seven, maybe.” She had thought about it; I could see it in her face. She had been thinking about it for two days. “I didn’t tell Mama. I didn’t tell the soldiers either. When they came on Sunday and asked if we’d seen any strangers.” She looked at me steadily. “I don’t know why I didn’t.”

“I do,” I said.

She waited.

“You didn’t tell them because you’d already guessed who it was,” I said. “Didn’t you.”

Lottie’s face crumpled. She had been holding it together for two days, alone, fifteen years old, with a secret like that. She put her face down on her knees.

“He was so nice to me,” she said into her knees. “He said I was a reader. He said I had ink on my finger.” And she cried, and I sat beside her on the hay bale in the dark barn and held her, and did not say anything, because there was nothing true I could say that would help.



When she had gone in, I sat alone in the barn and put it together.

A man who fell when his foot touched the ground. I had watched Booth come down onto the stage of Ford’s Theatre on one knee, and get up, and run into the wings, limping. Something had happened to that leg. Two men on horses, riding slowly. On Saturday evening, in the last light, coming up our lane from the direction of Bryantown and the doctor’s house on the other side of it.

He had come to our gate. He knew the lane. I had drawn it for him.

And then he had stood at the gate holding onto it, and looked at my mother’s lamp in the kitchen window, and not come in.

I have wondered about that ever since. I would like to believe it was the one decent thing he did that week: that he stood at the gate of a family that had been kind to him and understood what it would cost them to take him in, with the army an hour behind, and turned away to spare them. I would like to believe it. I have known men do that. It is possible.

It is more likely that he stood at the gate and saw, from there, what I had seen from the ridge that afternoon: the fires of the cavalry in the fields around Bryantown, a mile away, and understood that the lane he had studied in December now led straight into the arms of the Union army. And turned his horse toward the swamp, because the swamp was the one place in Charles County the cavalry could not ride.

I don’t know which. I never will. Most of what I know about John Wilkes Booth is like that.

But I knew where he was going.

The swamp was not a hiding place. The Zekiah was miles long, and wet, and a man with a broken leg could not live in it. It was a road. It ran south, in the dark, all the way to the river country, to the big farms along the Potomac

where the landings were and the men who had rowed people across all through the war. And the man who ran those crossings, everyone in the county knew, was a quiet fisherman down by the river named Thomas Jones. He had put more Confederate couriers across that river than anyone alive, and the Union had never managed to stop him for long.

Booth could not cross yet. Every gunboat in the Potomac flotilla was on that river now, up and down, day and night. He would have to be hidden, close to the water, and fed, and kept quiet, and wait for the right night. Somebody would have to hide him who knew the river country and was not afraid.

I sat in the barn and listened to my mother moving in the kitchen, and I knew, as well as I have ever known anything, that John Wilkes Booth was lying in the woods somewhere between our swamp and the Potomac, waiting for Thomas Jones to tell him the river was dark enough.

And I knew those woods.



He stopped.

"Lottie," I said.

"Yes."

"She was fifteen. And she kept that."

"She kept it all her life. I asked her, years later, whether she'd ever told anyone. She said no. She said she'd been waiting for someone to ask her, and nobody ever had." He looked at the window, at the frost going white on the field. "She was the best person I knew in that life. I've never been able to decide whether I did right by her."

I wrote that down. Then I sat looking at it.

"You're going to go and find him," I said. "In the woods."

"I'm going to go and find him," he said. "That's next."

The Whistle

On the fourteenth visit the field was frozen hard, and he was already in his chair with the notepad on his knee when I came in. There was no tea. The kettle was cold on the stove; I touched it on my way past, out of habit. The top page of the notepad was covered in small writing, which it never was before we started.

“Did you sleep?” I said.

“Some.” He did not look up. “I’ve been awake with this part since four. I’d like to get it said, if you don’t mind, before I think about it any more.”

I did not mind. I sat down and took out the recorders, and he started talking while I was still untangling the cord.

“I found him in two days,” he said. “It wasn’t clever. I just knew the country, and I knew who to watch.”



• RECORDING · APRIL 18 TO 23, 1865

I did not look for Booth. Booth was a man with a broken leg lying still in the woods, and a man lying still in the woods cannot be found by looking, not in that country, not by anyone. I looked for Thomas Jones.

Jones lived above the river, near Pope’s Creek, on a bluff where he could see the whole width of the Potomac and the Virginia shore beyond it. He was a quiet, thin, careful man in his forties who fished for a living and had spent the whole war doing something else. Everyone in the county knew what. Nobody said it. He had been in prison for it once, early on, and come home, and gone on doing it.

If Booth was being kept anywhere, he was being kept for Jones. And a man being kept alive in the woods has to be fed.

So I watched Jones. I took one of my mother's horses and rode down toward the river on the back roads in my blue coat, the way a Union man on leave might ride out to look at the country, and I found a place on a wooded rise across a field from the lane that led up to his house, and I lay in the leaves there with a piece of bread and my father's old spyglass, and I watched.

The country was full of soldiers. Cavalry went down the river road three and four times a day. Twice a patrol passed so close below me that I could hear the men talking about the reward. A hundred thousand dollars, one of them said, and what he would do with his share, and another one laughed at him. They rode on toward the river. They never once looked up at the rise.

Jones went about his business as if nothing in the world had happened. He fished. He mended a fence. He went to the landing and talked to the men who were watching the river for the army, pleasantly, for a long time. He was, I thought, lying there, the calmest man in Maryland.

And on the second afternoon, a little before dark, he walked out of his lane with a basket over his arm, and turned off the road, and went into the pines.

I followed him as far as I could without being seen, which was not far. The pines on that side of the road were thick, young, close-grown, the kind of thicket where you cannot see ten feet in front of you. I lost him in it almost at once. I stood at the edge of it, very still, and listened.

And from somewhere inside, not far off, I heard a whistle. Three notes. A little rising tune, like a bird that is not quite any bird.

A moment later, from deeper in the pines, somebody whistled it back.



I stood at the edge of those pines for a long time.

He was in there. A hundred yards from me, perhaps less. Lying on the ground on a blanket with his leg in splints, and Herold beside him, and Jones kneeling to open the basket. I could have walked in. I could have walked in

and stood over him. I have thought about what I would have said, many times. I have never once been able to think of anything worth the walk.

And I could have walked out. That was the other thing. I could have walked back to the road and waited for the next patrol and pointed into those pines and said *there*, and he would have been in irons by dark.

I want you to understand what that would have meant, because I understood it, standing there, all at once.

It would have meant Jones. Jones would have been taken, and Samuel Cox, the planter at Rich Hill, whose land that was and whose people had hidden them in those pines, and every man and woman in that part of the county who had carried a letter or a meal or a message that week. And the soldiers would not have stopped there, because they would not have needed to. They would have gone back up the road Booth came down, house by house. The doctor. The tavern. The farm by the swamp where two riders had stopped at the gate at dusk, and where a girl in the hayloft had seen them, and told no one, and a mother had had a lamp lit in the kitchen.

They hanged people, that summer, for a great deal less.

I stood at the edge of the pines and chose. I chose my mother, and Lottie, and a county that had hidden me and nursed me and asked me nothing, over the President of the United States, who was dead, and over the justice that was owed him, which was coming anyway. Booth could not stay in those pines forever. He could not walk. He would have to cross the river, and in Virginia he would be one crippled man among strangers, with every soldier in the Union army looking for him. He was going to be caught. I did not need to be the one who caught him here, on this shore, in the middle of everyone I loved.

But I would be the one who knew where he went.

I turned around and went back to my rise and lay down in the leaves again, and watched Jones's lane, and waited for the night he took them to the river.



It was Friday. The twenty-first. A week to the night.

A little after nine, I saw Jones come out of the pines leading a horse with a man on it, and another man walking beside, and they went down across the fields toward the bluff, slowly, without a light. I followed them as far as the top of the bluff, on my belly, the last of it.

From there I watched him put them in a boat. A small flat boat, pulled up in the reeds below. I watched Herold help Booth down into it, and Booth sit, and Jones lean down and say something to them both and point out across the water, and push them off. And I watched the boat go out into the dark on the river and turn south and west, toward Virginia, and grow smaller, and go.

Jones stood on the shore a long time after they were gone. Then he walked back up the bluff past where I lay, close enough to touch, and went home.

He never knew I was there. He told the whole story himself, years later, in a book. I have read it. I'm not in it.



They did not reach Virginia that night. I know that now; the whole country knows it. The tide and the dark took them up a creek on the Maryland side instead, miles off, and they had to hide another day and go again the next night. I did not know that then. I only knew that the boat had gone out on the river on Friday night, and that by Saturday morning, if they had any luck at all, they were in Virginia.

On Saturday and Sunday I watched the army search Maryland.

They were everywhere, and they were nowhere. They were searching the Zekiah Swamp, which Booth had left a week before. They were searching barns in Bryantown. They had questioned Dr. Mudd twice, and were arresting other men all over the county and taking them to Washington. And every hour they searched Maryland was an hour he had in Virginia.

I waited until I was sure he was across. I did not want them on Jones's shore.

On Sunday afternoon I rode into Port Tobacco, in my blue coat.

There was an officer there from Washington with a party of detectives, running the search in that part of the county from the hotel. A major, a provost marshal named O'Beirne. I had heard his name on the roads all week. I went and stood in the hotel yard among the soldiers and the horses, a lame Union private on leave, and waited until one of his detectives came out, and I told him.

I told him that I had been fishing on the Potomac below Pope's Creek on Friday night, and that I had seen a small boat put off from the Maryland shore in the dark, a little after nine, with two men in it. That one of them had been lifted into it by the other, as if he could not walk. That the boat had gone out toward the Virginia side, south and west, and had not come back.

I did not say whose shore. I did not say whose boat, or whose pines, or whose lane. I did not say a single name.

The detective looked at me a long time. He wrote it down. He asked me my regiment, and I gave him one, a Pennsylvania regiment I knew had been in the fighting around Petersburg, and he wrote that down too. He went inside.

I learned afterward, as everyone did, that on Monday morning Major O'Beirne telegraphed the War Department that he believed the men they were looking for had already crossed into Virginia. And that the War Department believed him, and that afternoon put a troop of cavalry on a steamer and sent it down the river. My report had been wrong in the one detail, and right in the one that mattered.

I did not learn that on Sunday. On Sunday, the detective came back out into the hotel yard with another man, and the other man looked at my face, and at my cane, and at my leg, and then at my face again, and said, "What's your name, soldier?"

And I heard, under the question, from somewhere behind me in the yard, one of the soldiers say to another: *a lame one. The clerk said a lame one.*



He stopped.

I had been writing fast. I looked up.

“They arrested you.”

“They arrested me.” He smiled slightly. “For the first time in that life. Not the last time in all of them.”

“For being lame.”

“For being lame, and a Marylander, in a coat that did not quite fit, with a story that was too useful.” He turned the pencil. “A clever man who is being careful does not walk into a room full of detectives with the one piece of information they need. I knew that. I did it anyway. I wanted them in Virginia. I wanted them out of my county.”

I looked at my notes, and then at him.

“You’re going to tell me how you got out,” I said.

“Somebody got me out,” he said. “I’ve never been entirely sure who.”

The Note

We broke for lunch. He heated soup, and I set the table without being asked, finding the spoons on the first try now, and we ate looking out the window at a pair of crows walking the frozen field like two men looking for something they had dropped.

"I was arrested once," I said.

He put his spoon down and looked at me with real interest, which he did not often show about me.

"I was twenty-two. I was covering a protest downtown for a paper that doesn't exist anymore, and when the police cleared the street they cleared me with it. Press pass and all." I shrugged. "Six hours in a holding cell with a woman who read palms. She told me I'd have one daughter and a lot of trouble with men who wouldn't give me straight answers."

"Was she right?"

"About the daughter." I looked at him. "Jury's still out on the other thing."

He laughed, properly, the first time I had heard him do it in weeks.

"What was the worst of it?" he said. "The six hours."

I thought about it. "Not the cell. The cell was just boring. It was being sure, every minute, that somebody out there was about to notice the mistake and come and let me out. And nobody did, until they did."

"Yes," he said. "That's the worst of it. Every time." He picked up his spoon again. "The first night, you think the mistake is the arrest. It takes a few days to understand that from their side there isn't one."

"How many times?"

“In all of them?” He considered it, the way another man might count his children. “Enough that I’ve stopped keeping the number. Not enough that I’ve stopped minding.”

He ate a little more. The crows had found whatever it was, out in the field, and were arguing over it.

I had used his bathroom that morning, and noticed something I should have noticed weeks before. There was no mirror over the sink. There was a pale rectangle on the wallpaper where one had been, and two screw holes, painted over. I had not seen a mirror anywhere else in the house either, now that I thought about it. It explained the cardigan.

“You don’t have a mirror,” I said.

“No.”

“Anywhere?”

“I stopped keeping them a few lives ago.” He did not seem to mind the question. “It’s never the face I’m expecting.”

“You’ll want to know what they had on me,” he said. “It wasn’t much. It didn’t need to be.”



• RECORDING · APRIL 23 TO 28, 1865

They took me to Washington in a wagon, with my hands tied, with two other men from the county who had been picked up that week: a farmer who had sold a pair of boots to the wrong stranger, and a boy who had been heard to laugh when he was told the President was dead. We did not speak to each other the whole way. We went up the road I had come down under a load of oats, and over the Navy Yard Bridge, and past the end of it where I had sat with a borrowed horse on the seventeenth of March.

They put us in the Old Capitol Prison. It had been the Capitol once, when the British burned the real one, and it had been a boarding house after that, and in the war it had become a prison, a big shabby brick building across from the new Capitol dome, full of spies and blockade runners and

Southern ladies and anyone the government did not know what else to do with. That week it was full to the attic with men from Southern Maryland.

When they asked my name, I gave them the one I had settled on in the wagon, somewhere south of the bridge. Christopher Hurley, of St. Mary's County. Not Keene; Booth's people knew Keene, and some of them were in that building. Christopher, because a man answers to his own first name without thinking, and a man who has to think before he answers is a man who is lying. And Hurley, because it belonged to a boy from the next county, with a voice like mine, whom nobody alive in Washington had ever met. It was the only thing of Ned's I had left, and he would have lent it to me without a second thought.



On the second day they brought the clerk from the Kirkwood House.

They stood me in a room with four other men, all about my age, all of us in whatever we had been arrested in, and they made us walk, one at a time, from one wall to the other. The clerk stood by the door with an officer beside him. When it was my turn I walked, and my leg did what it always did, and I watched the clerk's face.

He did not hesitate. "That's him," he said. "He asked for Mr. Booth. Ten o'clock Friday night. He asked when Mr. Booth left his card, and then he ran out the door."

"Ran?"

"As best he could, sir. With the leg."

The officer wrote it down.

That was what they had. It was enough to hang a man that month. A lame Marylander, wearing a coat that was not his and a name that was not his, who had asked for Booth at the Kirkwood House at the very hour of the murder, and had then run toward Ford's. Who had been found nine days later in the heart of the county Booth had fled through, walking into a room of detectives with a story about a boat. The officer who questioned me that afternoon, a tired colonel with a very clean desk, put it to me in almost those words, and asked me whether I had anything to say.

I had a great deal to say, and none of it could be said. I could not tell him why I was at the Kirkwood without telling him why I knew Booth. I could not tell him how I knew about the boat without telling him about the pines, and Jones, and my mother's gate.

So I said nothing. I let him think what he liked. I lay on a straw tick in a room with nine other men for three days and three nights, and I thought about rope.



On the morning of the twenty-seventh, the newspapers came in.

We were not supposed to have them. A guard sold them for a quarter, and a man by the window read them out loud to the rest of us, in a low voice, while we sat on the floor and listened.

Booth was dead.

The cavalry had found him in Virginia, the paper said, a long way south of the river, on a farm near a place called Port Royal, hiding in a tobacco barn. A farmer named Garrett had taken him in, thinking he was a wounded Confederate soldier going home. In the small hours of the twenty-sixth, the soldiers had surrounded the barn and called on him to come out. Herold had come out and surrendered. Booth would not. So they set the barn on fire. And while it burned, a sergeant had fired his pistol through a crack between the boards and shot him through the neck, against orders, and they had dragged him out of the flames onto the porch of the farmhouse, alive, paralyzed, and he had lived a few hours more.

The man by the window read out what Booth had said at the end. That he had asked them to tell his mother he died for his country. And that near the end, when they lifted his hands so that he could see them, he had looked at them and said, *Useless. Useless.*

Nobody in that room said anything for a long time.

I sat on the floor with my back against the wall and thought about the cavalry that had found him. The paper said they had gone down the river by steamer on the twenty-fourth, acting on information. It did not say what in-

formation. It did not need to. I knew what I had said in a hotel yard in Port Tobacco on Sunday afternoon, and I knew what day the steamer had sailed.

He had been going to be caught. I had known that at the edge of the pines. But I had sent them after him, in the end, with a story about a fishing trip, and they had gone, and they had found him, and he had died on a porch in Virginia looking at his hands.

I would like to tell you I felt something clean. I did not. I felt tired, and sick, and I thought of him on the church step in Charles County, playing a whole theater fire for his mother, and I thought of the President getting down from his carriage outside Ford's, tired, standing a moment on the pavement before he went in. And I found I could not tell which of them I was grieving for. That frightened me more than the rope.



The colonel sent for me again on the afternoon of the twenty-eighth.

He had a letter on his desk. He did not show it to me. He kept his hand flat on it while he talked, the way you keep a hand on a thing that might blow away.

"This came to the War Department on Tuesday," he said. "Unsigned. It concerns you. I'll tell you what it says, and you'll tell me whether any of it's true."

The letter said that the lame young man the Kirkwood clerk had described, the one the detectives were already hunting, had been seated in the dress circle of Ford's Theatre on the night of the fourteenth, from half past eight, nearest the door to the President's box. That at about twenty-five minutes to ten he had been handed a note by a man in a hotel waiter's jacket, and had got up and left the theater at once. That the usher at the head of the dress circle stairs would remember it, because the lame man had nearly fallen on the stairs going down. That he had gone to the Kirkwood House, and spoken to a German drinking at the bar, and that the German had left the hotel immediately afterward without going upstairs; and that the bartender would remember that too.

"We found the usher," the colonel said. "He remembers the stairs. We found the bartender. He says a lame man leaned on the bar next to Atzerodt and told him to go home. He heard that much. Go home. And Atzerodt put his money down and went." He looked at me. "So you left Ford's forty minutes before the President was shot. And you went to the Kirkwood, where the Vice President was asleep upstairs, and you sent home the man who was supposed to kill him."

I said nothing.

"And on Sunday you told Major O'Beirne's man that the murderer had crossed into Virginia. Which he had."

I said nothing.

The colonel sat back. He was a tired man, and a careful one, and I think he had been a lawyer before the war, and would be one after.

"I don't know what you are, Mr. Hurley," he said. "I don't believe that's your name, and I don't believe you went fishing. But I know what you did on Friday night, because somebody took the trouble to tell me. Unsigned, in the finest hand that has come across this desk all month, and I've had senators' letters on it. An educated man. Somebody who was in that theater himself, I'd guess, and has a name he'd rather keep out of all this. Half the men in that house on Friday were somebody. But every word of it checked." He tapped the letter with one finger. "Whatever you were before that, I've got a building full of men who did less than you did that night and deserve the rope more. Go home."

He did not show me the letter. I asked him who had sent it. He said he did not know, and I believed him.

I walked out of the Old Capitol Prison into the afternoon, across from the great white dome of the Capitol, and stood on the pavement, and thought about the finest hand the colonel had ever seen. He had pictured a gentleman with a name to protect. It would never once have crossed his mind that it belonged to a hotel waiter. It had crossed mine at a desk in the Kirkwood House, with the clock over it saying eight minutes past ten. And I thought about a man in a white jacket who had stood by the door in the dress circle and watched me go down the stairs, and had seen me nearly fall.

He had sent me to the Kirkwood. He would have wanted to know what I did there. He must have gone and asked the bartender himself.

I thought I knew. I have never been certain. I have thought about it every year since, and I have never once been certain.



He stopped.

"He saved your life," I said. "If it was him."

"If it was him." He was looking at the window. "It would have been easier for him not to. Much easier. A Black man writing to the War Department that month, about the assassination, about a white man he'd sent out of a theater with a false message: that was not a safe letter to write. He must have known the handwriting could be traced. He wrote it anyway." He was quiet for a moment. "And he never signed it. So I would never have to owe him anything."

I looked down at my notebook. After a moment I said, not quite to him, "At least somebody wrote something down."

"Hm?"

"Nothing. It's just." I turned a page back and forth. "They had a file on you. Two pages, and a letter, but a file. Bookbinder kept copies of everything. That was the whole point of him. Two banker's boxes of paper, in his apartment, in the closet by the door. I saw them the one time I was there. Everything he'd ever copied at Carrow, every invoice, every letter he'd been asked to repair." I shook my head. "There's nothing about them in the police report. Not a word. *Desk*. That's all it says. A desk." I closed the notebook. "I always figured he took them with him."

He did not say anything. He looked at me for a moment, very still, the way a man listens for one wrong note, and then he looked at the floor by my chair, as if the box of *CARROW* I had not brought were sitting there, and then back at the window.

"Next week," he said, "the trial."

The Arsenal

“You’ve read about her,” he said. “Since I told you her name.”

“Everything I could find.”

“Then you know what she’s famous for. Being the first.” He looked at the fire. “I want to tell you what she was to me. It isn’t the same.”

It was the fifteenth visit. The payment for the last session had come on Monday, double again, with the same note, and I had stopped being surprised by it and started being uneasy. I had not said so to him. I thought he knew.

Before we started, because he asked, I told him the school business was dragging on. Mr. Ostrowski had called both girls in on Monday and laid the two write-ups side by side on his desk, and Freda said you could hardly tell them apart, they even had the same weird numbers in the tables, and then Freda had cried in the car, which she never did. He listened, and nodded, and asked whether the gutter people had paid yet.



• RECORDING · MAY AND JUNE, 1865

I did not go home when they let me out. I could not face my mother yet, or Lottie, with everything I could not tell them. I went back to the lumber merchant on the waterfront, in my blue coat. I told him my name was Hurley now. He looked at me for a long moment and gave me my old stool back and called me Hurley from then on, and did not ask why. A great many people in Washington did not ask each other things that spring.

The trial began in May, at the Arsenal, down at the point where the Eastern Branch meets the Potomac, in the old penitentiary there. Not in a courtroom. The government would not risk a jury, not in a city where half the jurors might be Marylanders. It was a military commission: nine officers at a long table, generals and colonels, deciding in a room on the third floor of a prison. There were eight people accused. Mrs. Surratt was the only woman.

They let the public in, by pass. The newspapers printed every word of the testimony the next morning, pages of it, in small type. I read every page. And some days, when I could get a pass from a man at the lumber yard whose brother was a clerk at the War Department, I went.

I went the day Weichmann testified.



They sat the prisoners on a raised platform along one wall, in a row, with a soldier between each of them. The men wore irons on their wrists and ankles, and heavy chains between. Mrs. Surratt sat at the end, in black, with a veil over her face and a fan in her hand, and she did not wear irons. She hardly moved.

I sat at the back among the spectators in my blue coat, and I watched Louis Weichmann walk to the witness chair.

He had not changed. Plump, soft-spoken, polite. He had gone to the police himself, I learned later, within a day or two of the murder, and told them everything he knew, and they had kept him close ever since. He did not look at the prisoners. He looked at the commission, and he answered their questions for hours, in his careful clerk's voice, and he remembered everything.

He remembered every visit Booth had made to the house on H Street. He remembered Atzerodt, and the bottles, and Powell as Wood and Powell as the Reverend Paine. He remembered driving Mrs. Surratt to her tavern on the afternoon of the fourteenth, and the package she carried, done up in paper, and Booth talking with her before they left. He remembered it all, in order, with dates.

I sat at the back and listened to him, and remembered the first night I saw him, reading by the lamp in the parlor on H Street, and what I had told

Booth about him afterward, under a streetlamp: *if this ever goes wrong, that one will talk*. Booth had laughed and called him harmless. I had kept my name out of his hearing from that night on. It was not much protection. He had seen my face across that parlor, and my cane, and he remembered everything.

So I waited. Every time he came to a new day, I waited for him to say *and a lame young man who came with Booth*. He did not mention me. Not once, in all those hours. I have never known why. I have had a very long time to wonder, and I still do not know.

I had been right that he would talk, and something in him I never understood had saved my neck. And I sat there and watched that careful memory of his tie a rope, one date at a time, around the neck of the woman who had given him a room and fed him at her table all winter. I did not feel lucky. I did not feel anything I have a good word for.



John Lloyd testified too, the man who had leased her tavern. He was the worst of it, for her. He said that in March, John Surratt and Herold and Atzerodt had brought two carbines to the tavern and hidden them in the ceiling. He said that on the afternoon of the fourteenth, Mrs. Surratt had come to the tavern and handed him a package, and told him to have the shooting irons ready that night, because they would be called for. And that at midnight Booth and Herold had come, and he had given them the whiskey, and the carbine, and the package, which was a pair of field glasses.

And the officers who had arrested her testified that on the night of the seventeenth, while they were in her parlor taking her away, a knock had come at the door, near midnight, and it was Powell. Filthy, with a pickaxe on his shoulder, saying he had come to dig a gutter. And that when they asked her whether she knew him, she had raised her hand and said, *Before God, sir, I do not know this man*.

He had eaten at her table, as the Reverend Paine, for days.



I spent that spring doing what I always do. I took the thing apart, piece by piece, and looked at each piece.

The kidnapping: she knew. I was sure of that before the trial began, and nothing in it changed my mind. She had watched the men come and go in her house all winter. She had heard John talk, and John could never keep a secret he could boast of. She knew about the carbines in March, the ones hidden in her own ceiling; they were bought for the kidnapping, to hold off pursuit on the road south. She had known and said nothing, the way she said nothing about anything she did not want to know.

The murder: I did not believe she knew. And I had one thing, in all that trial, that nobody on that commission had.

I had stood on the corner of H Street at half past two on the fourteenth and watched Booth go into the house, and come out again, and go. And then I had watched her come out with that package, after his visit, and put it in the buggy without looking at it. Without opening it, or weighing it in her hand, or turning it over to see what it was. She had carried it the way she carried everything for the men in her house: as an errand, to be done and not asked about.

A woman who knows she is carrying the field glasses for a murderer's escape looks at the package. She cannot help it. I have watched a great many people carry things they knew to be terrible, in a great many lives, and they all look. They hold it as if it were hot. She had held it like a loaf of bread.

And the words she gave Lloyd, *have the shooting irons ready*: those were the words of the kidnapping. Those guns had been waiting in that ceiling for a month, for the road south with the President in a carriage. She had passed the message on, as she passed on everything. I did not think she had asked what they would be used for now. I did not think she had wanted to know.

And Powell at the door: she had lied. Of course she had lied. She had known him for weeks. But a woman with soldiers in her parlor, at midnight, being taken from her own house, who sees a filthy man with a pickaxe on her step and says *I do not know him*, is a frightened woman lying about a boarder.

That is not the same as knowing he had spent Friday night stabbing the Secretary of State in his bed.

All of the kidnapping. None of the murder. That was my answer, and I have never changed it.

It was the same line I had walked. I had known all of the kidnapping too. I had drawn them the road. The only difference between us was that I had got out on the eleventh of April, on a lawn, in the candlelight, when Booth said *the last speech he will ever make*, and she had not been standing there to hear it.



The commission gave its verdict at the end of June. It was kept secret for a week.

On the sixth of July, the newspapers said it. Four of them to hang: Powell, Herold, Atzerodt, and Mary Surratt. The others to prison. The hangings were set for the next day. One day's notice.

Years later it came out that five of the nine officers who tried her had signed a letter asking the President to spare her, because of her age and because she was a woman. He said he had never seen it. The judge advocate said he had shown it to him. People have argued about that ever since.

And a story went around, in those days, secondhand, the way stories do: that the President had said of her that she kept the nest that hatched the egg. I do not know if he said it. I heard it from a man at the lumber yard who had heard it from someone. But I remember thinking, when I heard it, that it was the truest thing anyone said about her that summer, and that it was not a reason to hang her.

I had kept the nest too. I had drawn it on my mother's tobacco receipts.



That night, the sixth of July, I sat at my table in a rented room on the waterfront and did the only thing I could think of. I wrote a letter.

I wrote it to the President. I wrote that I had been present in Washington in April and had reason to know that Mrs. Surratt had known of a plan to seize President Lincoln, but not of any plan to kill him; that on the afternoon of the fourteenth she had carried a package from Booth without looking at it, as a woman carries an errand she does not understand; that her crime was silence, not murder, and that silence was the crime of half of Maryland that winter. I wrote it as clearly and as plainly as I could. I wrote it three times, until every word was right.

I did not sign it. I could not sign it. To sign it was to put my own neck beside hers.

I walked it up the Avenue to the President's house at midnight, holding it inside my coat, and gave it to the doorkeeper, who took it without looking at me and put it on a pile with the others. There was a pile. It was a big one. Half of Washington was writing to the President that night.

I walked home down the Avenue. And somewhere around Seventh Street, I stopped, in the dark, and stood still for a long time.

A man writing a letter at midnight, three times over, until every word was right. Not signing it. Walking it out into the night toward the President's house.

I had seen that before. In the dining room of the National, on the thirteenth of April, by one lamp. I had thought it was a love letter.



He stopped. His hand had gone still on the notepad.

I sat very still.

"Damon," I said. "The night before. He was writing to Lincoln."

"I think so. I've thought so ever since that night on Seventh Street." He looked down at his hand, and moved it off the page. "I never knew for certain. I never saw it. He never told me. But I think that man sat up writing a warning to the President of the United States, in the best hand in Washington, and walked it to the door himself. And they put it on a pile." He was quiet a moment. "Like mine."

"Did yours do anything?"

“She was hanged the next afternoon,” he said. “At the Arsenal. At half past one.” He picked up his pencil again. “I was there. That’s next week. I’d like to stop.”

I turned off the recorders myself, before he asked me to.

July the Seventh

He was sitting on the porch when I drove up, in his coat, in the cold, the way he had been the week of the Kirkwood. He did not get up. When I came up the steps he moved over on the bench to make room, and I sat down beside him, and for a while neither of us said anything. Our breath went up white.

"I'd like to tell this one out here," he said. "If you don't mind the cold. It was very hot that day. I find I don't want to be warm while I tell it."

I put the phone on the bench between us and turned it on, and did not bother with the other recorder.



• RECORDING · JULY 7, 1865

It was a terrible day for heat. People said afterward it had been a hundred degrees in the sun, and I believe it. The air in the Arsenal yard sat on you like a hand.

I had a pass. The man at the lumber yard whose brother was a clerk had got me one, and he had not asked me why I wanted it, and I did not tell him. There were a great many passes. The yard was full of people by noon: soldiers, mostly, lined up along the walls in the heat, and officers, and newspapermen, and a few others like me, standing in whatever shade there was. Some men had climbed onto the prison wall to see better. A photographer had set up his camera on a roof across the yard, with his black cloth over his head, waiting.

In the middle of the yard was the scaffold. It was new. You could smell the fresh-cut pine from where I stood. It had been built the day before, and they had tried the traps that morning with weights, and the sound of them dropping had carried all over the Arsenal. Beside it, in the dirt, four graves had been dug, and four plain pine boxes laid beside the graves.

Men had been trying all morning to stop it. I learned that later. Her lawyers had got a judge to order her brought before him, and the order had been carried to the Arsenal gate, and the President had set it aside. Her daughter, Anna, had gone to the President's house that morning to beg for her mother's life, and had not been let in to see him. She had sat on the stairs and wept, people said. Nobody who could have stopped it would see anyone.

And my letter was somewhere on a pile.



At a little after one o'clock, a door in the prison wall opened, and they brought them out.

Mrs. Surratt came first. She could hardly walk. Two soldiers held her up, one on each side, and two priests walked with her, praying, and she was in black, with a veil. Someone was holding an umbrella over her head against the sun. It was the only kindness I saw that day: shade, for a woman who had half an hour to live.

Then Herold, looking about him the way he always had, like a boy at a fair, with his face gone white. Then Powell, tall and straight and perfectly calm, in a sailor's shirt, looking out over all of us as if we were not there. Then Atzerodt, in a gray coat, shaking so that you could see it across the yard.

They went up the steps. They sat in four chairs at the edge of the platform, with the umbrellas held over them, while an officer read out the orders in the heat, at length, and the ministers prayed, at length. It took a long time. The soldiers along the walls shifted in the sun. Somewhere a man fainted and was carried away.

I did not look away. I had decided that, on the walk down to the Arsenal. I owed her that much, at least. I did not look away once.



I will not tell you all of it. You can read it. It is all written down, and there are the photographs, from the camera on the roof: the four of them in their chairs under the umbrellas, and then standing, and then the other one. You have probably seen them. Everyone has.

I will tell you two things.

The first is that Atzerodt spoke at the end, standing on the trap with the rope around his neck, in his thick German voice, which shook. He said good-bye, and that he hoped we would all meet in another world. I thought of him at the bar in the Kirkwood House, looking at me in the mirror with that terrible hope in his face, and putting his money down, and going out without once looking at the stairs. He had never gone up to the Vice President's door. He had never touched him. He had gone home, the way I told him to, and they had hanged him anyway, for the room upstairs and the knife in it and the questions he had asked the bartender. For what he had been ready to do, and had not done.

I had given him leave to fail. It had not been enough.

The second is that the traps fell at half past one, and it was very quick, and the sound of it was the same sound the weights had made that morning, and I heard it all over the Arsenal, and I have heard it ever since.

Then it was very quiet in the yard, in the heat, for a long time.



I went home to Charles County the next week.

I told the lumber merchant I was going, and he shook my hand and said, *Good luck to you, Hurley*, and I said *good luck* back, and never saw him again. I burned the blue coat in the stove at the lumber yard, the way I had burned the receipts. I walked out over the Navy Yard Bridge in a farm coat I had bought for the purpose, and the sentry did not look at me. The war was over. Nobody stopped the ones going home anymore.

My mother was on the porch when I came up the lane. Lottie was in the hayloft; I saw her face at the little window before she came running. The tobacco was in. It had been planted in May without me, by my mother and Lottie and old Hester and two men they had hired from Bryantown for wages, and it was coming on well.

My mother held my face in her hands. She did not ask me where I had been. She never did, not once, for the rest of her life.

"You're home," she said.

"I'm home," I said.

It was true, as far as it went. It was the only home that body ever had, and I stayed in it to the end. I always do. I don't get to choose when I leave. One day I wake up somewhere else, in someone else, and sometimes I remember how the last one ended, and sometimes I don't.



He was quiet then.

I sat beside him on the cold bench and looked out at the field. The frost had gone off it in the sun, and it was brown and bare, and a hawk was going round and round over the far end of it, very high.

"That's the end," I said. "Of 1865."

"That's the end of 1865."

I reached down and turned off the phone. I did not know what I was supposed to say. In all my years of interviews I had never once not known what to say at the end of one.

"Thank you," I said at last. "For telling me."

He looked at me, surprised, as if nobody had ever said that to him before. Perhaps nobody had.

"Thank you for listening to it," he said. "I don't think anyone ever has. Not all of it. Not in order." He looked back at the hawk. "It turns out it's heavier in order."

We sat on the porch until I was too cold to feel my hands. Then he stood up, slowly, one hand on the rail, and said he supposed I would want my lunch, and we went in.

The Scale

It was a strange lunch. It was the first one in sixteen visits that was not in the middle of anything. 1865 was over. I did not know quite what we were supposed to talk about now, and I do not think he did either, and so, for a while, we did not talk at all. He made grilled cheese, because the soup had run out, and apologized for it, and I said it was the best thing I had eaten all week, which was true.

Then, halfway through the second half of my sandwich, he said, “Your man didn’t take his files.”

I put the sandwich down.

“Bookbinder,” he said. “You told me two things. Weeks apart. You told me that the police found his family photographs still on the living room wall. And two weeks ago you told me that he kept two boxes of papers in the closet by the door, and that the police found no papers at all.” He wiped his fingers on a napkin, carefully, one at a time. “You said you always figured he took them with him.”

“He must have.”

“A man who runs,” he said, “and has time to pack, takes his photographs first and his papers if he can carry them. He doesn’t leave his mother’s face on the wall and his cat shut in a bedroom and remember to take two banker’s boxes.” He looked at me. “Your man left the photographs on the wall and the cat in the bedroom, and the files were gone. That isn’t a man packing to run. That’s two different people. One of them lived there, and meant to come home. The other one came in after him, and knew exactly what to take.”

"Not after him," I said. "He let them in."

He looked at me.

"I called Petrakis. Weeks ago." I told him about Pearl, and the door, and the pressing machine. "He only shut her in when somebody came to the door. Petrakis made him promise, after the second time she got out."

He looked at me for a moment, and I could see he was pleased, and that it was with me and not the news.

"You checked," he said. "Good." Then it went out of his face. "Then it's worse than I said. He didn't open that door to a stranger. He put the cat away for somebody he knew."

I sat at his kitchen table with half a sandwich in front of me and six years going over in my head like pages in a wind. The report I had read over and over since I took the box down. *Framed family photographs on living room wall. Desk. The closet by the door. The cat.*

Then I heard how certain it sounded, and the part of me that used to do this for a living sat up.

"Somebody came to the door," I said. "That's all the cat tells you. He shut her in for anybody. Petrakis said so."

He thought about it. "Yes," he said. "Fair."

"And the boxes. The officer wrote down the cat and the dishes and the photographs because they were in front of him. Two boxes in a closet, he could have looked straight at and never written down. That report doesn't prove anything that isn't in it."

"No," he said. "It doesn't. It's a reason to ask, that's all." He picked up the plates. "But you couldn't see it until you set the boxes down next to the photographs, and you'd never said the two things out loud in the same month until you said them to me. I've wanted to tell you for some time. I didn't know how you'd take it."

"How am I supposed to take it?"

"The way you take everything," he said. "By checking."



He walked me out to the car at three. The hawk was still over the field, or another one like it.

I had the door open and one foot in when he said, "Oh. Tell Freda something for me."

I looked up.

"Tell her to ask Mr. Ostrowski to weigh something on her scale."

"Her scale."

"At her bench. The one that reads everything two percent heavy." He had his hands in his cardigan pockets. "You told me about it back in the fall, the same day you told me about the bow ties. She had to write an extra paragraph explaining why her whole lab came out wrong."

I did remember. I had told it as a joke. "What about it?"

"Last week you told me the other girl's write-up had the same weird numbers in it."

"It does. That's the whole problem. They're the same."

"The same wrong numbers," he said. "Two percent heavy. Every one."

I stood there with my hand on the car door, and I felt it begin to turn over, the way things did around him, a little before I could see what was underneath.

"Nobody else in that room weighed anything on Freda's scale," he said. "Their scales worked. If the other girl had done that lab herself, at her own bench, she'd have got the right answers. She has Freda's wrong ones." He lifted one shoulder. "That doesn't prove who copied whom. It proves where the numbers were weighed. That's enough to make him look again. And I know which way I'd bet."

"Freda won't say that. She won't say a word against her."

"No," he said. "You told me that too. She's protecting a friend. Even now, with the friend letting her take the blame." He said it gently, as if he liked Freda for it. "So she doesn't have to say anything against anybody. She only has to ask Mr. Ostrowski to put a weight on her scale, and let the scale do the talking."

I stood there. Weeks of Freda going quiet at the dinner table, and the answer had been sitting in a joke I told him back in the fall.

"When did you work this out?"

“Last week, when you said the numbers were the same. Before that it was only a hunch.” He shrugged a little. “I wasn’t going to hand you a hunch about your daughter.”

“Last week?” My voice went up. “Why didn’t you say?”

He took a moment before answering. “I had just told you about the Arsenal. I sent you home early because I wasn’t fit to think about anything else.” He looked at me. “But I should have told you before you left. I’m sorry.”

I stood there a moment longer, trying to think of what to say. He waited, but nothing came, and eventually I got into the car. He shut the door for me, and I turned around on the gravel and drove home with the radio off.

Twice I reached for my phone to call her, then thought better of it. I wanted to be there when I told her, to see her face and hear what she said.

Somewhere past Frederick, I caught myself saying the words out loud. *Ask Mr. Ostrowski to weigh something on your scale.* I said them again, the way I used to rehearse the first question of an interview I was afraid of. There were only nine words, but I kept going over them, making sure I had them right.



Freda was at the kitchen table. Every light was on. The phone was face down beside the chemistry book.

I hung up my coat and put my bag on the chair, but I did not sit down. All the way home I had thought about how to say it, and in the end I just said it.

“Ask Mr. Ostrowski to weigh something on your scale.”

Freda looked up.

“What?”

“Your scale. At your bench. The one that’s two percent off.” I sat down across from her. “If the other write-up has your numbers in it, it has your wrong numbers. Their scale worked. They’d have gotten it right if they’d done it themselves. You don’t have to say anything about anybody. Just ask him to weigh something.”

Freda did not move. I watched her face do the thing it did when she was working out a problem, the little frown between her eyebrows that she had had

since she was four years old. I watched it get there. Her eyes went to the phone, and away, and back.

Then Freda put her pencil down very carefully.

“How did he know about the scale?”

I had not expected that. “I told him.”

“You told him about my scale.”

“I told him about you,” I said. “I tell him about you every week.” And then, because it was true, and because I was tired of not saying true things in my own kitchen: “You’re my favorite thing to talk about. You always have been.”

Freda looked at me for a long moment. Her face did something complicated, and then something simpler.

“That’s so embarrassing,” she said. And then she put her head down on her arms on top of the chemistry book, and her shoulders started to shake, and it took me a moment to understand that she was crying, and a moment more to get around the table.



It took four days.

On Monday Freda asked Mr. Ostrowski. On Tuesday, she told me that night, he put a hundred-gram weight on her scale in front of her, and it said a hundred and two, and he looked at her write-up, and at the other one, and at the extra paragraph at the end of hers. The other one had every one of her wrong numbers, and no paragraph at all. He took off his glasses and cleaned them for a long time. On Wednesday he kept Maddie after class, and Maddie told him: she had copied Freda’s numbers at our kitchen table, the afternoon she came over to look at the lab, and then been too frightened to say so. Freda heard that part from Maddie herself, at lunch, and told me that night with her eyes on her plate. There was a meeting in the vice principal’s office that Freda was not in; I knew of it only because the school left a message on my phone. On Thursday, Maddie’s mother called me, and was very quiet on the phone, and apologized for something she did not quite name, and I was kinder to her than I had planned to be.

The next Thursday I drove up anyway. The client had not said stop, and the money had come on Monday the way it always did, and I told myself that was the reason. It was not. I wanted to tell him.

He asked about Freda before I had my coat off. I told him all of it, Monday and Tuesday and the weight that said a hundred and two, and he listened with his eyes closed and said “Good,” once, at the end. There was no more 1865 to tell, and neither of us pretended there was. We spent the rest of the afternoon splitting kindling behind the house, which he said I had been doing wrong my whole life, and he was right. The recorders stayed in my bag.

That night I came home, and hung up my coat, and put my bag on the chair.

Freda was at the kitchen table, doing her chemistry. The phone was beside the book. It was face up. While I watched, it lit up with a message, and Freda glanced at it, and snorted at whatever it said, and typed something back with one thumb, and put it down again. Face up.

Only the kitchen light was on. The rest of the house was dark.

I stood in the doorway and looked at my daughter for a long time.

I had taken the job for the money. I would have said so to anyone. Three thousand dollars a session, for an old man’s stories, from a client who knew too much. My plan had been to do my ten sessions and cash the checks and pay off the car and be done with it.

The ten sessions had been over for seven weeks, and I had not stopped. I had told myself it was the double payments, or the story, or the not being able to leave a thing half finished, which had always been my worst habit.

Standing in the doorway, I knew that I would go back next Thursday, and the Thursday after that, for as long as he would have me. And that it was not for the money anymore, and not for the story, and not for the client, whoever he was.

It was for the phone, face up, on my kitchen table.

The Pile

They put it on a pile. Like mine.

I could not stop thinking about it. Not the hanging, not Atzerodt, not the sleeves, though I thought about all of those. The pile. A waiter writing a warning to the President three times over, until every word was right, and walking it to the door himself, and the doorkeeper putting it on a pile with the others.

Piles got kept. That was the thing I knew, that he might not. I had spent twenty years in archives and records offices and the back rooms of county courthouses, and I knew that governments almost never threw anything away. They filed it. They filed it badly, and lost it, and forgot it, but they kept it.

That Thursday night, after Freda was asleep, I took the *CARROW* box down again and read the police report through with a pencil. *Framed family photographs on living room wall. Desk.* Nothing about any papers. I sat on the closet floor with it for a long time.

In the morning I did the two things you do when you have a theory and no proof. I asked the police department for the whole file, not just the report: the officer's notes, any photographs, whatever was behind it. And I found the movers. They were still in business, the same small outfit from across the river, and the woman who answered said they kept their job sheets seven years. I told her what I wanted. Who had booked the job, and when, and whether there was an address to take it to, or a number to call that wasn't his.

She called back that afternoon. The job had been booked by phone, eleven days before he disappeared, with a deposit in cash. The line for the new address was blank. Under it, somebody had written *Customer to call with address.*

He never called.

So on the Monday after Maddie's mother called, when Freda had gone to school with her phone face up in her hand, I drove to the Library of Congress.



The Lincoln Papers were easy. That was the first surprise. Almost all of them had been put online years ago, twenty thousand documents, photographed and indexed, letters to Lincoln and from him, every scrap his son had kept. I had sat up the whole of Sunday night scrolling through April of 1865 on my laptop at the kitchen table. There were letters of warning in it. Lincoln had got them by the hundred, all through the war; a friend of his had written, afterward, that Lincoln kept them stuffed in a pigeonhole in his desk and told him he had filed eighty just like them. Some of them were in the papers. Crude, some of them. Some with drawings. None of them in a beautiful hand. None of them dated the thirteenth of April.

But the papers online were only what Lincoln's son had handed over. His two secretaries, Nicolay and Hay, had spent years afterward writing Lincoln's life, and Nicolay, I found at two in the morning, had kept envelopes of his own: material he had set aside and never used. Notes. Clippings. Private letters. Papers that had come through the President's office in the last days and had never been sorted into anything. They were at the Library of Congress too, in his own collection. Most of that had been put online as well. But not all of it. A few boxes had come in long after the rest, from a relative's estate, and had been catalogued in a single line and never scanned.

At a quarter to nine I was on the steps of the Madison Building with a new reader card in my wallet, with a photograph that was, if anything, worse than the one from the Archives.



The Manuscript Reading Room was quiet in the particular way of rooms where people are handling things that cannot be replaced. Long tables. Green-

shaded lamps. A reference librarian with reading glasses on a chain, who listened to what I wanted and looked at me over the glasses for a moment.

“Nicolay,” she said. “The later addition. Some of that hasn’t been out of the stacks in a very long time.”

“How long?”

The librarian checked something on her screen. “That box? Nobody’s requested it since before I came here. And I’ve been here twenty-two years.”

It came up from the stacks at eleven, on a cart: a gray archival box, and inside it, a row of old envelopes, brittle, soft at the corners, some of them labeled in a thin, slanting hand, some of them not labeled at all. I washed my hands, and the attendant reminded me to keep the papers in order. A woman at the desk kept half an eye on me, the way they keep it on everyone.

I went through them one at a time. Newspaper clippings, yellow and crumbling. A draft of something in Nicolay’s hand. Notes on the backs of White House cards. A letter from a woman in Ohio about her son. Receipts. A list of names I did not recognize.

And in the fourth envelope, folded in thirds, on a single sheet of good paper gone the color of weak tea, a letter.

I knew it before I had it unfolded. I knew it from the handwriting, which I had never once seen. It was the most beautiful hand I had ever looked at: even, flowing, perfectly clear, with long looping capitals, the kind of writing that was taught in the best schools and that hardly anyone had ever mastered. It looked like it had been written slowly. It looked like it had been written more than once.

It was dated at the top: *Washington, April 13th, 1865.*

It was not signed.



Mr. President,

I beg you will read this to the end, though it is not signed, for reasons you will understand.

There is a man in this city who means to take your life. His name is John Wilkes Booth, the actor. He lives at the National Hotel. On the evening of the 11th

inst., standing upon your lawn while you spoke, he said in my hearing that it was the last speech you would ever make. I believe he meant it as I believe I am writing this.

He does not mean you alone. He has asked, in my hearing, after the house of Mr. Seward, who lies ill, and after the rooms of the Vice President at the Kirkwood House. He has about him a large young man who has called himself both Wood and Paine; a German of Port Tobacco who drinks; a druggist's clerk; and a young man of Charles County, lately a soldier of the rebellion, lame in the left leg, who is much at his table and knows the roads of Southern Maryland.

I pray you will not go abroad in the evenings, nor to any public place, until these men are taken up. I pray you will think of what you said upon the 11th, and of how many of us wait to see it done. We cannot spare you, Sir. Not now.

I have no name that would carry weight with you. I am one of those you spoke of.

On the back, in a different hand, a clerk's hand, small and hurried, someone had written: *Anonymous. Warning. Filed.*

And in the left margin, beside the last line, small, drawn in the same ink as the letter, as if the pen had moved there by itself while the writer was thinking, there was a mark. A small star, the kind you draw without lifting the pen, crowded with some foreign letters.

I looked at it for a moment, the way you look at a doodle in the margin of anything. It seemed vaguely familiar, the way a lot of things do, and I did not give it a second thought. My eyes went back up to the middle of the letter, and stayed there.

A young man of Charles County, lately a soldier of the rebellion, lame in the left leg, who is much at his table and knows the roads of Southern Maryland.



I sat in the quiet room under the green lamp for a long time.

I had checked a hundred things for him. The inauguration, the surgeon, Point Lookout, the National, the flag, the speech, the salute. Every one of them had been in some book, somewhere, that anyone could read, and so every one of them had proved nothing, and I had said so, every time, and he had agreed

with me every time and seemed pleased. And there were the two I could not check at all, the thread and the sleeves, which proved nothing the other way.

This was not in any book. I checked, right there, quietly, on my phone, searching every phrase of it I could remember. *Lame in the left leg. Much at his table. Knows the roads.* Nothing. No historian had ever quoted it. No book on the assassination mentioned it. It had never been put online. It had sat in a box in the stacks of the Library of Congress, unrequested, for longer than the librarian had worked there.

Carrow came into my head, because I could not help it. A letter that matched his story word for word was exactly what a clever man would forge, and my client read every word of that story. But nobody had asked for this box in twenty-two years. Nobody could have put anything in it since the autumn. The docket on the back was in a different hand, and the ink had gone brown into the fibers the way ink does in a century and a half, not in a season.

Twenty-two years was not forever, either. He could have read it twenty-three years ago, and built the story around it. I had no way of knowing.

And it described him. Not the story. Him. The lame young man at Booth's table. It described him exactly as he had described himself, week after week, from a chair by a woodstove, and it had been written by the waiter he had told me about, in the hand he had told me about, on the night he had told me about, and filed and forgotten less than a day before the shot.

I thought of the man in the dining room of the National, bent over the headwaiter's desk by one lamp, writing it three times. I thought of the old man in the cardigan, standing on the pavement on Seventh Street in the dark, understanding it a hundred and sixty years too late.

I have no name that would carry weight with you. I am one of those you spoke of.

I read the last line again. My eyes had filled, and I held the letter out over the table, away from me, until they cleared. It was a hundred and sixty years old, and I was not going to be the one who put a mark on it.

I photographed it on my phone, front and back, with no flash, as the sign on the wall asked. Then I asked for a copy anyway, because I wanted one I could

hold. The librarian looked at the letter for a long moment when I brought it to the desk, and at me, and did not say anything, and made the copy herself.

I walked out of the Madison Building into the gray winter noon with the copy in a folder under my arm, and sat in my car on the street for a long time without starting it.

For four months I had been a doubter. It had been the one thing I was sure of. Every Thursday I had come to his house determined to find the lie, and I had never found it, and I had told myself that proved nothing, and it had not.

Sitting there in the car, I made myself say it, out loud, alone, to the steering wheel, the way I made myself say true things on paper.

“I don’t know what he is.”

It was not the same as believing him. I knew that. But it was the first time since that first Thursday that I had not been sure.

The Carpathia

The photocopy sat on the kitchen table all that evening, in its folder, and neither of us touched it.

Freda had seen it when she came in from school. She had asked, and I had told her, all of it: the envelope, the gray box nobody had asked for in twenty-two years, the handwriting, *lame in the left leg*. Freda had listened with her chin on her fist, the way she had listened as a little girl to stories at bedtime, and at the end she had said, “So he’s not lying.”

“I don’t know.”

“Mom.”

“I don’t know what he is,” I said. “That’s all I know. That’s the most I’ve ever known about him.”

Freda thought about that. “That’s kind of a lot,” she said, and went back to her chemistry, and her phone lay face up beside the book and buzzed twice, and she read both and laughed at one.



The payment came at eight o’clock.

I heard my phone go and looked at it and did not understand the number at first. Then I did. It was twenty thousand dollars. It was more than I had made in the whole of the year before. It was the car paid off, and the dentist, and a start on Freda’s college, if she went somewhere sensible. The note on the transfer said: *With our client’s thanks, at the close of the first part.*

The first part.

At a quarter to nine there was a knock at the door.

It was a courier, a young man in a reflective jacket with a motorcycle idling at the curb, holding out an envelope and a tablet for me to sign. I signed. He was gone before I had the door shut.

The envelope was heavy cream paper, the same as the first letter, months ago, on the night of the electric bill. *Aldine, Mercer and Voss*. Inside was a single card, smaller than a postcard. There was no letter with it, no typed note from the lawyers. Only the card, and on the card one line, written by hand, in ink.

It was the same old-fashioned hand that had written *Please ask him what he thinks of 1865* at the bottom of the first letter. I would have known it anywhere. Still, I went and got the first letter out of my file to be sure, and laid them side by side on the kitchen table under the light.

It was the same hand. But it was not the same. The letters were the same shapes, the same careful, schooled, slightly slanting shapes, but they wavered now. The long strokes had a tremor in them, a little shiver, like a line drawn on a moving train. The pen had stopped, here and there, and started again. Whoever had written this had written it slowly, and I thought it had cost him something.

Please ask him about the Carpathia.

"What's the Carpathia?" Freda said, from across the table.

I was already looking it up.

"A ship," I said. "It was a ship. In 1912." I read, and my voice went quieter. "It was the ship that came for the Titanic. It picked up the survivors from the lifeboats, in the morning. Seven hundred and five of them."

"The Titanic?" Freda put her pencil down. "Like, the Titanic?"

"Like the Titanic."

"Did he ever say anything about the Titanic?"

"No." I looked at the card. "He never said anything about it. Not once. Not in four months of Thursdays." I thought back, carefully, through every page of every transcript, all of it, the way I had been trained to. "He's never mentioned the Carpathia. Or 1912. Nothing about where he was that April."

Freda looked at the card, and at my face.

"Then how does the client know to ask?"

I did not answer. I sat at the kitchen table with the letter and the card side by side under the light, the steady hand and the shaking one, and the folder with the photocopy in it at my elbow, and I did not have an answer to that at all.



On Thursday there was a late snow, the last of the winter, probably. We had missed only two Thursdays in all that time, Thanksgiving and Christmas Eve. The gravel road was white at the edges, and the field beyond the house was white, and the old blue pickup had a clean cap of snow on its roof.

He had the kettle on. He had a fire going. He looked, I thought, tired, more tired than I had seen him, and I wondered for the first time how old he really was in this life, and whether anyone looked after him when I was not there.

The folder was in my bag. On the drive up I had decided that I would show him. That I would lay the photocopy on the table in front of him, the waiter's letter, *I am one of those you spoke of*, and watch his face while he read it, and that whatever his face did would tell me the thing I had not been able to decide in nineteen weeks.

I set out the recorders and said the date and the time. And then, because it was how every Thursday began, and because it was the client's question and I was being paid to ask it, I took the card out of my notebook first.

"The client sent a question," I said. "Monday night. By hand."

"Read it to me."

I read it.

"Please ask him about the Carpathia."



He did not move.

That was the first thing. He had been reaching for his tea, and his hand stopped, just short of the cup. After a moment it came down and rested on the arm of the chair, and did not move again. The pencil in his other hand stopped on the notepad. His face did not change at all, and that was the second thing,

because his face was always changing, always listening, always a little amused, and now it was entirely still, like a pond in the moment after the stone and before the rings.

I waited. Without meaning to, I counted, the way I had counted on the tape in the autumn. Eleven seconds, that first day, after 1865.

I got to forty.

Then, very slowly, he looked past me, over my shoulder, at the mantel. At the empty wooden frame with its polished glass, waiting.

"Say it again," he said.

"Please ask him about the Carpathia." I held up the card so he could see it. "It's in the same hand as the first letter. The one at the bottom that said 1865. But it's shakier. Like he's..." I stopped. I did not know what I had been going to say.

He looked at the card for a long time. At the handwriting. At the tremor in the long strokes.

"Ms. Barnett," he said. "Did I ever say that word to you? *Carpathia*. In any session. Even once, in passing?"

"No. I checked. Every transcript."

"I know you did." He was still looking at the card. "I have never said it to anyone. Not in this life. I have never written it down. I have never told a soul where I was in April of 1912." He said it very quietly, almost wonderingly, as if he were checking it against his own memory as he spoke. "Not one living person."

The fire ticked in the stove. Outside, the snow had started again, very fine, drifting past the window without seeming to fall.

"Then how does he know?" I said.

He did not answer me. He sat in his chair by the woodstove, an old man in a cardigan buttoned wrong by one button, and looked at the empty frame on the mantel, and for the first time since I had known him, he looked like a man who did not know something.

The folder with the photocopy in it sat in my bag on the floor by my chair, six feet from the notepad on his knee. I did not take it out. I found that I could not. Not today. Not on top of this.

On the notepad, without looking down, his pencil had begun to move again. Going over something already drawn. Around, and around, and around.

“Tell your client,” he said at last, and stopped, and began again. “Tell your client yes.”

“Yes, you’ll tell him?”

“Yes,” he said. “I was there.” He turned from the mantel and looked at me, and something had come back into his face, something sharp and awake that I had not seen in it since the day he told me about the dress circle at Ford’s. “Next Thursday, Ms. Barnett. And bring a warmer coat.”

“Why?”

“Because it is very cold,” he said, “in the North Atlantic, in April.”



End of Book One

Facts

Lincoln stood on the parapet at Fort Stevens in July 1864, the only sitting President ever to come under enemy fire in battle.

Booth's first plan was to kidnap Lincoln, not kill him, and trade him for Confederate prisoners. The attempt on March 17, 1865 failed because Lincoln changed his plans that afternoon and never came down the road.

On April 10, the morning after Appomattox, Lincoln asked a crowd at the White House for "Dixie," and told them the Attorney General had ruled it a lawful prize.

On April 11 he spoke from a window about giving the vote to Black men, "the very intelligent, and on those who serve our cause as soldiers." Booth was standing below, and is recorded as saying it would be the last speech he ever made.

On April 14 Booth rode a bay mare with a white star from Pumphrey's stable, and was warned she would break her halter if left alone.

That same afternoon Mrs. Surratt drove to her tavern with a package from Booth that held field glasses.

Booth left his card at the Kirkwood House for Andrew Johnson: "Don't wish to disturb you. Are you at home?"

He handed a letter to the actor John Mathews to give to the newspapers. Mathews read it and burned it.

The Grants left town that afternoon. On the way to the train, a horseman galloped past their carriage and stared in. Grant later learned it was Booth.

The President's guard, John Parker, was away from his post. Booth timed his shot to a laugh line in the third act.

Lewis Powell got into Secretary Seward's house by claiming to bring medicine from his doctor, beat Frederick Seward with a revolver that misfired, and ran into the street shouting "I'm mad! I'm mad!" All five men he hurt that night lived.

George Atzerodt took a room at the Kirkwood House, where the Vice President was staying, drank in the bar, and never went upstairs.

Lincoln was laid diagonally across a bed too short for him in the Petersen house, and died there at twenty-two minutes past seven the next morning.

Thomas Jones hid Booth in the woods for days and brought him the newspapers.

Booth was shot in a burning tobacco barn on the Garrett farm. At the end he asked to see his hands and said "Useless, useless."

Three nights after the shooting, while detectives were in Mrs. Surratt's boarding house, Powell turned up at her door carrying a pickaxe. She said "Before God, sir, I do not know this man."

Louis Weichmann and John Lloyd both testified against her at the trial. President Johnson said he never saw the plea for mercy for Mrs. Surratt. She was hanged on July 7.

John Surratt gave a public lecture about the plot in Rockville, Maryland, in December 1870.

Lincoln received a great many warning letters. He said he had eighty of them, and kept them in an envelope marked *Assassination*.